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Riders to the Sea

J. M. Synge

Title Significance

A title is always very significant in dramatic literature as it plays a conspicuous role to give a suggestive hint about the theme of the story or play. 'Riders to the Sea' literally means people venturing out into the sea. In this play, *Riders to the Sea* the life of the Aran Islanders is represented through one family. The death of all its male members shows how the sea acts as an

agent of fate. The title *Riders to the Sea* is so appealing because at the very outset it hints that it is a story of a group of peasants and fishermen who are professional riders, living at the coastal region of the **Bay of Galway** and the key word 'riders' is metaphorically used by the playwright to refer to those people who move on the sea in their struggle for existence, and thereby, hinting at the **eternal conflict between man and necessity**. The title is, therefore, used in a highly dramatic sense and the experience out of which the author drew the word 'riders' is based on reality.

The title "*Riders to the sea*" is the most **significant and symbolic to the thematic journey**. The main theme of the play, *Riders to the Sea* is the **conflict between man and the sea**. The title is very attractive and thought-provoking. The readers are curious to know who the riders are and what is going to be their journey to the sea. The two riders Bartley and Michael represent the whole riders of the peasant families of Aran Islanders. The **sea sustains these people; it also swallows all the earning members of Maurya family** as Synge suggests the cruelty of the sea and human helplessness before its omnipotent power. Synge's choice of title is the superb brainwork of his genius.

Implicitly, the title brings out symbolically the bread earners and the adverse worldly force, though **mother's stoical resignation to the will of God** in conclusion focuses the human riders and superior force to the elemental fate and therefore, the sea cannot ultimately keep the native grandeur of human mind suppressed. Synge's title is thus quite precise and suggestive.

The title of this great play is also an **allusion to the Book of Exodus from the Bible**, which says: "The horse and his rider hath he thrown into the sea." Clearly, the title therefore relates to the death of Maurya's sons and the way that the sea has been the reason for all of their deaths. This **allusion also represents the theme of fate or destiny**, as Maurya seems fated to lose all her sons to the sea, whatever she tries to do to stop this from happening.

Central Idea

Riders to the Sea **revolves around the idea of inexorability of fate**. That is, fate is inevitable, and there is nothing humans can do to stop it. At the beginning of the play, the matriarch of the family, Maurya, hopes she can save her last remaining son from drowning in the sea as all of her other sons and her husband have done. Despite her efforts to stop him, her last son goes to the sea and drowns. Maurya, though bereft, now knows that there is nothing left for the sea to take from her. A **related theme is the powerlessness of humans**, including religious figures, to combat the power of nature and of fate. Even the priest in the village cannot stop the sea from claiming Maurya's sons and husband. **Religion is powerless in the face of nature and fate.**

Themes

Man's Constant Struggle for Survival: *Riders to the Sea*, is the stage craft of not only Maurya's family, but it can happen to any family on the island, where **young people still endanger their lives to fulfill the 'primitive necessities' of earthly existence**. The setting of the story might be the Aran Island yet its **appeal is universal**. The main reason of the loss of male people on the Island is utilitarian one, as the young people earn their livelihood by catching fish from the sea

and sometimes, they cross the sea, to visit the mainland for the business purpose. Even the storms in the sea, cannot stop them doing their duty as is evident from Cathleen's remarks in, *Riders to the Sea*; "It's the life of a young man to be going on the sea..."

Female Loneliness and Helplessness: Synge's description of the life of the people on Island tells us that, "the men were in constant danger of being destroyed by the sea and thus of leaving the women to suffer the loss of the bread winner." Women on these lands, who "live only for their children" are the passive sufferers. Synge says, "The maternal feeling is so powerful on these islands that it gives a life of torment to the women. Their sons grow up to be banished as soon as they are of age, or to live here in continual danger on the sea; their daughters go away also, or are worn out in their youth with bearing children that grow up to hands them in their own then a little later." So, how much piteous the situation is where the females, when, are child, lose their fathers and brothers and when youth comes and they get married, are left alone by husbands and later children. Thus, on the Island, this is the continuous drama of female's isolation, which is hallmark in Synge's *Riders of the Sea*.

Theme of Enlightenment through Sufferings: Deep analysis of the play, *Riders to the Sea*, suggests us that the central theme signifies man's struggle with sea, where it is the sea, which victories over the human being, but only at the surface level. A profound study of the climax of the drama, conveys us that in spite of enduring unbelievable suffering, Maurya stands as a superhuman, who challenges the sea in following words, ".... there isn't anything more the sea can do to me...". Her stoic acceptance finally lifts her from an ordinary human being to a person with outstanding features.

Religion, Superstition, and Nature: The strongest theme in *Riders to the Sea* is the conflict between religion, superstition, and nature. On the surface, Maurya and her family are devout Catholics. The most important thing to Maurya is the return of Michael's body so he can have a proper Catholic funeral. When Bartley's body is returned, she blesses it with holy water. Throughout the play, the characters pray to God and ask for blessings. Everyone views the young Catholic priest as a prominent community leader. Under that religious surface, however, it becomes clear that Maurya, and perhaps the community at large, no longer trust in God's control. After first glance, the family's religious comments—such as "God help us," "[t]he blessing of God on you," or "God spare us"—seem mechanical rather than reverential, suggesting they have lost their meaning as prayers.

The Power of Nature: Nature's power is thematically important throughout the play in that the sea isn't a neutral entity. The men are forced to make a living by working on the sea, yet everybody seems to know that the sea is going to eventually take any person's life who earns their living in this way. The storm also indicates to readers that nature's power is to be respected. Maurya assumes that Bartley won't go to sea because the storm is too powerful for the men to venture out that day. Tragically, Bartley does go to sea, is thrown into the waves, and is killed. Maurya seems to come to a kind of truce with the sea in the end; it has now taken all the men in

her life from her, and thus its power over her is neutralized. She reflects, "They're all gone now, and there isn't anything more the sea can do to me."

Sea: As a Villain/Protgonist: Conflict is the essence of every tragedy. As T.R. Henn Says, "Of this archetypal nature is the conflict of man with the Sea, the giver and taker of life. The Islandmen must be constantly aware of its menace, its moods, its protection...." it is quite ironic that man is fully aware of the temperaments of the sea, but the sea is quite indifferent to man. In Riders to the Sea the sea is personified as a villain, who leads to all the disasters and misfortunes, in the play, thus not only a main actor but comes as a chief agent in the action. The sea is destroyer as well as sustainer so it is her right to call back all the persons, who are given life by her. It does not have pity on poor Maurya, who was sometimes a mother of "six fine men", in the end laments. "...I've had a husband, six fine men, though it was a hard birth I had with every one of them and they coming to the world—and some of them were found and some of them were not found, but they're gone now the lot of them...." So, we see that the most active character in the play is the sea and it is not exaggerated to say that sea is the protagonist of the play, which is impersonal and devoid of human attributes.

Mortality: The theme of mortality is present throughout Riders to the Sea, as evidenced by both the death of Bartley and the death of Michael. Death is always on the minds of the characters within the play. From the very beginning, Cathleen and Nora discuss the bundle of clothing that represents all that is left of their brother Michael, and the two girls even resort to hiding the evidence from their mother in order to protect her fragile mental state. Their attempts are not met with success, as Maurya realizes that conditions at sea are awful and recognizes the clothes as belonging to Michael. When Bartley leaves, Maurya becomes convinced that he, too, will now die, and in this she is proven correct. In the play's final lines, Maurya expresses her acceptance of morality by stating that "No man at all can be living forever, and we must be satisfied."

Fate: It seems the men that exist within this play's world are all fated to die at the hands of the sea. The men are forced to make a living from the sea, yet it appears that their work ensures certain death at some point. To illustrate this, all of the men in Maurya's have died from a life on the sea. This is the reason why she tries to convince Bartley not to go to sea in the first place. The eventual fated death of Bartley is hinted at so much in the text that, when Bartley's death eventually comes, it isn't particularly shocking to readers or audience members. We have heard characters talk about it, and we have even seen it symbolically shown to us through the white coffin boards and the rope that Bartley makes into a noose-like halter. Maurya's words after Bartley's departure are an overt indication of the theme of fate and humanity's powerlessness against it: "He's gone now, God spare us, and we'll not see him again." Having already lost all her other sons to the sea, Maurya accepts what she believes to be Bartley's inescapable fate.

Summary

In Riders to the Sea, death is depicted as a sense and an inevitable part of life. The play starts with Maurya's daughters Cathleen and Nora speculating about their brother Michael. Although

they don't have proof yet, the sisters' sense that the drowned person is their brother Michael. A young priest is bringing the clothes from the drowned man, and she and Nora sense that the clothes belong to Michael. Arguably, Maurya also senses that Michael is the drowned man, which is why she is lying down and "speaking querulously." She is uneasy and preparing herself for the tragic news. Concerning her living son Bartley, Maurya senses that he will die if he goes on his trip to sell horses. This is why she tells him, "It's hard set we'll be surely the day you're drown'd with the rest." **Bartley doesn't heed his mother's premonitions**, so Maurya calls him a "hard and cruel man" for not listening to her. Later, Maurya's forebodings give her scary visions about Michael and Bartley. The apparitions reinforce her sixth sense.

By the end, Bartley has died, and **Maurya makes peace with her fate**. Death is depicted as an unavoidable fact of life. Maurya doesn't bemoan her lot. Instead, she thanks "the Grace of the Almighty God" for giving Michael a "clean burial" at sea and granting her the ability to supply Bartley with a nice coffin. Death is shown as something that should be accepted. Maurya's final words are, "No man at all can be living forever, and we must be satisfied."

Symbols of Death

Throughout the play, Synge presents **multiple omens and symbols signifying death**, which foreshadow Bartley's fatal accident and remind the rest of the characters of their own mortality. The **white boards** that Maurya bought for Michael's coffin are onstage during the entire play, strongly implying that there will be at least one death. Maurya refers to these boards often, which makes clear that death weighs constantly and heavily on the minds of the characters.

Bartley's death is also foreshadowed by the **rope he uses to make a halter for his horse**. The rope bears resemblance to a noose, an instrument of execution, and it is also associated with death through Maurya's statement that they might need the rope to lower Michael's body into a grave. Additionally, the belongings of the dead have a strong pull on the living, which is particularly apparent in how Michael's belongings affect Bartley and Maurya. Maurya is holding Michael's walking stick when **she sees his ghost riding behind Bartley**, and Bartley wears Michael's shirt when he is thrown into the sea. It seems that the dead want the living to join them, and Maurya seems to believe that death will also be her fate, saying that all of her men are together now and that she will soon be with them.

In light of all of these omens, it's not surprising that Maurya predicts Bartley's death. Throughout the play, she believes that it is his **fate to die in the sea** just as it was the fate of her other sons and her husband. However, she still desires to save him from this fate, even while believing that she is powerless to help him. Maurya attempts to persuade Bartley not to go to the sea by telling him outright that he will die. She says, "It's hard set we'll be surely the day you're drown'd with the rest," and she tries various strategies to keep him home, including telling him not to take the rope that he needs to halter his horse. Despite her efforts to keep him home, she seems to know that his death is inevitable, since she continues to claim that Bartley will die until his body is finally brought into the house.

Bartley's death is shown to be part of a pattern of deaths in Maurya's family. All the men have died in the sea, and thus Bartley's eventual death in the same manner was inevitable. It is the

fate of the young men in the community to go on the sea, since they must make a living for their families, despite that their lives are at risk each time they go out. Bartley thus had no choice, despite his mother's pleading; he had to go to sea and eventually die like his fathers and brother in order to keep his family alive. Bartley's death is foreshadowed to such an extent that it is not necessarily a surprise when he dies, but rather the culmination of the pattern of death that has afflicted the family. With Bartley gone, Maurya achieves a weary calm, delivering the last line of the play, *"No man at all can be living forever, and we must be satisfied."* Thus, the play acknowledges that fate cannot be avoided—it is every character's fate to die, not only the men.

Maurya now feels free from the shackles of the worries she has endured for so long. She calmly prays for all the male members of her family; from her father to her children. Calmly and confidently Maurya tells her daughter, Nora, to pray not only for her family members but also for those who have preceded them. She also says that with the permission and grace of God, Michael has also been buried well by using white coffin. Now Maurya understands and realizes that death is a universal event and everyone will surely die; for that the death of a person is not a catastrophe to those left behind. No one can live forever and everyone should be able to accept this. The findings indicate that Synge's *Riders to the Sea*, as the representative of literary works, contains points of discussion always existing in society. **Suffering, supernaturalism and death are inseparable from the life of society**, giving at the same time an illustration that literary work is universal or nuances of universality are always there in literature.

The twelve-pound look

J. M. Barrie

He is rated as the **foremost English dramatist of the day and his plays**, taken together, make the most significant contribution to English drama since Sheridan. Practically his entire life has been given to the writing of the novels and plays, many of the later having their heroines conceived especially for Maude Adams, one of the America's greatest actresses. He was born in Kirriemuir Scotland in 1860. He received his education at Dumfries and Edinburgh university. His first work in journalism and letters was done at Nottingham, but soon he took up his work in London where he now resides. Sir **James M Barrie's literary labors have been very fruitful**. The professors love story, *The Little Minister*, *Quality street*, *What Every Woman Knows* are well known to everyone.

Title Significance

The title "The Twelve Pound Look" is significant because it refers to a scene in the play where the character of Sir Harry Sims is admiring himself in a mirror, practicing his "twelve-pound look" which is the expression he uses when he is dealing with his wealthy clients.

The title of the play, "The Twelve-Pound Look," refers to the price Harry pays for a portrait of himself that he commissioned to be painted. **The title is significant because it represents Harry's obsession with his own image and his belief that his wealth and status are what make him important**. The cost of the portrait is not only a monetary value, but it also represents the weight and importance Harry places on his appearance and social status. However, as the play

progresses, it becomes clear that Harry's obsession with his image is hollow, and his true worth as a human being is not determined by his wealth or status. Ultimately, the title serves as a commentary on the superficiality of social status and the importance of inner worth and self-respect.

The title also refers to a woman's calculation of the amount of money she would need to save in order to leave a stifling marriage and strike out on her own. Furthermore, the title can also be interpreted as a commentary on the societal expectations placed on women during the time period in which the play is set. The character of Kate is a successful woman who has achieved financial independence, but she is still expected to conform to traditional gender roles and to be subservient to her husband. The title therefore suggests that despite Harry's achievements, her value in the eyes of society is still determined by her husband's status and the amount of money he paid for his knighthood.

Overall, the title "The Twelve Pound Look" is significant because it highlights the themes of societal expectations, the commodification of worth, and the ironic nature of social status.

Summary

Harry Sims is a successful businessman, He's practicing the kneeling, scraping and backward exiting that will be required of him on the great day, and his apparently adoring wife is helping out with the rehearsal, standing — or rather sitting — in for the officiating monarch. A professional typist has been sent for, to handle the thank-you notes that the almost Sir Harry is sending to his multitude of well-wishers. When she arrives, she proves to be briskly efficient, with an impressive keyboard speed and an even more impressive ability to guess in advance what the letters will say. She seems to be a figure from Harry's past.

Harry, on hearing about the arrival of typewriter sends his wife downstairs so she can *"tell her the sort of things"* about him as *"he prefers to keep a wife in the house for that purpose"*. After some time, he confronts the lady himself. Once recovered from his initial shock, he alternates between sneering at her and upbraiding her, professing pity at the life, so materially and spiritually impoverished, that he fancies she must be leading, and contrasting it with his own existence, surrounded by the wealthy and powerful and rising steadily through their ranks. She hits him where it hurts by remarking on how boring his social circle must be, how paranoically preoccupied with who's in and who's out. Gently but firmly, she demolishes all his preconceptions, especially the ones about her. She even has some compassion for him, though not as much as she has for his wife, and the future wives of the two boys she learns he has fathered.

Plot

There is the **Plot** of the play "Twelve Pounds Look". The play starts with Harry Sims who is practicing for receiving the title of a knight with his wife Lady Sims. He is a proud man and favors honor on the other hand his wife is a beautiful, illiterate and naïve lady who fears his husband.

After their practice, Harry instructs Lady Sims about the person who was about to come to answer letters. Kate, a simple and intelligent lady came as a type-writer and Lady Sims who was impressed by her personality instruct according to his husband.

After the arrival of his Harry, it reveals that Kate was his former wife and left him to be an independent person by creating a misunderstanding in his mind. Then Kate clears all the misunderstanding and tells him about her success, criticize him and inform him about his price in her eyes. She also reveals about the mental condition about his current wife which proves to be true at the end of the play when she questions about the price of the type-writer.

Characters

Here is the **character analysis** of "Twelve Pounds Look". An interesting feature of J.M. Barrie is the complexity of character. His characters are often designed to be multidimensional with complex desires and motivation. He tends to explore the inner lives of his characters, layering their traits and showing how their experience and past shape their actions and personalities. Such is the case with most of the characters of this play that often give an impression of being one-dimensional, but an in-depth analysis indicates otherwise.

"The Twelve-Pound Look" is a one-act play written by J.M. Barrie. The play centers around the character Harry Sims, a wealthy businessman, and his interactions with his wife, Kate, and his new typist, Miss Jones. A minor actor is Harry' Butler Tombes.

Harry Sims: The play begins with the introduction of Harry Sims, the *major protagonist* of the story, a successful businessman and a typical member of the British upper-class, who is to receive the honor of knighthood in a few days. He's seen busy rehearsing the ceremony with his wife, practicing the kneeling, scraping and backward exiting that will be required of him on the great day, and his apparently adoring wife is helping out with the rehearsal, standing — or rather sitting — in for the officiating monarch. He is initially presented as a confident and arrogant man who believes he has complete control over his wife and his household. However, as the play progresses and he ends up with a tense encounter with his ex-wife Kate, it becomes clear that Harry is deeply insecure and harbors a fear of losing his social status and authority. He is shocked to learn that his wife has become more self-sufficient and independent during their separation, and he struggles to maintain his composure when confronted with the reality of his own limitations. Ultimately, Harry is a complex character who represents the traditional gender roles and societal expectations of his time, and the play highlights the changing roles and expectations of men and women in society.

The majority of the plot rotates around him, as the writer tends to use him as typical representation of a patriarch, using his title and wealth to reaffirm himself as he even said: "I'll tell you; I'll be worth a million yet" Initially shown as a man of pride and honor, the writer soon exposes the actual dark, stubborn personality of a seemingly noble man thus, making him a round character with complex inner life.

He is also a **static character** who doesn't undergo any significant change, though the glimpses of **insecurity** that we see at the falling-action may depict otherwise but, this fear is the one he harbored since the elopement of his ex-wife, whereas his egoistic nature stays the same till the very end. **He brazenly claims to know his wife when he actually doesn't.** "I suppose I know my wife."

Another element of his personality is the increasing *superiority complex* that drives him to undermine the value of women even though ironically, he is secretly much affected by his ex-wife's status. His character is explained using both direct and indirect characterization, where the writer explicitly portrays that the only driving force for him is his title and success without which **he is nothing but a clump of insecurity that grows on the discouragement of women's significance in the society.** "One's religion is whatever he is most interested in, and yours is Success." Overall, his character covered the themes of patriarchy, insecurities, lethal success, aristocracy and superiority complex.

Kate: The second major character is Kate, Harry's ex-wife, **who has separated from him for 15 years ago to pursue her own interests and self-improvement.** She is a strong and independent woman who has gained confidence and knowledge during her separation from her husband. She was one of the **female employees of The Flora Typewriting Agency** and was summoned to write thank you letter on the behalf of Harry Sims. She is a more multidimensional character that may not seem one superficially.

Being a **round character**, as an empowered woman completely opposite to lady Sims, many of her traits are defined and described through direct and indirect characterization, where the narrator introduces her as: "She is a mere typist, dressed in uncommonly good taste, but at contemptibly small expense, and she is carrying her typewriter in a friendly way rather than as a badge of slavery, as of course it is. Her eye is clear; and in odd contrast to LADY SIMS, she is self-reliant and serene."

She is a career-oriented woman trying to free herself from the shackles of patriarchy, where her personality is much relatable as she sympathizes with her husband who as a patriarchal man fearing the existence of an empowered woman. "Harry; I was even sorry for you, for I saw that you couldn't help yourself."

There are **two points of notable confusion here.** First, classifying her as *a static character*. on the outer edge, she seems like a dynamic character, as a woman that went through a major character development from being the wife of Harry Sims to an independent typist, but this was a part of her past she was introduced in the play as an already established woman until the very end what we are able to see is the same resolute career-oriented woman, **who took pride in the "eight Shillings" that she earned, not being intimidated by her husband,** which makes her a static character.

The second point of contemplation arises when we are posed with a question, whether she is a protagonist or an antagonist. Now to understand this concept, we need to break down the

character sketch into pieces. On one hand, we know that this play primarily focuses on Kate's growth, **she is someone who represents the struggle for empowerment that women faced in 20th century, as she challenges the traditional patriarchy and drives the plot. Thus, we end up naming her the protagonist.** While on the other hand in this attempt she also asserts herself in the face of her husband's arrogance, opposing his views and beliefs. *"Success is a fatal gift."*

Here we need to keep two things in mind, first Sir Harry Sims is the first major protagonist that instigates the play and secondly, **the character of Kate and Lady Sims revolves and branches out of his character.** Thus, when a derived character like Kate, having goals and motivation in conflict of first major protagonist, serves as an obstacle to his desires of strong hold over women she ends up becoming an antagonist. **Hence, Kate can be both a protagonist and an antagonist where she is a protagonist in context of the play and an antagonist in context of Harry Sims.**

All in all, her character identifies with the themes of feminism, self-reliance, challenging the patriarchal spirit, financial independence and contentment. *"LADY SIMS has a maid for buttoning and unbuttoning her, and probably another for waiting on the maid, and she gazes with a little envy perhaps at a woman who does things for herself."*

Kate represents a departure from traditional gender roles and societal expectations of women in her time, and her character is a symbol of the changing attitudes towards women's roles in society.

Lady Sims: Another important character is that of **Lady Sims** (also known as Emmy). She *is the wife of Harry sim, a good-natured woman. At the beginning of the play she is seen wearing her presentation gown, and personating the august one who is about to dub her Harry knight.* Initially **shown helping her husband in his practice Lady Sims soon gets shunned by him.** Later on, she becomes perplexed by Kate's self-reliance which leaves a deep impression on her.

She is neither a major character (as her actions are not driving the plot), nor a minor character (as she is significant enough to contribute to the overall message of the play and different themes). She is a **secondary character that accentuates the support and influence of the main characters Harry and Kate.**

She is a **round character** where her personality is described through both direct and indirect characterization. Initially shown as a contented woman, believing that her husband is an honorable man who provides her life of luxury, **she serves as an exact representation of the privilege of a class and status of women** that was influenced by patriarchal men. However, as the play progresses her characters turn out to be flawed, having a submissive nature perspective on life, and inferiority complex in face of Kate's abilities.

"As a first impression she rather likes the woman, and the woman, though it is scarcely worth mentioning, rather likes her. LADY SIMS has a maid for buttoning and unbuttoning her, and probably another for waiting on the maid, and she gazes with a little envy perhaps at a woman who does things for herself."

She is a slightly dynamic character as well, where we see a transition from her being a delusional, dependent rich wife to a slightly inspired one - as her final question to her husband about the cost of typewriter shows the glimpses of her stepping towards desiring independence and breaking free from the limitations of privileged yet restricted life.

"LADY SIMS. [Dutifully.] I'm sorry; I'll go, Harry. [Inconsequentially.] Are they very expensive?"

SIR HARRY. What?"

LADY SIMS. Those machines?"

Overall, she represents the themes of effects of patriarchy, typical gender roles, social class, and self-worth.

Tombes: The only minor character of the story is Tombes, a flat character having little time in play with few traits exposition, all of which remain same till his last scene making him a static character.

He appears in the rising action as the butler in Sir Harry's household and is depicted as a servant who is dedicated to his job and respectful of his employer's social status. Throughout the play, Tombes is shown to be polite, well-mannered, and obedient to Sir Harry's commands. A representation of the era's conventional servants keenly aware of the social hierarchy and is quick to defer to his employer's wishes and holds pleasure in pleasing his master as he shows contentment with calling Harry "Sir". *"Beg pardon, sir, but it is such a satisfaction to us"*

Overall, the characters in "The Twelve-Pound Look" are used to explore themes of gender roles, societal expectations, and the changing roles of men and women in society. The play highlights the struggles and insecurities of men who have been conditioned to believe they have complete control over their wives and households, as well as the empowerment and independence of women who are challenging these traditional roles and expectations

Themes

Success: "The Twelve Pound Look" by J.M. Barrie is a play that explores the theme of success in a satirical manner. The play revolves around Harry Sims, a successful businessman who is *to receive the honor of knighthood in a few days*. Harry is a man who is obsessed with success and the trappings of wealth. However, Harry is not content with just financial success; he also desires social status and prestige.

The play's central conflict arises when Harry's wife, who he left many years ago to pursue his career, returns to him. She has become a successful writer and is now financially independent. This threatens Harry's sense of superiority and success, as he feels that he must remain in control and dominant over his wife.

Throughout the play, Barrie uses humor and satire to critique the idea that success is measured solely by financial wealth and social status. The play suggests that true success is not found in material possessions or societal position, but rather in personal growth, integrity, and happiness.

In the end, Harry's obsession with success is revealed to be hollow and empty. His wife, who has found success on her own terms, is the true victor. The play suggests that success should not be measured by external factors such as money or status, but rather by personal fulfillment and happiness.

Gender Roles: Another aspect of the theme of success in "The Twelve Pound Look" is the idea of gender roles and expectations. The play was written in the early 1900s, a time when women's roles in society were changing. Harry's wife, who has become a successful writer, represents a new type of woman who is breaking free from traditional gender roles.

Harry, on the other hand, represents the old-fashioned view of a successful man who is dominant and in control. His obsession with success is tied to his need to maintain this traditional gender role and his fear of being emasculated by his wife's success.

Through the character of Kate, Harry's wife, the play challenges traditional gender roles and suggests that women can achieve success and independence. However, the play also suggests that men can be threatened by women's success, as it challenges their traditional role as the breadwinner and head of the household.

Overall, "The Twelve Pound Look" explores the theme of success through the lens of gender roles and societal expectations. It suggests that success should not be defined solely by financial wealth or social status, but also by personal fulfillment and the ability to break free from traditional gender roles.

Feminism: The Twelve-Pound Look' is interesting because it advocates feminism and women's financial independence, at a time when most 'feminist' plays and stories were more interested in lampooning the women's suffrage movement. Barrie wrote 'The Twelve-Pound Look' in 1892, when Englishwomen were still getting arrested (and ridiculed) for seeking the right to vote. This film version was released in 1920, shortly after women in Britain received the vote at long last.

'The Twelve-Pound Look' is also interesting for another reason, because it depicts the effect of the typewriter upon society, and how this machine helped women gain financial independence. When originally invented, the 'typewriting machine' was intended for men only. The word 'typewriter' referred to the machine's operator, not the mechanism itself, and all 'typewriters' were men ... because the machines were only used in office situations, and respectable women did not work in offices. Eventually someone discovered that long narrow female digits were better suited to a typing keyboard than stubby male fingers, and gradually women were employed as typists ... in many cases, getting their first chance to earn wages and participate in a workplace.

Kate's marriage, when becomes extremely unbearable, led to her scraping together £12 to buy a typewriter, so that she can leave her husband and earn a living as a typist. Years pass. Harry Sims divorces Kate, but she earns a respectable living and learns self-reliance.

Patriarchal society: "The Twelve Pound Look" is a play by J.M. Barrie that was first performed in 1910. The play explores the theme of patriarchal society through the character of Harry Sims, a successful businessman who believes that he has complete control over his wife, Kate.

Harry's belief in his own superiority and his entitlement to control Kate's life is a clear example of the patriarchal attitudes that were prevalent in early 20th-century society. He views Kate as a possession rather than a partner, and he treats her with condescension and disrespect.

"SIR HARRY: I flatter myself that whatever I say, Lady Sims will accept without comment.

[She smiles, heaven knows why, unless her next remark explains it.

KATE: Still the same Harry."

Kate, on the other hand, begins to question the assumptions that underlie Harry's behavior. She realizes that she has been living in a state of subservience, and she rejects this role in favor of a more independent and self-assertive identity.

"Kate: So, I didn't give you up willingly, Harry. I invented all sorts of theories to explain you. Your hardness--I said it was a fine want of mawkishness. Your coarseness--I said it goes with strength. Your contempt for the weak-- I called it virility. You want of ideals was clear-sightedness. Your ignoble views of women--I tried to think them funny".

Through Kate's journey, Barrie shows that the patriarchal attitudes that were common in his time were not only unjust, but also harmful to both men and women. By challenging these attitudes, Kate is able to reclaim her dignity and assert her own agency, while Harry is forced to confront the limitations of his own worldview.

In conclusion, "The Twelve Pound Look" offers a powerful critique of patriarchal society, showing how it perpetuates inequality and stifles individual growth and development. Through its exploration of gender roles and power dynamics, the play remains relevant to contemporary discussions about gender and identity.

Women and Identity: Originally staged in 1910, The Twelve-Pound Look is a surprisingly modern examination of women's identity and place in society, challenging traditional patriarchal ideas with a light touch. Still set in the Edwardian period, the story focuses on Harry Sims who is excitedly looking forward to his impending knighthood for services rendered, supported by his wife, Emmy. He is full of preening self-importance until the arrival of a freelance typist to write up his correspondence. She turns out to be his first wife, Kate, who suddenly and mysteriously "bolted" years before. As the truth of her departure emerges, Harry's sense of his own superiority and his belief that he understands women is steadily crushed. Kate's independent life throws into question Harry's, and society's, concepts of success and how we judge human worth.

Independence: Since leaving her husband, Kate has to support her life. That is why she decided to have a job. She is described as a typist. She is glad to do her job and is very proud of her being a typist. It can be seen from the way she carries the typewriter. She thinks being a typist is not reflection of slavery but power to stand on the dignity as human being.

[These sentiments carry him off light-heartedly, and presently the disturbing element is shown in. She is a mere typist, dressed in uncommonly good taste, but at contemptibly small expense, and

she is carrying her typewriter in a friendly way rather than as a badge of slavery, as of course it is. Her eye is clear; and in odd contrast to LADY SIMS, she is self-reliant and serene.)

From the quotation above, it can be seen that Kate considers about her appearance although it seems cheap in Sir Harry Sims and Lady Sims' point of view. It is also described that Kate has clear eyes and is independent. Her self-reliance or independence can be seen from the way she works for her life. She supports her life without relying on someone else as Sir Harry Sims' new wife, Lady Sims, does.

In conclusion, "The Twelve-Pound Look" is a powerful exploration of the themes of feminism, power, control, self-worth, education, and the nature of marriage and relationships. Through its portrayal of strong female characters who refuse to be defined by societal expectations, the play challenges traditional gender roles and highlights the struggle of women to achieve equality in a male-dominated society.

Literary Devices

"The Twelve Pound Look" is a one-act play by J.M. Barrie. The play uses literary devices to create meaning and enhance its impact on the audience. Here are some examples of literary devices used in "The Twelve Pound Look" with textual references:

Irony is a situation in which there is a contrast between expectation and reality. The play "Twelve Pound Look" is filled with **irony**. For instance, the title "Twelve Pound Look" is ironic because it refers to the value of Harry in the eye of his ex-wife. As Harry has become a knight, has high status in society and is respected and envied by all, but in the eye of his ex-wife his worth is only Twelve pound which she gathered and left him. As from the textual reference when Harry asked Kate about his worth, she replied;

Harry: *I tell you I am worth a quarter of a million.*

Kate: *That is what you are worth to yourself. I'll tell you what you are worth to me: exactly twelve pounds. For I made up my mind that I could lunch myself on the world alone if I first prove my mettle by earning twelve pounds; and as soon as I had earned it I left you.*

Harry is a dignified, proud and attention gaining person. He cares for honour and used to get compliments from others. But when Kate came to reply for Harry's letter, Lady Sims described his character ironically. As from the text she said;

Lady Sims: *I should explain that my husband is not a man who cares for honours. So long as he does his duty.*

There is also an ironic statement of Harry Sims against his wife that she is satisfied with her married life. As he said to Kate according to the text;

Harry: *I'll thank you if ever there was a woman proud of her husband and happy in her married life, that woman is Lady Sims.*

But in contrast Lady Sims was afraid of her Husband as described earlier in the play. "She must be an extraordinary proud and happy woman, yet she has a drawn face and shrinking ways as if there were some one near her of whom she is afraid." Also, she dares not enter the room without his husband's permission as in the text;

[There is a timid knock at the door.]

Lady Sims: May I come in?

Harry: It is Lady Sims.

Kate: I won't tell. She is afraid to come into her husband's room without knocking!

And also, there was a twelve-pound look in lady Sims' eyes as described by Kate. So, Harry's statement that **Lady Sims is happy and proud of her married life is a prominent irony.**

There is also **irony of situation** in the play, where the audience knows more than the characters do. For example, the audience knows that Harry's wife has become successful and wealthy, while he still believes she is the same person he left years ago.

We can also sense the **presence of humor in this play.** As we can see the foolish and naive Harry whose foolishness creates humor. For Example; Kate told him about the selfishness of his friends by using the literal word "fate" which he really thought as fate. As from the textual reference;

Kate: How you beamed at me when I sat at the head of your fat dinner in my fat jewellery, surrounded by our fat friends.

Harry: They weren't so fat.

Symbolism is used in this play to convey meaning and to create a deeper level of understanding. For example, the **"Twelve Pounds"** represents the value and worth of a person i.e Harry Sims. Also, **the type-writer** represents the independency and freedom of the person like Kate. It also represents the struggle of women for independence and rights during 19-20th century, when women start to use type-writer to earn their living.

The dialogue in the play is witty and clever, with characters using puns and wordplay to convey their emotions and thoughts.

The cask of Amontillado

Edgar Allan Poe

Short story as a genre in literature (Edgar Allan Poe):

Term 'genre' implies **types or classes of literature**. A short story is fictional work of prose that is shorter in length than a novel. Poe has also described the short story as a **prose narrative**, "requiring from half an hour to one or two hours for its perusal". Edgar Allan Poe, in his essay "The Philosophy of Composition,"

said that a short story should be read in one sitting, anywhere from a half hour to two hours. In contemporary fiction, a short story can range from 1,000 to 20,000 words.

A primary idea that Poe focused on was the importance of brevity - telling and keeping the principal elements of a text but in fewer words. Poe firmly believed that anything non-essential needed to be eliminated, which meant the rest of the elements in the text had to be strengthened. The main characteristic of Poe's short stories is the existence of what is so called a single emotional effect: all incidents in the story, the words and details that create the incident, must point toward this single, effect. Regarding the structure of a short story, *"Poe was the first to consider endings as crucial elements in compositional strategies and defined the short story in terms of reading experience"*. Poe is known as the possessor of one most original imagination. Edgar Allan Poe was the first great master of the modern short story. In his short stories, we encounter various fictional genres, such as science fiction, detective fiction, etc. Although it had its literary beginning in America, the influence in other parts of the world was immense. Guy de Maupassant, the eminent French short story writer was greatly influenced by Poe.

Title Significance

Amontillado, literally, it's an alcoholic beverage, closely related to sherry (Reference=CASK OF SHERRY, another short story by Poe). Casks, by the way, are barrels for storing wine or other drinks, and they come in many sizes. The title is ironic in a sense that the word cask is derived from the same root word used to form casket, meaning coffin. Thus, the cask figuratively represents Fortunato's casket. Montresor tells Fortunato he has a *"pipe of what passes for Amontillado."* In this context, "pipe" and "cask" mean the same thing. The cask of Amontillado represents Fortunato's arrogance and weakness, his love for wine is what leads to his death by the hands of Montresor.

Poe's stories are strongly psychological. Everything in a Poe story represents an aspect of the human mind. Poe tells us that there are figurative meanings. He gives us lots of clue, one way to get at this mysterious Amontillado is to consider what it means to each of our two characters. For Fortunato, Amontillado symbolizes pleasure and enjoyment in the extreme. He's willing to travel through the nastiest graveyards to get what he wants. He would probably do just about anything for it, but it betrays him. In the end, for Fortunato, Amontillado means imprisonment by his own desires. He's trapped, and he can't do anything but die – though, alternatively, death can be considered freedom from desire. For Montresor, Amontillado means something slightly different. Instead of being ruled by it, he uses it to get what he wants, which is the power to make Fortunato feel his revenge – permanently. In the end, Montresor is freed from his desire – for revenge, at least. The title of the Edgar Allan Poe short story, "The Cask of Amontillado," is a highly appropriate one since it serves Fortunato into his final resting place.

Characters

Montresor: Montresor is a complex and intriguing character whose desire for revenge drives the story. Given that his family motto is *Nemo me impune lacessit, which means "no one insults me with impunity,"* Poe seems to suggest that this drive is one that defines his existence. His noble lineage seems to be at least part of what makes him murderous. From the start of the story, his vengeful nature sets the tone for the acts that will follow. One of the first things that Montresor narrates to the reader about Fortunato is that he *"...must not only punish but punish with impunity"*. Montresor is also manipulative, as he tells Fortunato that he will have someone else taste the Amontillado, knowing that by doing this Fortunato will feel compelled to taste the wine himself. He says he has cause for seeking revenge—that Fortunato has insulted and injured him—but he never gives any specifics. The cause of his injured pride, then, is unknown and may be imaginary.

Montresor shows his skill at deception by how he tricks Fortunato, and his skill at planning how he sets up the final **resting spot in the catacomb** and guides Fortunato to it. While there is one moment that seems to give him pause (when Fortunato screams), **he is ultimately cold, calculating, and relentless**. Montresor dons a *“mask of black silk”* and a heavy knee-length cloak (76-77). Montresor's clothes seem to indicate his **wanting to conceal himself** so he can carry out his devious plan. He also displays condescending traits; Montresor addresses Fortunato in the catacombs saying, *“your health is precious. You are rich, respected, admired, beloved; you are happy as once I was. You are a man to be missed”*.

Montresor's character is a favorite of scholars because **he is an example of Poe allowing us into the mind of a sinister schemer**. Montresor instigates a larger study into themes and elements within the story such as the competing desires to do good or evil: **Montresor's name seems evil, similar to a "monster"**, while Fortunato is supposed to be lucky. Fortunato indeed does not find luck in this story, however, the reader may assume that one of the reasons Montresor enacts revenge on **Fortunato is that he is typically lucky in other suits**. In the story, Montresor mentions how loved, rich, and respected Fortunato is, and hints that he, himself, does not have these qualities. Montresor's murder **plot to bury Fortunato alive is particularly evil**, nonetheless he feels that he is **doing rightful work**. The reader must make the decision as to which side they will take.

Fortunato: Fortunato first **appears in the story through Montresor's discussion** of how Fortunato has hurt him. When he appears in the story in person, he's wearing a costume—specifically, motley—clothes a jester or fool would wear a *“tight fitting parti-striped dress, and his head was surmounted by the conical cap and bells”*. These two factors largely frame Fortunato's role throughout the story. At first glance, Fortunato seems easier to identify with than Montresor. **It's much simpler to relate to the victim than to the victimizer**. But, in some ways, he seems even more **foreign to the reader than Montresor**. Part of this is because Montresor is telling us the story, and he doesn't give us much information on his prey. **Readers experience Fortunato through Montresor's narrative**, which is clearly biased and likely insane—and Fortunato himself plays the fool at many turns, missing clues and making choices that make his fate worse. **Fortunato's ego, greed, and competitiveness cloud his judgment.**

Fortunato has a lot of weaknesses including his **addiction to wine**. He's already really drunk when he meets Montresor, and he thinks **the Amontillado can help him take it to the next level**. Right up until the end, he thinks of Amontillado, and only Amontillado. Plus, he lets Montresor get him even drunk down in the catacomb. His **addiction** leaves him vulnerable to Montresor's attack. Whether he really hurt and insulted Montresor or not, **he's so insensitive**, he doesn't notice that Montresor is mad at him, something any fool can see. And he just **guzzles Montresor's wine without even saying “thank you.”** Because he's so insensitive, he's a poor judge of character. He's either too **proud or too greedy**. Maybe Montresor doesn't need to bring up Luchesi to get Fortunato down in the hole, but it doesn't hurt. **Fortunato either wants to prove that he's a better wine taster than Luchesi**, or he wants to make sure Luchesi doesn't get his hands on the Amontillado. **Being too trusting can be a weakness** and that weakness led to his downfall. Montresor says he made sure Fortunato had no reason to doubt him. But still, Fortunato should know better than to follow a masked man into a catacomb. *“For the love of God, Montresor!”* Fortunato addresses this plea—his last spoken words—to Montresor, the **man who has entombed him alive**.

Luchesi: Luchesi is another wine expert. He does not appear in the story in person, but **Montresor repeatedly mentions him to Fortunato**. Montresor pretends he is on his way to see Luchesi to ask about the value of the Amontillado he supposedly has found, but really he is just using **Luchesi as a foil to goad Fortunato into descending into his vaults**.

The servants: Montresor's servants do not appear in this story in person. Judging by Montresor's references to them he does not have a high opinion of their work ethic or honesty. He says he explicitly ordered them not to leave the house, fully expecting they would leave as soon as his back was turned to join in the carnival festivities.

Themes

Revenge: Edgar Allan Poe explicitly signals that revenge will be the focus of "The Cask of Amontillado" in its opening line: *"The thousand injuries of Fortunato I had borne as I best could; but when he ventured upon insult I vowed revenge."* Much of the story's following two paragraphs explore Montresor's ideas about revenge. From there, Poe moves to Montresor's discussion of how he plans his revenge on Fortunato. This strategy echoes the idea of the dramatic monologue in poetry and the monologues of Shakespeare's plays, where the villain reveals himself to his audience.

Several things are striking about Montresor's commitment to revenge. The first is how powerful and all-consuming it is. This is a man who keeps track of how other people insult him and how many times. He plans ahead, first to deceive Fortunato and then to kill him. This calculation is part of what makes this story so hypnotic: Montresor's act is the opposite of a crime of passion. Poe emphasizes this opposition by having Montresor pull a trowel out from under his robe. Trowels have very specific purposes, and no one except a skilled tradesperson is likely to carry one.

Almost as striking as his commitment and calculation is the fact that revenge is the Montresor family tradition. It is so central to who they are as a family that it is the theme of their coat of arms and their motto's message. In his fiction, Poe often portrayed characters that developed intense passions, and some of these are even aligned with revenge, as in "The Tell-Tale Heart" or "The Black Cat." In Montresor, however, Poe gives readers something unique: a character for which revenge are a defining characteristic and a family value. *"A wrong is unredressed when retribution overtakes its redresser. It is equally unredressed when the avenger fails to make himself felt as such to him who has done the wrong"*. This establishes Montresor's very specific idea of justice. If someone is punishing another person for an offense, he is only successful if he doesn't suffer himself and if the other person knows what is going on and why.

Suspense: Throughout the story, Edgar Allan Poe creates events in which he builds suspense. The author keeps his readers on their feet by having a surprise at every corner. Edgar Allan Poe demonstrates in "The Cask of Amontillado" how he uses the conflict to show the build of suspense, change of mood of the reader, develop the theme, and reflect a change in the character/characters. Poe let the readers know that Montresor was out for revenge in the first line of the story. This keeps the readers at the edge of their seat because the readers can assume that there is going to be a fight or death occurrence at some point in the story.

Folly of Pride: Pride is a central motivation in this story, and foolish pride is one of the themes that affect both main characters throughout. Montresor concludes he must have revenge on Fortunato because of his wounded pride. Fortunato may be full of himself and a bit foolish, but nothing in this story suggests any of the "thousand injuries" he did to Montresor were intentional. They might not even be real offenses. Instead, they might be Montresor valuing his pride and his family legacy of being proud so highly that he takes offense even when none is meant (or given). Montresor is rich enough to have a house with servants and enough spare time to plot this elaborate revenge, but he is not, as he says, happy. He compares himself to Fortunato and finds himself wanting.

Fortunato's foolish pride is just as central to this story, but is a bit coarser and more clownish. He is dressed for a party (as a fool, notably) and clearly has plans, but he abandons those plans in a flash as soon as

Montresor taunts him with the threat of asking Luchesi about the wine. His outsized pride continues to motivate him throughout the story. Fortunato is clearly unwell and has a terrible cough. However, rather than protecting his health, he insists on going deeper into the catacomb, spurred on by the mere mention of Luchesi's name.

Delusion: Both of the main characters in The Cask of Amontillado suffer from different kinds of delusions. Though Fortunato does come across as foolish, he is never shown to be intentionally evil. Montresor never elaborates on any particular incidents where he felt slighted by Fortunato and it is possible that he suffered from the delusion that Fortunato was trying to antagonize him when he actually wasn't. Montresor also lives in the delusion that revenge is a valid reason to murder someone, even when the perceived insults are not intense but just numerous. The story was terrifying for people when it came out because Montresor is a dispassionate killer who does not feel remorse and is never punished for his crime. Even as an old man he claims that he would have done the same again. Fortunato on the other hand has delusions about his own importance. He considers himself well-liked and respected and does not realize that most people find him irritating. He is blinded by his own sense of self-importance. Montresor uses this to create a plot to lure him to the catacombs where the murder finally takes place. He also lives in the delusion that Montresor is actually his friend, a trust that Montresor takes advantage of.

Substance Abuse: The only drug that is mentioned in The Cask of Amontillado is alcohol but addiction is a running theme throughout the story. Montresor is addicted to revenge whereas Fortunato is addicted to feeling important and the intoxicants that make him feel good. The story takes place during Carnival, a time of drunken revelry when people are allowed to behave excessively.

The fact that Fortunato is known to love alcohol is an important piece of information for Montresor's revenge plan. He chooses Carnival as the time to carry out his plan because he knows that Fortunato will be intoxicated. He uses the lure of a cask of Amontillado, a rare type of brandy, to convince Fortunato to come with him. He further makes sure to continue plying Fortunato with drinks along the way so that he stays drunk and does not feel in danger.

Edgar Allan Poe himself battled alcohol and substance addictions in his own life and many of his stories have the theme of substance abuse in it. In this case, however, it is not the main character who suffers from a substance abuse issue but the object of his vengeance who does. Written towards the end of Poe's life, The Cask of Amontillado themes, including substance abuse can be seen as issues he considered important in his own life. Pride is a drug in "The Cask of Amontillado." Fortunato is addicted to wine; but Montresor has his drinking under control.

Freedom

Freedom is another important The Cask of Amontillado theme. Montresor wants to be free of his desire for revenge and believes the only way is to act upon it. Fortunato is literally walled into a small area at the bottom of a catacomb. It is interesting to consider why Montresor chose this method of murder. Apart from being the perfect way of hiding away a body, he may be motivated to take away Fortunato's freedom the same way Fortunato's insults built up into an all-encompassing hatred that took away Montresor's freedom of thought.

Remorse

Remorse is one of the themes of The Cask of Amontillado that is somewhat complicated. Montresor is so fixated on revenge that he **does not consider the emotional consequences of murder**. After walling Fortunato in the catacombs, he feels strangeness in his chest but attributes it to the dampness. 50 years later when he tells the story, **he still does not regret his actions and is unapologetic**. This is one of the reasons why people found the story so disturbing; the **coldness of Montresor and the fact that he escaped punishment**. In the modern context, it can be speculated that Montresor is a sociopath; an idea that still scares people in today's world.

Fortunato on the other hand has no opportunity that the audience is aware of to feel remorse. **Montresor never tells him why he is exacting vengeance, and Fortunato is too self-deluded to reflect on the thousands of small insults**. Both of the characters in the story do not feel remorse for their actions, but for very different reasons. Written at the end of Poe's life, this The Cask of Amontillado theme may be an insight into the great author's mind and his considerations of remorse.

Pride: Pride, as the precursor to revenge, is one of the main The Cask of Amontillado themes. Montresor feels as if his pride has been wounded by Fortunato. Even though he is unable to state any particular instances, he still feels wronged and this is what motivates his desire for revenge. His sense of superiority may have caused him to exaggerate the offenses in his mind. Despite being wealthy he still does not feel happy and believes that his family's legacy and his own pride are the most important things.

Fortunato has a very different kind of pride but one that is just as silly and destructive. His delusional sense of self-importance makes him unaware of his status amongst people. He dresses as a clown for carnival as an excuse to behave like the fool that he actually is. **Montresor uses the threat of asking a competitor to taste the cask of Amontillado as a way of poking at Fortunato's pride** and convincing him to go with him. Even as Fortunato descends deeper into the catacombs and his cough gets worse his pride does not allow him to turn back.

Freedom and Confinement: The contrast between freedom and confinement is extreme in "The Cask of Amontillado." For one character to be free, another must die. Most of the story takes place in a vast and incredibly foul smelling catacomb, or underground graveyard. Dead bodies (or at least bones) abound. Freedom becomes less and less of a possibility as the characters move into smaller and smaller crypts, each one more disgusting than the last. Such confinement makes both the readers and the characters appreciate the deliciousness of fresh air. Hopefully, it makes us, the readers, think more deeply about what makes us feel trapped, and what makes us feel free. Even though Fortunato dies and Montresor lives, Fortunato is still the freer character of the two.

Betrayal: Betrayal drives the action in "The Cask of Amontillado." One character's betrayal sets off a hideous chain of retribution, enacted below ground in a mass grave. Behind all this revenge and death, **the story is about trust**. Without trust there can be no betrayal. The story has much to do with the lengths human being will go to feel better when they feel betrayed – and the tragedy that comes when those lengths hit murderous extremes.

Fortunato betrays himself by not paying enough attention to his surroundings.

Mortality: "The Cask of Amontillado" has a **frightening fixation on death, corpses, and bones**. Edgar Allan Poe's last short story, written only a few years before his death, is a precise and compact expression of anxieties concerning mortality. But don't worry – Poe injects plenty of humor into all the doom and gloom. And in the end, we all feel a little happier to be alive. It's ironic that, for Montresor to enjoy his own life, he has to take Fortunato's.

Disguise: Disguise, both in metaphorical and literal terms, allows Montresor to carry out his crime. Both characters are literally in disguise because it is Carnival, which makes it logistically possible for Montresor to take Fortunato into the catacombs. With Poe's use of dramatic irony the true meaning behind many of Montresor's words and Montresor's true intentions are disguised from Fortunato.

The Power of the Dead over the Living: Poe often gives memory the power to keep the dead alive. Poe distorts this otherwise commonplace literary theme by bringing the dead literally back to life, employing memory as the trigger that reawakens the dead, who are usually women. In "Ligeia," the narrator cannot escape memories of his first wife, Ligeia, while his second wife, the lady Rowena, begins to suffer from a mysterious sickness. While the narrator's memories belong only to his own mind, Poe allows these memories to exert force in the physical world. Ligeia dies, but her husband's memory makes him see her in the architecture of the bedroom he shares with his new wife. In this sense, Gothic terror becomes a love story. The loving memory of a grieving husband revives a dead wife. "Ligeia" breaks down the barrier between life and death, but not just to scare the reader. Instead, the memory of the dead shows the power of love to resist even the permanence of death.

Self vs. Alter Ego: In many of Poe's Gothic tales, characters wage internal conflicts by creating imaginary alter egos or assuming alternate and opposite personalities. In "William Wilson," the divided self takes the form of the narrator's imagined double, who tracks him throughout Europe. The rival threatens the narrator's sense of a coherent identity because he demonstrates that it is impossible for him to escape his unwanted characteristics. The narrator uses the alter ego to separate himself from his insanity. He projects his inner turmoil onto his alter ego and is able to forget that the trouble resides within him. The alter ego becomes a rival of the self because its resemblance to the self is unmistakable. Suicide results from the delusion that the alter ego is something real that can be eliminated in order to leave the self in peace. In "The Black Cat" the narrator transforms from a gentle animal lover into an evil cat-killer. The horror of "The Black Cat" derives from this sudden transformation and the cruel act—the narrator's killing of his cat Pluto—which accompanies it. Pluto's reincarnation as the second cat haunts the narrator's guilty conscience. Although the narrator wants to forget his murder of Pluto, gallows appear in the color of his fur. The fur symbolizes the suppressed guilt that drives him insane and causes him to murder his wife.

IRONY

Poe's use of both *verbal irony* and *situational irony* adds to the chillingly humorous and unsettling tone of the story. The irony in this story becomes more grotesque once Fortunato realizes that Montresor is trapping him within the catacombs; they both speak a series of ironic falsehoods about Montresor allowing Fortunato to leave when both characters and the audience know that Fortunato will die there.

Verbal Irony

One of the literary devices used most effectively in "The Cask of Amontillado" is **verbal irony**, or when a speaker says one thing but means something very different. Early in the story, Montresor runs into Fortunato at the carnival. Montresor says, "I was so pleased to see him, which I thought I should never have done wringing his hand."

This early in the story, before the reader knows what's going to happen, it would be easy to assume that Montresor was simply happy to see his friend and socialize. As we find out, Montresor is only glad to see Fortunato so that he can ultimately enact revenge on him.

Later, as Montresor is taking Fortunato down into the cellar, supposedly to see the wine, Fortunato says that he is not going to die of a cough. "True—true," Montresor says, since he, in fact, knows exactly how Fortunato will die, in a manner unrelated to his persistent cough.

Point of View

Point of view is the perspective from which a story is told. The first sentence tells us that it is written in first person point of view: "The thousand injuries of Fortunato I had borne as I best could; but when he ventured upon insult, I vowed revenge." We learn that the narrator is Montresor. The fact that he, who killed Fortunato, is telling the story, means that it's told from his perspective.

Imagine how different the story would be if it had been told from Fortunato's point of view; he might not have even known why Montresor wanted to get revenge, or he might have realized what it was but thought it was a small matter. If the story was told in third person point of view, maybe from the perspective of the person Montresor is telling this story to, we would probably have a very different story also.

Flashback & Imagery

The whole story is a **flashback**, in other words, the story is told after it happened, and as the narrator remembers it. In this case, the narrator is Montresor, and he is telling unknown listeners around 50 years later. Notice that the entire story is told in past tense. At the end of the story, we learn that Montresor is actually telling the story many years later: "Against the new masonry I re-erected the old rampart of bones. For the half of a century no mortal has disturbed them."

Imagery helps readers to imagine the story in a more vivid way with phrases that help the reader see, hear, taste, or smell various aspects. In this story, imagery is used quite effectively. The outfit that the narrator describes Fortunato as wearing is a "tight fitting parti-striped dress, and...conical cap and bells" meant to indicate fun and happiness. These party clothes are in direct opposition to the dark tone of the story and the murder that befalls Fortunato.

Lady and the Tiger

Frank R. Stockton

Title Significance

"The Lady or the Tiger?" is a short story by Frank R. Stockton that was first published in 1882. The title itself is significant because **it represents the central dilemma faced by the protagonist in the story.** In the story, a king creates a system of justice where the accused is forced to choose between two doors. Behind one door, there is a beautiful lady who the accused will marry, and behind the other door, there is a ferocious tiger that will kill the accused. The protagonist of the story, a young man, is faced with this choice after he falls in love with the king's daughter and is accused of a crime.

The title of the story, "The Lady or the Tiger?" refers to the **difficult decision** that the protagonist must make. He must choose between two doors, and he does not know which one leads to the lady and which one leads to the tiger. **The title reflects the uncertainty and tension that permeate the story, as the reader is left wondering what the protagonist will choose and what fate awaits him.**

The ambiguity of the title is also symbolic of the larger themes in the story, including the nature of justice, the power of love, and the unpredictability of life. The title challenges readers to think about the choices we make in life and the consequences that follow, even when the outcome is uncertain.

In addition to the significance of the title as it relates to the story's plot and themes, it is also worth noting that "The Lady or the Tiger?" has become a well-known phrase in English literature and popular culture.

The story's popularity can be attributed in part to its open-ended conclusion, which leaves the reader to imagine what happens after the protagonist makes his choice. **This ambiguity has inspired countless interpretations and adaptations,** including stage plays, films, and literary critiques.

Furthermore, the phrase "The Lady or the Tiger?" has been used in a broader context to describe situations where someone is faced with a difficult choice between two equally unappealing options. **The story has thus become a metaphor for life's uncertainties and the choices we must make in the face of difficult circumstances.**

Overall, the title "The Lady or the Tiger?" is significant not only for its role in the story's plot and themes but also for its lasting impact on literature and popular culture. **The story's enduring popularity is a testament to its timeless themes and the powerful symbolism of its title.**

Characters

The Princess: The princess is the daughter of the king and is described as beautiful and intelligent. She is deeply in love with the young man, who is of lower status than her. The princess is jealous and possessive and cannot bear the thought of her lover marrying someone else. She has the power to decide the young man's fate by choosing between two doors. One door leads to a lady who the young man will marry, while the other door leads to a ferocious tiger that will kill him. The princess struggles with her love for the young man and her loyalty to her father, the king.

The Young Man: The young man is described as brave and handsome. He is deeply in love with the princess and hopes to marry her one day. **He is willing to accept his fate, whatever it may be, and puts his trust in the princess.** He is torn between his desire to be with the princess and his fear of the unknown behind the doors.

The King: **The king is a powerful and authoritative figure who has absolute control over the kingdom. He is described as "semi-barbaric" and is known for his unusual punishment system.** He is fiercely protective of his daughter and does not want her to marry someone of lower status. He gives the young man the choice between the two doors, knowing that the princess will be the one to decide his fate.

The Lady: The lady behind one of the doors **represents the possibility of a happy marriage** for the young man. She is described as beautiful and gentle, and it is implied that the young man would be happy with her.

The Tiger: The tiger behind the other door **represents death for the young man.** It is described as a ferocious beast that will kill the young man instantly. **The tiger represents the brutality** of the king's punishment system and the cruelty of fate.

The Court: The court represents the society in which the story takes place. The court is described as being **made up of both barbarians and civilized people,** and they are all gathered to witness the young man's

fate. The court is divided between those who hope the young man will marry the lady and those who hope he will be killed by the tiger.

The Attendants: The attendants represent the officials who carry out the king's orders. They are described as being well-dressed and well-mannered, but also emotionless and detached. They show no sympathy towards the young man, even though they know his fate rests in the princess's hands.

The Young Lady Who Loves the Young Man: This character is mentioned briefly in the story, but she is important because she is also in love with the young man. Her love for him creates a love triangle between her, the princess, and the young man. Her presence in the story emphasizes the unfairness of the King's punishment system and the difficult choices that love can sometimes force people to make.

The Doorkeeper: The doorkeeper represents the impartiality of fate. He is described as being stoic and emotionless, and he has no say in the outcome of the young man's fate. His job is simply to open the door that the princess points to, revealing either the lady or the tiger.

Overall, the characters in "The Lady or the Tiger" represent different aspects of human nature, such as love, jealousy, fear, and cruelty. The story is a commentary on the unpredictable nature of fate and the difficult choices that life can sometimes force people to make.

Themes

Barbarism vs Civilization: The question of barbarism vs civilization is a major theme in "The Lady, or the Tiger?" Throughout the story, characters are described as "barbaric" to the extent that they are not easily controlled and are given to extreme emotional passion. In contrast, they are described as "civilized" insofar as their behavior is seen as educated and refined.

The king is equal parts barbaric and civilized. Thus, he is "semi-barbaric." In other words, neither force gains the power to determine his character completely. The civilized half of his character has been influenced by "distant Latin neighbors" who have helped to polish and sharpen his ideas. Additionally, he has adopted the idea of the public arena from his Latin neighbors. This method of judgment also reduces his barbarism.

Despite this, the barbaric half of the king's character is obvious. His ideas are "large, florid, and untrammelled" and he is "a man of exuberant fancy". Whatever the king decides on becomes a fact as a result of his great power.

The most immediate expression of the king's barbarism is how he uses the idea of the public arena in his kingdom. Rather than make it a place where the kingdom can enjoy a public celebration or the arts, he turns it into the kingdom's court of justice. In the public arena, prisoners must choose between two doors, leaving their fate up to chance. Should the prisoner choose the door hiding a tiger, the entire kingdom must then witness the prisoner's bloody death. This form of "justice" reflects the king's barbarism, as he greatly enjoys the spectacle of watching the prisoner be forced to unwittingly choose his own fate. The narrator explains how the arena works: "the fate of the accused person would be decided in the king's arena" Like the king, the kingdom is "semi-barbaric" as well. The king's subjects greatly enjoy this system of justice, which appeals to their barbarism but which also "refine[s]" and "culture[s]" their minds.

The king's daughter, the princess, is also "semi-barbaric." The narrator describes her as a young woman "as blooming as [the king's] most florid fancies, and with a soul as fervent and imperious as his own". The princess's barbarism causes her to passionately love her lover: "she loved him with an ardor that had enough of barbarism in it to make it exceedingly warm and strong". It is thanks to the princess's barbarism that she is in the arena watching her lover choose his fate: "had it not been for the moiety of barbarism in her nature it is probable that lady would not have been there, but her intense and fervid soul would not"

allow her to be absent from an occasion in which she was so terribly interested". Additionally, the princess's barbarism is what causes her to hate the lady hiding behind the door whom her lover might wed: "The girl was lovely, but she had dared to raise her eyes to the loved one of the princess; and, with all the intensity of the savage blood transmitted to her through long lines of wholly barbaric ancestors, she hated the woman who blushed and trembled behind that silent door".

Because "The Lady, or the Tiger?" ends on a question, we are not sure if the princess succumbed to the "barbaric" or "civilized" side of herself. The "barbaric" side would likely have influenced her to send her lover to his death over having to share him with a lady whom she hates. Her "civilized" side might have led her to save him, choosing her own heartbreak over her lover's death. Because these attributes are equally strong inside of the princess, as they are in her father, it is hard to tell which door she chose.

Justice: "The Lady, or the Tiger?" depicts a unique form of "justice" which we do not often see represented in contemporary society. What marks the form of justice in the king's arena is that it is completely up to chance. No one decides the fate of the prisoner; it depends on nothing but his own luck. In this way, it is also impartial: luck or chance does not care which door the prisoner chooses. In the story, the narrator refers to this kind of justice as a "poetic justice" in which the fate of the prisoner is decided by "an impartial and incorruptible chance". That chance cannot be "corrupted" means that those in power do not have a say over the outcome of the trial and every prisoner is given an equal opportunity to save their own life—except, of course, when the princess gets involved.

According to the narrator of "The Lady, or the Tiger?" this form of justice is perfectly fair: *"Its perfect fairness is obvious. The criminal could not know out of which door would come the lady: he opened either he pleased, without having the slightest idea whether, in the next instant, he was to be devoured or married. On some occasions, the tiger came out of one door, and on some out of the other".* The prisoner's fate is also immediately decided and set in stone, and therefore cannot be changed. He is married or murdered right there in front of the entire kingdom.

Thus, readers are left with an interesting question: is this form of justice truly "fair"? Is it fairer than the justice that we see in the modern world, where the fate of an accused person is decided by a judge or jury? In our current system of justice, there is the worry that the accused fate will be hindered by the jury's biases. Though there are often procedures in place to check that bias (e.g. screening a jury, choosing jury members that do not have personal stakes in the trial, etc), the court can never be certain that these procedures are 100% effective. In the end, those with more power are often given more of a say and different people receive different kinds of justice in the courtroom.

Is a justice that is based on chance any better? Obviously, it is not—innocent prisoners might be sent to their death simply because they had been accused of a crime. Similarly, guilty prisoners might be rewarded simply because they happen to choose the door that is hiding the princess. The only benefit to this kind of justice system seems to be the fact that it is "impartial" and "incorruptible"—but is it, really? The princess, thanks to her power, is able to corrupt the justice system and mold it to her own ends.

The princess's intrusion in the "perfect fairness" of this justice system also offers its own message. Because she is so powerful, she is able to use her power to discover what is behind each door. No one in the kingdom has ever done this before, not even her father. As a result, the fate of her lover is not left up to chance but is instead completely in her hands. She has the power to save him or send him to his death depending on her will. Perhaps the message of the princess's intrusion is that justice can never really be impartial as long as it is being dealt out by humans. Humans have a natural tendency to have biases, knowingly or unknowingly, and there will always be someone with enough power to tip the scales of justice in their favor.

Power: Hand-in-hand with the theme of justice comes the theme of power. Because this story is about the workings of a kingdom, we are given a setting in which a few characters (i.e. the king and the princess)

are given great power, and the rest of the characters (i.e. the subjects) have very little. **The king has so much power, in fact, that the quality of life of his subjects is entirely dependent on his fancy.** As the narrator tells us, the king is powerful enough that every single one of his whims can be converted into fact: *"He was a man of exuberant fancy, and, withal, of an authority so irresistible that, at his will, he turned his varied fancies into facts. He was greatly given to self-communing; and, when he and himself agreed upon any thing, the thing was done".*

He has the power to decide whether or not his subjects will prosper or suffer. In fact, the kind of justice that each subject receives is dependent upon whether the king is interested in their case: *"When a subject was accused of a crime of sufficient importance to interest the king, public notice was given that on an appointed day the fate of the accused person would be decided in the king's arena".* The king has the power to upend tradition as he pleases and make new traditions of his own. The narrator writes, the king *"knew no tradition to which he owed more allegiance than pleased his fancy"*. Additionally, because the king takes so much pleasure in his justice system, **he does not allow anything to postpone the spectacle of the punishment or the reward:** *"It mattered not that [the prisoner] might already possess a wife and family, or that his affections might be engaged upon an object of his own selection; the king allowed no such subordinate arrangements to interfere with his great scheme".* For anyone who might be stepping into the king's arena, *"there was no escape"*.

There is only one character in the story whose power matches that of the king. That is his daughter, the princess, **who is able to completely subvert the king's system according to her own interests.** Because of her great power, she is able to figure out which door is hiding the princess and which door is hiding the tiger: *"Possessed of more power, influence, and force of character than any one who had ever before been interested in such a case, she had done what no other person had done,—she had possessed herself of the secret of the doors. . . [G]old, and the power of a woman's will, had brought the secret to the princess".* Here, it is suggested that the princess's power is not only in her status but also in her gender: it is thanks to her "woman's will" that she is able to discover the secret.

The princess's discovery of the truth has given her a power that no one—not even the king—has before possessed in the kingdom. She now has the power to determine whether her lover lives or dies. **Her lover goes confidently, without doubt, in the direction that the princess sends him:** *"Without the slightest hesitation, he went to the door on the right, and opened it".* In this way, the princess's power is absolute. She holds an entire life in her hands. This power is what makes the central question of "The Lady, or the Tiger?" so interesting. **She has upended the "perfect justice" of the king's arena** and has turned it instead into a matter of her own will. Very few people will ever hold that much power. It is hard to imagine what someone with that much power would choose.

Human Nature: Another theme of "The Lady, or the Tiger" is human nature. In fact, the story's question depends upon the reader's understanding of human nature more than anything else. The story does not give us a definite answer to the question of the young man's fate at the end of the story: that question is left for readers to interpret and judge for themselves. The reader's judgment about what happens at the end of the story depends entirely on what they think the princess will do.

As the narrator tells us, *"the more we reflect upon this question, the harder it is to answer."* Deciding whether the princess chooses her lover's death or her lover's marriage to another *"involves a study of the human heart which leads us through devious mazes of passion, out of which it is difficult to find our way".* In fact, as the narrator tells us, we cannot think about this question in terms of what we would do ourselves; instead we must consider the character of *"that hot-blooded, semi-barbaric princess, her soul at a white heat beneath the combined fires of despair and jealousy".* The princess, who is so powerful,

nonetheless does not have the power to decide who she can love. Here, her power has failed. As the text asks, "she had lost him, but who should have him?".

The fact that the princess gestures towards the door on the right without hesitation does not mean that she had not spent countless days thinking about the question of which door to choose. In fact, "she had known she would be asked" and prepared her decision accordingly. In order to answer this question, the reader must know the princess intimately—something that is impossible to do. The narrator himself does not know the answer. He writes, "[t]he question of her decision is not one to be lightly considered, and it is not for me to presume to set myself up as the one person able to answer it". As a result, he leaves the question with us readers. We each will have our own interpretations of the princess's decision, depending upon how we have read her character.

Love and jealousy: The story explores the power of love and the destructive force of jealousy. The princess is deeply in love with the young man but is also consumed by jealousy, which might have made her choose the door that leads to the tiger.

Fate and free will: The story raises questions about the role of fate and free will in our lives. The young man is ultimately forced to make a choice, but it is unclear whether the outcome is predetermined or the result of his own decision.

Justice and punishment: The story also raises questions about the morality of the king's justice system. The punishment is brutal and arbitrary, and the story suggests that justice should be fair and impartial.

Human nature: The story explores the darker aspects of human nature, including jealousy, revenge, and cruelty. It suggests that these traits are universal and can be found in people from all walks of life.

Ambiguity: The story is deliberately ambiguous, leaving the reader to speculate about the outcome. The ambiguity also invites the reader to reflect on the story's themes and what they mean in the context of their own lives.

Ethics and morality: The story poses ethical and moral questions about the nature of right and wrong. The young man is forced to make a choice between two doors, each with a different consequence, and the story leaves it up to the reader to decide what the right choice would be.

Sacrifice and selflessness: The story explores the themes of sacrifice and selflessness. The young man is willing to risk his life for his love, and the princess ultimately makes a sacrifice for him.

Consequences of actions: The story highlights the consequences of one's actions. The young man's decision has a significant impact on his fate, as well as the fate of the princess and the kingdom.

Power and authority: The story raises questions about the nature of power and authority. The king has absolute power over his subjects, but the story suggests that this power may be arbitrary and unjust.

Perception and reality: The story plays with the idea of perception and reality. The young man must choose between two doors, one of which he believes holds the love of his life, but he does not know what lies behind it. The story asks the reader to consider whether perception or reality is more important in decision-making

Literary Devices

"The Lady, or the Tiger?" is a short story by Frank R. Stockton that was first published in 1882. Here are some literary devices used in the story:

Irony: The story is full of irony, from the king's method of justice to the princess's decision at the end. For example, the king's system of justice is described as "*fair and just*" even though it is based entirely on chance, and the princess's decision is also ironic because it is both a triumph and a tragedy.

Foreshadowing: The author uses foreshadowing to hint at the outcome of the story. For example, the description of the princess's "*jealous and imperious nature*" suggests that she might choose the tiger for her lover.

Symbolism: The tiger and the lady are both symbolic. The tiger represents danger and savagery, while the lady represents beauty and grace.

Personification: The author personifies the arena when he writes, "*The very prison itself seemed alive and pulsating.*"

Imagery: The author uses vivid imagery to bring the story to life. For example, when describing the princess, he writes, "*She was a barbarian, but she had instincts that were almost refined.*"

Suspense: The story is full of suspense as the reader wonders which door the princess will choose for her lover.

Ambiguity: The story's ending is ambiguous, leaving the reader to imagine the princess's final decision.

Tone: The author's tone is ironic and satirical, especially in his description of the king's justice system.

Metaphor: The princess is metaphorically described as a "semi-barbaric" because of her mixed nature and uncertain behavior.

Allusion: The author alludes to ancient Rome and the Colosseum when he describes the arena and the spectators' bloodthirsty excitement.

Contrast: The story presents several contrasts, such as the contrast between the barbaric and civilized worlds, the contrast between the lady and the tiger, and the contrast between justice and chance.

Repetition: The phrase "The Lady, or the Tiger?" is repeated several times throughout the story, emphasizing the central conflict and creating a sense of suspense.

Irony of situation: The entire story is an example of irony of situation, as the king's justice system is based on chance rather than reason or morality, and the princess's decision ultimately renders the system meaningless.

Hyperbole: The author uses hyperbole to describe the princess's emotional state, such as when he writes, "Her soul was in a turmoil of wild hope and fearful apprehension."

Point of view: The story is narrated from a third-person omniscient point of view, allowing the reader to see into the minds of the characters and understand their motivations.

Alternative Ending

"She had known she would be asked, she had decided what she would answer, and without the slightest hesitation, she had moved her hand to the right." In his head the suitor wondered, can he trust her?

His heart racing, lover cautiously shifts toward the right. As the anxiety inside him builds up, he raises his hand toward the door. You can hear the audience hold its breath and feel the tension in the arena. This is it- the choice between life and death. **The princess sits uncomfortably in her seat wondering, hoping that she made the right choice.**

The common man's hand grips the door knob, it's unusually cold. With hesitation he slides back the enormous door. He hears nothing, not the slightest noise, just darkness. The spectators in the audience, quiet as a mouse, crane their necks to see inside the door. The king sits tall and mighty, clearly delighted to watch and find out the common man's fate.

The common man's eyes strain into the darkness. Then suddenly a noise comes from the blackness. **Is it beads or chains, the beads of the lady's dress or the chains restraining the tiger?** The man looks at the princess and holds his breath like it is his last. He closes his eyes and hears a steady pit, pat on the loose dirt. He peers out of his half open eyelids. Slowly emerges an angelic lady. The common man lets out a sigh of relief and shoots up a glance at the princess. Her face was full of hatred and pain, he grows a lump of guilt in his throat. The crowd is still cheering as the common man plasters a fake smile on his face to fool the lady and the audience. The common man examines the lady, who is without a doubt beautiful, covered with one of the most lavish dresses he had ever seen. The off white fabric, covered with jewels he couldn't recognize, draped over her body in a wave of beauty.

It wasn't enough, for she wasn't as beautiful as the princess he loved. Nothing would fill his heart but her. As the wedding begins, his eyes sneak up to where the princess had been watching, only to watch her leave the arena. He moved his glance to the right to see the king with a big evil smirk on his face. **The king knew that if he had set the tiger on the common man, his daughter would hate him.** So no one but him knew that behind the other door was another lady. The princess laid in her room, too tired and betrayed to cry. She had hated the lady behind the door beyond belief, but her love for the common man was too much. He was the love of her life and her soul mate. She knew that she wouldn't be able to stand to see him with the other lady. Something had to be done. **The princess was just a little bit barbaric, but that was all it took to completely change the way she was looking at things.** She was a princess; she knew people and who would know and who would tell if the lady from the arena never woke up the next morning? So that night she made two calls; one to an assassin and one to the common man. The princess and the common man met at the city gate at midnight. The night was cold; they both stood close to the horse that would be their escape from the city. They were both wrapped in heavy cloths, draped over their heads, hiding their faces in shadow. They waited silently for the signal; the only noise was the horse, anxiously shifting his weight. A scream sounded in the distance and off they went into the night. Little did they know that high in the tower was a pair of big eyes watching their every moves. The barbaric king was heated in anger. He was horrified because of the betrayal of his daughter against his own law. He summoned his best knights and gave them just one command, "No one betrays the King's justice, and they should be the ones to meet their fate now."

The Story of an Hour

Kate Chopin

Title Significance

The title of a story serves as an important link to the plot. An hour can seem like it goes on forever if you're doing something difficult or uncomfortable, however **it doesn't seem like a lot of time under normal circumstances** i.e it seems like it's over as soon as it starts. In Mrs. Mallard's case, **processing the tragic news of her husband's death and what it means for the upcoming years of her life makes that hour slow way down and stand still as a lot of stuff happens to Mrs. Mallard during that hour.** In this case, the title "The Story of an Hour" aptly suits the main plot of the short story. **The freedom and joy gained in one hour after husband's death by Louise is quickly lost.** Within an hour she has a glimpse of her life free from restrictions and her husband and then loses all her dreams and aspirations at the sight of her husband, still alive. **The introspection towards life and independence takes place in one hour,** at the end of which Louise meets her sudden death.

Themes

Mortality: Death is so powerful in "The Story of an Hour" that even **news of someone else's death, if told the wrong way, can be lethal.** Finding out someone hasn't died can be almost as powerful, and deadly, too. Instead of being at first stunned by the news of her husband's death, Louise immediately burst into wild tears *"She wept at once, with sudden, wild abandonment, in her sister's arms."* This story is unusual in that it allows a character to explore the feelings beyond grief or loss that one might have if a loved one died. **Mrs. Mallard's complex reaction to the news of her husband's death speaks to the terrible, almost welcome freedom a tragedy can bring.** Ultimately, the fact that death is coming seems certain. It's the question of who gets taken away by death, though, that changes so drastically.

Time: The events in "The Story of an Hour" happen quickly, and the author herself does not mince words in relaying them. Yet it seems like life can change drastically, and a person can change dramatically, in under an hour. Mrs. Mallard spends less than an hour processing the news that her husband has died. In doing so, **she moves rapidly through her grief to arrive at a "dream" or "story" of what life by herself will be like.** *"She said it over and over under her breath: 'free, free, free!'"* In less than an hour, she's gotten used to the idea of a whole different future – a future she's excited about, instead of a future that she dreads. *And she opened and spread her arms out to them in welcome.* But the work of a few seconds – seeing her husband alive and well – proves her wrong and blows up that new dream of a possible future path.

Freedom and Confinement: At first, idea of freedom seems like a terrible thing to Mrs. Mallard, who's **restricted in lots of ways: through her marriage, by her bad heart, and even inside her home,** which she doesn't leave during "The Story of an Hour." On the other hand, though, **she has considerable freedoms as an upper-class, married lady.** She can tell freedom's coming for her, and she dreads it. Once it arrives, though, it fills her with an overpowering joy *"Free! Body and soul free!" she kept whispering.* Yet, she **experiences this mental and emotional freedom while being confined to a room.** As soon as she leaves that room, the freedom she'd only just barely begun to understand is taken away from her.

Language and Communication: In "The Story of an Hour," how you tell someone what happened is almost more important than what actually happened. The biggest concern isn't whether someone lives or dies, it's how you tell a person with a weak heart bad news without killing her. In other words, communication or news can be lethal. *"Knowing that Mrs. Mallard was afflicted with a heart trouble, great care was taken to break to her as gently as possible the news of her husband's death."* Surprising information doesn't just have the power to shock – it can actually kill someone. In this case, the surprise

that a husband isn't dead after all is more deadly than a railroad accident. Ideas have to be communicated carefully, with preparation and delicacy. Otherwise, the listener may very well end up dead.

Theme of Oppression: *"She was young, with a fair, calm face, whose lines bespoke repression and even a certain strength."* Through a brief description, Chopin conveys two important personality traits of Mrs. Louise Mallard. She is a woman who is repressed, and she has a strength of will that probably both contributes to her repression and to the embrace of her freedom. The writer has an interesting take on the institution of marriage which can be traced to a second wave feminist ideology. Caring and building a family together is considered an exercise in control and domination. Homemaking and raising a family is considered to be a waste of potential with respect to getting a job and spending money on base desires. This is signified by Louise's sense of freedom when she learns about her husband's death. Even though marriage is portrayed as a device of control and cruelty, it is selfish individualism which shows in the sheer apathy of Louise's thoughts.

Theme of Marriage: Marriage is condemned as an instrument of oppression to cage women inside households in the story. It is regarded as an antiquated tradition that has lost value in the light of modern and individualistic lifestyle. Through Louise, there is a strong criticism of the old custom of bringing two people in a relationship as opposed to allowing them to just stay alone and impose their will without constraints. There is a clear suggestion that independence is more valuable than interdependence. Interestingly, there is no point in the story where Louise does not depend either on her sister Josephine, Richards or even her husband Brently for support, information or care. The writer celebrates the pleasures of selfish indulgences over togetherness and dependence in a strong marital bond. The fact that the Mallards have a shared history seems to be overshadowed by the ideas of the self and individualism.

Theme of Independence: The story celebrates the idea and desire for independence and freedom. Louise is a caring wife and sister. She has a loving family with a husband and sister who care for her. Freedom is valued even greater than family, love, and togetherness. It also highlights the importance of individualism over interdependence between individuals. There is a condemnation of the institution of marriage as some sort of prison and an allusion to a better life without such a bond. The writer points at Louise's happiness at being free from the confines of her marriage in contrast to the grief of becoming a widow as *"She said it over and over under her breath: 'free, free, free!'"*.

Brief moment of illumination

"Story of an Hour" was written and published in 1894. This story was written in an era where a lot of questions were risen, about who the dominant sex was and why. This story was written to share with the world how men treated women in that era and how men really felt about women. Women were forced to be with men and were bound to be unhappy. The biggest question was the "Women's Question". What role the women fulfilled in the society and that the female species were the less dominant species. Men were the overriding species, women were forced to do things they did not want to do and were forced to be with men they did not really love and care for. In the "Story of an Hour" Mrs. Mallard is also forced to be with a person she did not really know. She never really loved him and cared for him the way she was supposing to. Mrs. Mallard was treated the same as all the women were treated in that era, badly and were abused in many ways.

Mrs. Mallard's "brief moment of illumination" is a very deep and touching story about a lady who is forced to be married to a man she did not really know and did not love deeply with all her heart, as if she is bound with unhappiness for life! Now she has been liberated. The narrator portrays that she was feeling a kind of

freedom that she could not describe, but does not know how to deal with it. In this essay matters such as this freedom she was feeling, the little love she had for her husband, the "monstrous joy" she was feeling will be discussed. Matters such as women's issues and their feelings towards life and death are also included in this essay. These matters are all part of Mrs. Mallard's "brief moment of illumination". "A kind intention or a cruel intention made the act seem no less a crime as she looked upon it in that brief moment of illumination."

Joy that kills

In the short story "The Story of an Hour" by Kate Chopin, the reader is introduced to Louise Mallard, the wife of Brently Mallard who supposedly died in a train accident. The story uses multiple literary devices such as irony, conflict and symbolism to convey Mrs. Mallard's emotions within the hour that she discovers the sudden death of her husband. Writer Kate Chopin uses different types of irony to emphasize Mrs. Mallard's true feelings about her husband's death, her marriage, and her life. Irony is defined as "The expression of one's meaning by using language that normally signifies the opposite, typically for humorous or emphatic effect". Chopin uses dramatic irony to provide the reader with additional information when compared to the characters. Chopin writes, "When the doctors came they said she had died of heart disease - of joy that kills". This was the main example of dramatic irony from the story. Louise's overwhelming sense of hope in experiencing an independent future as a widow, was abruptly shattered when she discovers that her husband is alive. The characters in the story believe and agree with the Doctor that Mrs. Mallard died due to an excess of happiness from seeing her husband alive and well. The characters believed that Mrs. Mallard was so happy to see her husband alive and healthy that those strong emotions were too much for her. On the other hand, the reader knows that Mrs. Mallard didn't die of an overload of joy but died due to the shock, disappointment, fear and possible guilt of seeing her presumably dead husband alive. She was ecstatic at her husband's death and when she saw him alive it was the sudden shock on her happiness that killed her. Here, Louise's momentary joy caused her death

Ironic ending

The ending of "The Story of an Hour" is a classic fake-out (deliberately misleading). The event that starts the story off – Mr. Mallard's death – is completely undone in the conclusion. It's the opposite of a linear life story because he starts out dying and ends up alive. Meanwhile, Mrs. Mallard's life, which her friends and family tried so hard to protect at the beginning, is lost at the end. So, the story ends with an event the characters tried to avoid at the beginning. "Knowing that Mrs. Mallard was afflicted with a heart trouble, great care was taken to break to her as gently as possible the news of her husband's death." That's ironic. And, on a second look, pretty brutal. In the last line: "When the doctors came they said she had died of heart disease – of joy that kills". Readers can take away one thing for certain from this: Mrs. Mallard has died.

The doctors referenced say it was because of the "joy" that Mrs. Mallard felt upon realizing her husband hadn't died. If that were all, it would be a cruel twist of fate. Her happiness killed her. That would prove just how much she loved her husband. The denouement of Kate Chopin's "The Story of an Hour" is ironic in that the death of Mrs. Mallard has been inevitable, not because she has a bad heart, but because she has had "a heart trouble," a repressed heart that in its elation cannot return itself to its former state of subjugation without damage—"a heart trouble." Her joy, finally released, is what causes her death as she cannot go back to her life as the wife of Bently Mallard.

A victim of the institution of Victorian life, Mrs. Mallard has been under the "powerful will bending hers in that persistence" of her culture. While she has felt love for her husband, she is like the prisoner who is released, but once outside, is told that he must return and serve more time. This would seem like a death

sentence. Kate Chopin's employment of irony is absolutely superb. The opening line is ironic--"a heart trouble" that Mrs. Mallard has is a spiritual, not a physical problem; the "joy that kills" is also ironic, for the release of her imprisoned grief cannot be repressed again without fatal results because the anguish is too much for her heart.

Examples of irony

- Josephine is concerned that Louise is making herself ill in her room, but we know that she feels better at that moment than she has in a long time, maybe ever.
- The doctor's stated cause of Louise's death, "the joy that kills," was more likely a shocking disappointment that killed. She was closer to joyful before her husband walked in, not after.
- There are other things that are only ironic in hindsight e.g. Everyone's concern over breaking the sad news as gently as possible when Louise takes it very well.
- All of Louise's thoughts of being free and living for herself were an illusion—her husband was alive the whole time.
- How Louise descends the stairs feeling triumphant and victorious only to die seconds later.

Symbolism

The Open Window: The open window from which Louise gazes for much of the story represents the freedom and opportunities that await her after her husband has died. From the window, Louise sees blue sky, fluffy clouds, and treetops. She hears people and birds singing and smells a coming rainstorm. Everything that she experiences through her senses suggests joy and spring—new life. And when she ponders the sky, she feels the first hints of elation. Once she fully indulges in this excitement, she feels that the open window is providing her with life itself. The open window provides a clear, bright view into the distance and Louise's own bright future, which is now unobstructed by the demands of another person. It's therefore no coincidence that when Louise turns from the window and the view, she quickly loses her freedom as well.

Heart Trouble: The heart trouble that afflicts Louise is both a physical and symbolic malady that represents her ambivalence toward her marriage and unhappiness with her lack of freedom. The fact that Louise has heart trouble is the first thing we learn about her, and this heart trouble is what seems to make the announcement of Brently's death so threatening. A person with a weak heart, after all, would not deal well with such news. When Louise reflects on her new independence, her heart races, pumping blood through her veins. When she dies at the end of the story, the diagnosis of "heart disease" seems appropriate because the shock of seeing Brently was surely enough to kill her. But the doctors' conclusion that she'd died of overwhelming joy is ironic because it had been the loss of joy that had actually killed her. Indeed, Louise seems to have died of a broken heart, caused by the sudden loss of her much-loved independence.

Spring: Spring is a major symbol in *The Story of an Hour*. Mrs. Mallard welcomes the new spring life. This symbolizes a new beginning for her, spring represents life and that is what Mrs. Mallard gains as a widow. It also helps to note that spring comes after winter. Winter can be seen as Louise while she was married to her husband. Winter is symbolically a depressing, cold and isolated season. Contrasting that to Louise's new-found spirit and life in the story's "Spring" setting. "She could see in the open square before her house the tops of trees that were all quiver with the new spring life."

Weather: The change in the weather within the story is another symbolic method applied by Chopin to show her character's feelings. In the beginning, the readers observe rainy and cold weather that indicates

the onset of something negative, such as the news about death. It also points to the unhappiness and dependence of Mrs. Mallard on her husband, which seemed to be endless. However, with the realization of her freedom, she takes *"the delicious breath of rain was in the air"*, and the day becomes sunny.

Sun: One may suggest that the sun is a sign of the coming improvements, and the weather changes as if a hint that life would be much better. It should be emphasized that Mrs. Mallard is definitely upset by the news, yet she is also happy to understand that she can live for her pleasure. The sun and fresh air are regarded as an elixir of life, which helps her to figure out her new position.

The Scythe

Ray Bradbury

Title Significance

The title is usually the first introduction readers have to any short story. Therefore, it is important to select a title that grabs attention, accurately describes the contents of the story, and makes people want to read further. Ray Bradbury has wonderfully highlighted the main theme of his short by selecting the most appropriate title for it. "The Scythe" is based upon the biblical allegory of the grim reaper, whose name is Death. In the allegory as well as in Bradbury's story, this reaper has absolute control over the bounds of life and death. "The Scythe," then, depicts death incarnate. Furthermore, the scythe or the sickle itself is also linked with many allegories of death. Symbolically, it carries a double meaning. First is its function of cutting, paralleling the insatiable hunger of Death. Then, the scythe is also symbolic of the hope of rebirth, indicative of the continuity of the life force. This second meaning finds substantiation in the story when new grain sprouts magically from the old. This story is one of Bradbury's earliest attempts at dealing with and ridding humanity of what he calls the "hairball" fears about death. Free from such fears, we can devote our energies to positive endeavors.

Ray Bradbury, who created hundreds of short stories, several novels, novellas, dozens of plays, poems, tragedies is traditionally regarded as one of the best fiction writers. Ray Bradbury's style is very rich and manifests itself on all linguistic levels. "The Scythe" is a short story by American author Ray Bradbury. It was originally published in the July 1943 issue of *Weird Tales*. It was first collected in Bradbury's anthology *Dark Carnival* and later collected, in revised form, in *The October Country* and *The Stories of Ray Bradbury*. Plot Ray Bradbury's, "The Scythe" is about a family who happens upon an old farmhouse. The family is poor and is in need of some food. When Drew enters the house, it is quiet and still. He ventures upstairs to a bedroom, where an old man is lying, dead. Inside the room, the old man leaves a note, saying that anyone who comes across him has full responsibilities to his home and duties as a farmer. A scythe is also in the room. The family's luck seems to be changing. Never will they or their kids go hungry again. Never will they have to worry about the next meal. Everything is right there for them; food, shelter and the love of a strong family. All they have to do is keep the promise of the dead farmer's last wishes. Drew works day and night working outside in the wheat field, but to no avail. As soon as he cuts the wheat, it grows back. Eventually he learns that with each swipe of the scythe, cutting wheat, he's taking someone's life. One day he recognizes one of the stalks of wheat as his family. He refuses to cut it. The next day his house burns to the ground with his family inside. They're not dead, but sleeping. With his refusal to cut the grain, he's refusing their death, yet they can't live either. Like many other works of Bradbury, there is a strong metaphor to his stories. In my opinion, "The Scythe" is about fate. It's also about God and Man. Drew holds the fate of many in his hands. The Scythe is his tool. And with the scythe constantly cutting and

cutting and cutting, people meet their fate, dying, dying and dying. To go a little deeper it could also resemble the plot of population control. In the story, if Drew stops working, the lives of others hang on longer than fate would originally allow. Symbolism Contains some biblical references 📖 In The Scythe there started a fire in the house. Inside there were people – man's wife Molly and their two children. They were sleeping and when the man rescued them from the house, nothing bad happened to them. This episode can be compared to an episode which we can find in the Old Testament in the book of Prophet Daniel. It is the story of three men – Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego. These men did not want to bow and worship golden image that king Nebuchadnezzar built and wanted people to worship it. These men rejected to do so because they believed in One and True God. King Nebuchadnezzar got angry, ordered the furnace to be heated seven times hotter than usual and ordered to put Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego into the furnace. But nothing bad happened to them, because they trusted in God (Daniel 3:1-90). Biblical symbols have been used by many authors and Ray Bradbury is not the exception. The symbol is characterized by a set of such properties, as associativity, anthropocentricity, emotivity, cultural determinativeness and stability, polysemy, and contextual conditionality. In The Scythe the wheat represents living people and when the man cuts it, people are dying. In the Bible we can find many symbols and many passages where wheat is mentioned as symbol of something. The wheat in the Bible is connected with the end of the world (Matthew 3:12) or it is used as a parable for faith (John 12:24). Deformation of citations leads to its complete transition into the Biblical allusion and is accompanied by the antithesis, paronomasia and repetitions (Чепрак 2004: 12-13), like, e.g., in the short story The Scythe the citation "Who wields me – wields the world" can be compared or is very similar to a citation which can be found in the Bible. This citation is: "Anyone who has seen me has seen the Father." (John 14:9). Some paragraphs in The scythe by Ray Bradbury are built on the principles of logical or emotional escalation, such as: "Bombs shattered London, Moscow, Tokyo The blade swung insanely ... Bombs ruined London, ruined Moscow, ruined Tokyo." By separating sentences into separate paragraphs, the author intensifies the emotionality of the passage and builds up the tension - each stroke of the scythe took the lives of thousands of people around the world, especially during the great wars and disasters that humanity endured. The logical buildup is reinforced by the repetition of the word "the blade" (the blade/scythe). "The Scythe" is based upon the biblical allegory of the grim reaper, whose name is Death. In the allegory as well as in Bradbury's story, this reaper has absolute control over the bounds of life and death. "The Scythe," then, depicts death incarnate. Furthermore, the scythe or the sickle itself is also linked with many allegories of death. Symbolically, it carries a double meaning. First is its function of cutting, paralleling the insatiable hunger of Death. Then, the scythe is also symbolic of the hope of rebirth, indicative of the continuity of the life force. This second meaning finds substantiation in the story when new grain sprouts magically from the old. This story is one of Bradbury's earliest attempts at dealing with and ridding humanity of what he calls the "hairball" fears about death. Free from such fears, we can devote our energies to positive endeavours.

Symbolism white color, farmer's hand

Themes

Migration hunger self-respect

A clean well-lighted place

Ernest Hemingway

Title Significance

The title is significant because the old man and the older waiter both have a deep fear of the nothingness that surrounds them. The older waiter thinks that there is no meaning to life, but he still wants to cling to his dignity. He cannot do this if he allows himself to fall into the darkness. The image of the café is central to the story; we get the feeling that outside of this clean, well-lighted place, the world is nothing but chaos. Emotional darkness is the central theme of the story. It is the symbol of a meaningless life that surrounds the older waiter and the café visitor. They are victims of inner loneliness, fear, hopelessness, and "nothingness." In all this despair, they perceive the clean, well-lighted café as a refuge from the emotional darkness. The café, with its cleanliness and light, is the only oasis in the darkness of night where they can shed off their fears.

The older waiter says, *"This is a clean and pleasant cafe. It is well lighted. The light is very good."* Each word of the title has a meaning. "A" shows that it is an unspecified location. Any place can be proper and light. "Clean" stands for decency. "Well-lighted" means security. People are afraid of the darkness because it hides the unknown. But if we turn on the light, our fear leaves.

Characters

Older waiter: A compassionate man who understands why the old man may want to stay late at the café. The older waiter distinguishes himself from the younger waiter through his response to the old man—he is sympathetic and understanding of the old man's loneliness and his need to frequent a place like the café late at night. He is in no rush to close the café and reveals his problem with insomnia and makes this comment near the end of the story when he and the younger waiter are about to leave the café which reveals his own loneliness and despair *"Each night I am reluctant to close up because there may be someone who needs the café."* Until this point, the old man seemed to be the only one who wanted to stay at the café, but now the older waiter seems to need the café as well. A few lines before this, he reveals that he is someone who likes to stay at cafés late into the night, so his reluctance has two meanings. First, he understands why the old man and others may want or need to stay late, and he keeps the café open as a gesture of kindness and generosity. Second, he himself needs the café, so he is reluctant to close it because he, like the old man and others, will then be without a place to sit and wait out the night. While the younger waiter is rushing to get home, the older waiter leaves the café sadly, once again displaced and alone.

The ideas of despair and nothingness occur throughout the story, and here the older waiter's response shows that he feels he understands why the old man would try to commit suicide over "nothing"—it is nothingness that causes despair as he replies to the younger waiter's claim that he is "all confidence." *"You have youth, confidence, and a job ... You have everything"* The older waiter points out that youth and confidence may go hand in hand, and that confidence may be the quality that allows the younger waiter to ignore or reject the "nothing" that the older waiter and the old man sense is waiting for them. The younger waiter is impatient because he has a wife at home—he does not have to face the dark and seemingly endless night alone.

Younger waiter: An impatient young man who cares only about getting home to his wife. The younger waiter is usually irritated with the old man because he must stay late and serve him drinks. He does not

seem to care why the old man stays so long. His only concern is leaving as quickly as possible. The younger waiter shows little interest in the old man's life or struggles. He pays little attention or respect to the older waiter's argument as to the necessity of keeping their café open late for those who need it. He seems unable to understand the concept of loneliness that the older waiter describes. He is preoccupied with his own interests and concerns—chiefly, going home to his wife. *"He's lonely. I'm not lonely. I have a wife waiting in bed for me."* The younger waiter can't quite grasp that he, too, will be older and lonelier someday, and therefore dismisses the older waiter's argument. He reveals himself to be insensitive when he claims the old man would have been better off killing himself *"You should have killed yourself last week"*. He also shows this insensitivity when he shudders at the idea of being that old and when he describes being an older man to his older coworker as *"a nasty thing."* He doesn't recognize the luck bestowed on him by his youth.

Old man: A deaf man who likes to drink at the café late into the night. The old man likes the shadows of the leaves on the well-lit café terrace. Rumor has it that he tried to hang himself, he was once married, he has a lot of money, and his niece takes care of him. He often gets drunk at the café and leaves without paying. The old man comes to the café at night to sit in the shadow of the trees made by the electric lights. Being deaf, he enjoys sitting like this because he finds the quiet of the night relaxing. Most of what the reader learns about the old man is through the dialogue between the two waiters. A week earlier, the old man attempted suicide, but he was saved by his niece who *"cut him down."* Younger waiter ponders as to why the old man committed suicide since old man has *"plenty of money,"* Older waiter answers the younger waiter's question as to why the old man tries to commit suicide by saying *"He was in despair."* The older waiter also believes the suicide attempt was over *"nothing."* In other words, the older waiter blames the incident on the old man's despair about the meaninglessness or nothingness of life. He drinks with the purpose of getting drunk, the older waiter points out the dignified manner in which the old man does so. He *"drinks without spilling,"* and when he departs the café his steps may be unsteady, but he walks down the street with dignity.

Barman: The barman is annoyed by the older waiter and does not engage in conversation.

Themes

Ethical Conduct

Hemingway is a writer obsessed by ethical conduct. The bulk of his writing is concerned with questions of good versus bad actions. In this fiction, it's not about winning or losing, it's about how you play the game. This is true, perhaps, because in Hemingway's fictional universe one rarely wins. The title of the collection from which **"A Clean, Well-Lighted Place"** comes suggests this complicated stance. It is called Winner Take Nothing. If one has won nothing as a winner, then all one has done is played the game.

The old waiter is the epitome of someone who plays by the rules. No matter that it is a lone and drunk old man making this waiter stay up all night; the cafe offers a specific service, and is run according to certain rules from which the old waiter will not deviate. He cuts no corners in his social responsibilities. The centrality and repetitiveness of this theme in this author's oeuvre costs him popularity in many camps. Hemingway's heroes consistently detect and perform unspoken ritual, usually in trying conditions so that their upholding of these rules seems all the more admirable. These beset characters are always male, and they are usually proving themselves while pursuing very traditional male pursuits (e.g. while big-game hunting or deep-sea fishing). This self-conscious cultivation of, and propensity for, an agonistic and all-male world is immortalized in a title of another of his short story collections. Appropriately, it is called *Men Without Women*. This highly gendered world of strenuous physical and moral contest makes Hemingway's fiction seem dated in many respects.

Meaninglessness and Loneliness

The older waiter repeats the Spanish word *nada* meaning "nothing" while reciting the Lord's Prayer. This change reflects the older waiter's thought that religious belief and prayers do not provide one with meaning or solace in life. By replacing words like *God* and *heaven* with the word *nada*, he implies neither exists. He repeats the word so many times that the prayer comes to express meaninglessness.

The concern over meaninglessness is woven throughout the story, beginning when the younger waiter asks the older waiter why the old man attempts suicide. The older waiter says it was over "nothing." The older waiter understands the old man's despair over "nothing," in a way the younger waiter does not, due to his own experience. The old man is alienated from others even as he continues to frequent the café. The older waiter tries to explain to the younger waiter why a "clean, well-lighted" place like the café is necessary to offset this loneliness. To him, this sense of order in the café is the only antidote to the crisis is existential nihilism. The only meaning the old man has left is his dignity (he doesn't spill his drink, even when drunk), and the older waiter only finds meaning by working at the café, which provides those like himself with respite from their anxieties. Therefore, both of them cling to the ritual and location as an anchor to the meaninglessness they feel.

Youth versus Age

The reader is introduced to the theme of age with the character of the deaf, drunk, old man when it is revealed he tried committing suicide. The two waiters, whose age difference is not revealed until later, discuss the old man's suicide attempt, with the younger waiter asking why the old man attempted suicide—pointing out the old man has "plenty of money," and the older waiter saying it was over "nothing." The younger waiter's attitude reveals he can only make sense of the old man's despair in monetary terms, while the older waiter recognizes the larger issue at play, one he himself is familiar with. He may not be as old as the old man, but he recognizes the trajectory of loneliness. The fact that the older waiter recognizes something of himself in the old man and demonstrates compassion suggests that age brings wisdom—youth does not last forever and loneliness and the search for meaning are constant in old age once the things the aged have relied on (religion, money, or marriage) have disappeared.

The young waiter is in a hurry to get home to his wife—he has a lot of life left to live and no interest in wasting his time worrying about the old man. Yet both the old man and the older waiter seem to exist in a state of waiting since the majority of their lives have passed them by. The younger waiter brags that he is "all confidence," and the older waiter agrees he has everything—confidence, youth, a job. He himself only has a job, and therefore the clean, well-lit café gives him a sense of purpose.

Every character in the story is dissatisfied, regardless of age: the younger waiter is dissatisfied with having to stay late, the old man is dissatisfied with his life and attempts suicide, and the older waiter is dissatisfied with having to close up the café and go home. Ernest Hemingway suggests that this sense of dissatisfaction occurs regardless of one's age. Although the story's conflicts appear to be among the characters, the dialogue regarding youth, aging, and one's sense of mortality reveal a larger conflict.

Futility of Modern Society

Despite indications the story takes place in affluent modern society—the café is well-lit and the old man has money—the characters struggle with futility and try to steel themselves against it. The two waiters discuss the old man's failed attempt at suicide, revealing the old man has money and once had a wife. The younger waiter accepts the older waiter's claim that the old man tried to kill himself over "nothing." This acceptance suggests something has not gone according to the plan and promise of modern society where

materialism has replaced religion as a purported means of comfort. Money and status do not provide happiness and contentment. The older waiter and the old man find more comfort in the existence of a clean, well-lighted café to inhabit than in prayer recitation.

The Unknowable and Nothingness

“Nothing,” or the Spanish equivalent “nada,” is the most important word in this short story—if only by virtue of the high number of times it is repeated in a story so very brief. It is the reason why the old man kills himself, according to the older waiter: “‘Last week he tried to commit suicide,’ one waiter said.”/ “‘Why?’”/ “‘He was in despair.’”/ “‘What about?’”/ “‘Nothing.’”/ “‘How do you know it was nothing?’”/ “‘He has plenty of money.’” It is the word which obsesses the old waiter as well. After work, he leans against a bar and recites two prayers to himself substituting “nada” for most of the prayer’s major verbs and nouns. The result is a litany of “nadas.”

This narrative pattern suggests at least two possible explanations. The first follows from considering the character of the older waiter. The waiter is a man of few words, an elemental soul. He is face to face with humanity itself under duress, what he identifies as “despair,” and attributes the cause of this despair to be “nothing.” This paradox of believing in an emotion (despair) with no cause (“Nothing”) is unraveled if one decides that with “nothing” the waiter refers to intangible yearnings, as opposed to referring to bodily or material yearnings (“He has plenty of money”). In this case, he exemplifies a stance which does not presume to fathom the mysteries of life (intangible yearnings), but prefers to stand before them mute. “Nothing” has become his way of indicating the mystery of humanity and his own professed conceptual and verbal limitations when faced with it. Thus, this old waiter might be elemental or simple, but it is this simplicity that makes him wise. He is not afraid of admitting that the task of explaining humanity is beyond him, and his manner of speaking indicates this humble stance.

A second explanation follows from taking the old waiter’s answer (“Nothing”) to mean that the old man, at least in his opinion, is in despair over the fact that his life means “nothing.” This can be linked, for example, to the old waiter later thinking, “It was all a nothing and a man was nothing too.” In this case, despair follows from a belief in the inherent meaningless or absurdity of life. If one suffers one does so for no reason; it does not matter if one lives or dies. This is why despair is over nothing if one has “plenty of money.” In this world view, there is no meaning beyond the bodily and material; all intangible yearnings are nothing but illusion. If the old man does not sink into nihilism because of this bleak knowledge, it is because of his ethical bylaws and his ability to revel in the physical present: “It was all a nothing and a man was nothing too. It was only that and light was all it needed and a certain cleanness and order.” In the view above, however, this reveling in “light . . . [and] a certain cleanness and order” would indicate a certain blind, dumb faith. One’s environment gives one proof of some “order” or meaning, it is simply that this meaning will never be known, expressible, or representable by mere human beings.

Dissatisfaction

Unhappiness, discontent, or just plain everyday life – call it what you will, dissatisfaction is a pretty universal theme in the works of Mr. Ernest Hemingway. In “A Clean, Well-Lighted Place,” Hemingway offers a fairly pessimistic view of the world, suggesting that even people who are young, happy, and totally content will someday end up lonely, drunk, and dissatisfied. By showing us three characters in different

stages of life (young, middle aged, and elderly), Hemingway depicts the way in which life grows increasingly unsatisfactory, until the only viable options are suicide or drunkenness. Depressing.

Life as Nothingness

In “A Clean, Well-Lighted Place,” Hemingway suggests that life has no meaning and that man is an insignificant speck in a great sea of nothingness. The older waiter makes this idea as clear as he can when he says, “It was all a nothing and man was a nothing too.” When he substitutes the Spanish word *nada* (*nothing*) into the prayers he recites, he indicates that religion, to which many people turn to find meaning and purpose, is also just nothingness. Rather than pray with the actual words, “Our Father who art in heaven,” the older waiter says, “Our *nada* who art in *nada*”—effectively wiping out both God and the idea of heaven in one breath. Not everyone is aware of the nothingness, however. For example, the younger waiter hurtles through his life hastily and happily, unaware of any reason why he should lament. For the old man, the older waiter, and the other people who need late-night cafés, however, the idea of nothingness is overwhelming and leads to despair.

The Struggle to Deal with Despair

The old man and older waiter in “A Clean, Well-Lighted Place” struggle to find a way to deal with their despair, but even their best method simply subdues the despair rather than cures it. The old man has tried to stave off despair in several unsuccessful ways. We learn that he has money, but money has not helped. We learn that he was once married, but he no longer has a wife. We also learn that he has unsuccessfully tried to commit suicide in a desperate attempt to quell the despair for good. The only way the old man can deal with his despair now is to sit for hours in a clean, well-lit café. Deaf, he can feel the quietness of the nighttime and the café, and although he is essentially in his own private world, sitting by himself in the café is not the same as being alone.

The older waiter, in his mocking prayers filled with the word *nada*, shows that religion is not a viable method of dealing with despair, and his solution is the same as the old man’s: he waits out the nighttime in cafés. He is particular about the type of café he likes: the café must be well lit and clean. Bars and bodegas, although many are open all night, do not lessen despair because they are not clean, and patrons often must stand at the bar rather than sit at a table. The old man and the older waiter also glean solace from routine. The ritualistic café-sitting and drinking helps them deal with despair because it makes life predictable. Routine is something they can control and manage, unlike the vast nothingness that surrounds them.

My Oedipus Complex

Frank O Connor

Title Significance

The title of Frank O'Connor's story “My Oedipus Complex” has its roots in ancient Greek literature and the psychoanalytic theories of Sigmund Freud. As the title suggests, the story’s preoccupation lies in Sigmund Freud’s renowned Psychoanalytic theory about the “Oedipus Complex” that derives its name from the Greek king Oedipus of Thebes. His story is most famously told in Sophocles's play Oedipus Rex who unknowingly kills his father and marries his mother. *Interpretation of Dreams* (1899) first mentions this

theory that revolves around a desire for the parent of the opposite sex which may or may not be sexual along with a sense of envy for the parent of the same sex. We can see, then, why the title is appropriate for O'Connor's story, which depicts Larry's attachment to his mother and dislike of his father. The story is narrated by a first-person child narrator Larry but the past tense of the narrative lends the possibility of the plot to be a retrospective act of writing by the author who shares similarities with the child protagonist. The awareness of Larry about his Oedipus complex also supports the claim in the previous sentence as an understanding of psychoanalytic theory is farfetched for a young boy.

Themes

CHILDHOOD AND OEDIPUS COMPLEX – A child needs both a mother and a father to develop fully and learn about life. But when either of them is absent, a child naturally inclines more towards the present one. Larry has spent all his life up till the age of five with his mother. There are no friends who he can address as companions except his mother. At his age, the development of the Oedipus complex is natural and crucial to his growth. Apart from the title, there are multiple instances that lend insight into his feelings concerning both his parents that exemplify the complex.

- He *"disliked her looking anxious, because it destroyed her good looks,"*
- *"saw nothing to be pleased about [his father] because out of uniform, Father was altogether less interesting, but she only beamed,"*
- affirms *"either Father or I would have to leave the house,"*
- wishes *"to be treated as an equal"* in his home and lastly,
- proclaims to his mother *"I'm going to marry you."*

Towards the end, after the arrival of his younger brother Sonny, Larry again experiences avoidance as he does upon his father's arrival but *instead of being a swollen child who desires to pamper, he comforts his father who is in a similar state*, thus evidencing his initiation towards maturity.

NEXUS BETWEEN POLITICS, RELIGION AND ECONOMY – O' Connor builds a link between the three key facets of society- *Politics, Religion and Economy i]n the backdrop of the First World War.* The foremost contention is about the *nature and occurrence of wars* which are not an execution of wrath by the almighty but the dirty politics of *"bad people"* as the mother explains to Larry. This revelation dispels his belief in the power of God as he *"began to think that God wasn't quite what He was cracked up to be."* As a religious practice, families of the soldiers pray for the well-being and safe return of the soldiers of the war which Larry and his mother do as well by listening to *"Mass at St. Augustine's"* and saying *"a prayer for Father."*

Every war has its repercussions and Larry's family suffers from an *economic crisis as a result of its ending.* Since the soldiers are no more employed, the *source of income hits a dead end.* Larry's mother received money to run the household from his father's salary that she used to collect from the post office. She explains to Larry that his *father is stressed* due to his unemployment which might compel them to beg *"like the poor old woman on Fridays"* which obviously he would not like to. *The notion of finances arrives at the scene in Larry's conception of babies coming into a family as a transaction requiring pennies.* He alludes to a family in their neighbor who has a baby despite their poor economic condition and wishes his mother to bring a baby too for him that does not cost *"seventeen and six"* which does happen, only through a procedure inconceivable for a child of his age.

COMING OF AGE: Before beginning his slow coming of age, Larry lives in a state of childish ignorance. When mentioning his father's visits home during wartime, Larry remarks, *"Like Santa Claus he came and went mysteriously."* Not only does *Larry believe in Santa Claus,* but he is also at a stage in life in which

much of the world is still unknown to him—including the gravity of his father’s occupation as a soldier. Larry also shows his naiveté when **he expresses his desire for the family to have a baby**. He remarks that a baby would *“brighten the home”* (as if it were simply décor rather than a life-changing responsibility) and then suggests that **families obtain babies by purchasing them**, which shows his profound innocence of human reproduction. Furthermore, Larry’s interests are characteristic of his age (“trams, ships, and horses”), and **he cannot fathom why his father would not be equally interested in them**. *“I had never met anyone so absorbed in himself as he seemed,”* Larry says of his father’s interest in adult things like talking to men his own age. The irony of this is lost on Larry, as he is acting incredibly self-absorbed by expecting his father to tailor his interests to suit his five-year-old son’s.

However, as he adapts to his father’s presence, Larry begins to see the world in a more complex way. In **a surprising act of maturity**, Larry reacts to this by vowing to do his best not to jeopardize his family’s finances, showing him taking responsibility for his part in the family. As Larry sheds his childhood innocence, **he also expects his parents to treat him as a mature person**. While he doesn’t register much objection to punishments earlier in the story, the first time **his father spans him, he considers it to be an indignity to which he should no longer be subjected**. In addition, when his father brings tea for himself and his mother but none for Larry, Larry feels that he, too, should have a cup, since he wants to be *“treated as an equal in my own home.”* Of course, Larry is not an equal—he is a child—but his increasing demands for respect and consideration show him growing up.

CONFLICT BETWEEN FATHER AND SON: Larry’s relationship to his father seems to mirror Freud’s theory, since Larry wants all of his beloved mother’s attention, and when his father returns from war, Larry despises him for taking up her time and affection. He *“was prepared to compete with him any time for Mother’s attention,”* **However, Larry’s fixation on his father and his anguish over his father’s indifference to him suggests that their conflict is not simply over Larry’s mother—it’s also rooted in Larry’s desire for his father’s love.**

While Larry’s mother seems to be the most important person in his life, **O’Connor depicts Larry’s father’s presence and absence as uniquely powerful**. For example, while the story’s first section describes Larry’s blissful wartime experience of being alone with his mother, O’Connor begins with the word “Father” and introduces Larry’s relationship to his mother through recollections of his father’s absence from the home. In this way, **Larry’s affection for his mother is shown to be inextricable from his awareness of his father**—even though his father isn’t often physically there. Although Larry ostensibly loves his mother and hates his father, **his narration shows him to be equally obsessed with both parents**—and perhaps even more obsessed with his father. For example, when he and his father walk into town and his father ignores him, it makes Larry so frustrated that he wants to cry. **This emotional reaction seems more severe than the simple anger or irritation he shows whenever his mother shushes him or ignores him**. Getting teary over his father’s indifference therefore suggests a unique investment in earning his father’s attention.

Characters

LARRY – He is the child narrator of the story who yearns for his mother’s affection after the arrival of his father from the war. Unlike children of his age, he cherishes spending time with his mother and views his father and later his younger brother Sonny as competitors. Larry wryly notes of his early childhood, before his father’s return, *“The war was the most peaceful period of my life. . . . Life never seemed so simple and clear and full of possibilities as then.”* His display of an innocent conviction about how babies arrive in this world and God’s way to keep his father safe. He also assumes God to be a medium that can call his father back at war and in a humorously satirical comment pins out his doubts concerning God’s potential after learning humans to be the main cause of the wars.

There is also a little rebel inside himself that unleashes occasionally through kicks at his father and intentional pinches at his baby brother. He is a lonely child longing for companionship after his mother divides her attention between him and the other two males in the house. The only place of solace he can access is his **imagination where he mirrors his problems through fictional characters Mrs. Left and Right.** Though he still harbors distant and vengeful feelings for his father, towards the end, he becomes a comforter to him as the positions switch for his father who now experiences avoidance like Larry in the earlier parts of the story.

MOTHER – She is a **caring and doting mother who loves her son Larry and spends most of her time with him during her husband's absence.** However, she becomes a subject of competition between the two men who compete for her attention. Her efforts to please them both and maintain peace are evidence in ensuring **Larry is silent while his father is asleep and letting her son sleep next to her despite the possible chances of disruption he might provide to her husband.** She is always careful around her husband to not evoke his anger and frustration which are an outcome of economic liabilities the family has to bear after the war years. **In conclusion, she is a typical woman who resides a deep faith in God and her prayers while making sure to be a good wife and** a good mother to both her sons even though her husband and Larry despise her ignorance towards them towards the end.

FATHER – He is a soldier who returns from the First World War and comes across as a **distant, distracted and troubled man.** The aftermath of the war floods him and his family with financial troubles as well as fragments his psyche which is characteristic of a man in the 20th century. **He owns war souvenirs and treasures them at the top of his cupboard.** His constant agitating demeanor compels his wife to be patient and pleasing towards him in order to avoid infuriating him. He is unlike other fathers who miss their children during their stay away in the war camps. **Cold and authoritative, his detachment from Larry and a presumption of him as a competitor for his wife's attention are realized in his inhumane remarks to his own son as a "puppy" and "he wants his bottom smacked."** But after the arrival of his second son, situations alter and he transforms his behavior towards Larry with its bitter-sweet eccentricities the story culminates with him gifting his first born a model railway for Christmas.

SONNY – He is the newborn sibling to Larry who becomes the center of attraction for his mother and in Larry and his father's view consumes her completely. **He is envied by the other two males** in the house and becomes a rekindling force the otherwise estranged father and son.

Pleasure of Reading

Viscount Grey

"The Pleasure of Reading" is an essay written by Viscount Grey of Fallodon, **a British statesman and author, in the early 20th century** and the main force behind British foreign policy in the era of the First World War.

The essay explores the **joys of reading and its value as a means of personal growth and education.** In the essay, Grey begins by asserting that reading is one of the most rewarding and pleasurable activities a person can engage in. He argues that reading allows individuals to expand their horizons and gain knowledge about the world, as well as develop their imaginations and creative thinking abilities. Grey also emphasizes the importance of reading as a means of personal growth

and education, arguing that it can help individuals develop critical thinking skills and gain new insights into themselves and others.

Throughout the essay, Grey provides numerous examples of how reading has enriched his own life and helped him better understand the world around him. He discusses the importance of reading literature, history, philosophy, and other subjects, and emphasizes that reading should be a lifelong pursuit.

One of the key themes of Grey's essay is the importance of reading as a means of cultivating empathy and understanding towards others. He argues that reading allows individuals to gain insight into the perspectives and experiences of people from different backgrounds and cultures, and helps foster a sense of empathy and compassion towards others.

Overall, Viscount Grey's essay is a thoughtful and engaging exploration of the pleasures and value of reading. His arguments for the importance of reading as a means of personal growth and education, as well as a tool for developing empathy and understanding towards others, continue to resonate with readers today.

The pleasure of reading is an essay which is a part of project "recreation" initiated by Viscount Grey. While he was primarily known for his contributions to foreign policy, he was also an avid reader and writer. In his essay titled "The Pleasure of Reading," Grey shares his thoughts on the joys and benefits of reading.

Viscount Grey's essay is divided into several sections, each of which focuses on a different aspect of the pleasure of reading. In the first section, Grey argues that reading is a source of intellectual and emotional stimulation that can provide a deep sense of satisfaction and fulfillment. He notes that reading can stimulate the imagination and inspire creativity, and that it can also provide a sense of escape from the pressures of daily life.

In the second section, Grey explores the role of reading in personal growth and education. He argues that reading allows individuals to expand their knowledge and understanding of the world, and can help them develop critical thinking skills and gain new insights into themselves and others. Grey also notes that reading can help individuals develop their own sense of values and ethics, and can provide them with a framework for understanding the world and their place in it.

In the third section of the essay, Grey discusses the importance of reading as a means of developing empathy and understanding towards others. He argues that reading can help individuals gain insight into the perspectives and experiences of people from different cultures and backgrounds, and can help foster a sense of compassion and empathy towards others.

Throughout the essay, Grey provides numerous examples of how reading has enriched his own life, and he emphasizes the importance of reading as a lifelong pursuit. He also notes that the

pleasures of reading are not limited to any particular genre or subject, and encourages readers to explore a wide variety of literature and other written works.

Overall, Viscount Grey's essay provides a thoughtful and insightful exploration of the pleasures and value of reading. His arguments for the importance of reading as a means of personal growth and education, as well as a tool for developing empathy and understanding towards others, remain relevant and compelling today.

Analysis

Viscount Grey's essay "The Pleasure of Reading" is a compelling argument for the importance of reading as a source of enjoyment and personal development. Throughout the essay, Grey supports his arguments and demonstrates the benefits of reading. One of the key points that Grey makes in his essay is that reading allows us to escape from the world around us and to immerse ourselves in other worlds and other perspectives. He writes, *"To the reader, the world is always full of interest, variety, and delight, and he is never alone."* Here, Grey is suggesting that reading is a form of companionship, a way to connect with others and to feel less isolated. Grey also argues that reading is essential for personal development and self-improvement. He writes, *"Reading not only furnishes the mind with knowledge, but it disciplines it, strengthens it, and enlarges its powers".*

This idea is supported by his reference to the famous philosopher John Locke, who believed that reading was essential for developing a well-rounded and thoughtful mind. Another key point that Grey makes is that reading allows us to explore and expand our imaginations. He writes, *"The power of imagination, so essential to happiness, is developed by reading".* This is an important point, as it suggests that reading is not just a passive activity, but one that requires active engagement and participation on the part of the reader. Throughout his essay, Grey draws on a variety of textual references to support his arguments. For example, he references the works of great authors such as Shakespeare, Milton, and Wordsworth, suggesting that their writings are a testament to the power and importance of reading. He also cites the opinions of other notable figures, such as the historian Edward Gibbon, to support his arguments about the benefits of reading.

Viscount Grey highlights the universality of reading as a means of connecting with people from different cultures and time periods. He argues that reading allows us to understand and appreciate different perspectives and experiences, and to develop empathy and understanding for others. Grey also touches on the importance of reading for developing critical thinking skills. He writes, *"The reader who reads wisely and discriminately will form judgments and opinions for himself, and will learn to distinguish between what is good and what is bad".* Here, he is suggesting that reading is not just about passive absorption of information, but about actively engaging with the text and evaluating its contents. Throughout the essay, Grey emphasizes the importance of reading for pleasure, rather than solely for educational or practical purposes. He writes, *"Reading for pleasure is the most perfect school of all, and the happiest way of acquiring*

knowledge". This point underscores the idea that reading should be a joyful and fulfilling activity, rather than one that is solely driven by external expectations or goals.

Overall, Viscount Grey's essay "The Pleasure of Reading" is a compelling argument for the importance of reading in our lives. Through his use of textual references and persuasive arguments, Grey highlights the benefits of reading for personal growth, imagination, empathy, critical thinking, and pleasure. His essay is a powerful reminder of the value of reading, and encourages us to continue to make it a priority in our lives. According to Grey, reading is not just a way to gain knowledge, but also a source of great pleasure. He believes that reading allows us to escape from the mundane realities of life and enter into a world of imagination and creativity. Through books, we can experience different cultures, times, and perspectives, which can broaden our understanding of the world and enhance our empathy for others. He chose this name because on the one hand he wanted to bring everything to light and on the other hand he wanted to get the attention of those who started taking light of him. The Viscount speaks of two types of people: those who understand the importance of reading and enjoy it, and those who do not have the time due to worldly affairs. "If they do not do so they will lose one of the greatest resources and one of the most precious recreations of life". The author argues that reading is an essential part of human development and is something that can be enjoyed by people of all ages. One of the main themes of the essay is the idea that reading is a form of escape.

According to Grey, reading allows people to transport themselves to other places and experience things that they may not otherwise be able to. He argues that this ability to escape is what makes reading such a valuable tool for personal growth and development. Another important aspect of the essay is Grey's emphasis on the importance of reading for children. He believes that early exposure to books and literature can help children develop their imagination, expand their vocabulary, and cultivate a lifelong love of learning. He also notes that reading can help children develop empathy and understanding for others, as they explore different perspectives and experiences.

Throughout the essay, Grey emphasizes the importance of choosing quality literature and reading with intention. He argues that reading should be an active process, and encourages readers to engage with the text, make connections, and form opinions. He also notes that reading can be a powerful tool for personal reflection and self-improvement.

In conclusion, "The Pleasure of Reading" is a persuasive essay that extols the many benefits of reading. The author emphasizes the importance of reading for personal growth and development, and argues that it is an essential part of human experience. Overall, Grey's essay encourages readers to embrace and enjoy the pleasures of reading, emphasizing the transformative power of literature. His essay serves as a powerful reminder of the value and pleasure of reading, and encourages us to continue to make it a central part of our lives.

Themes

In his essay "The Pleasure of Reading," Viscount Grey discusses several themes related to the joy of reading. Some of the themes he touches upon include:

The Importance of Reading: Grey argues that reading is an essential aspect of personal growth and development. He believes that reading allows individuals to explore new ideas, perspectives, and experiences that they may not encounter otherwise.

The power of imagination: Viscount Grey emphasizes the power of books to spark our imagination and take us on journeys to new and exciting places. He writes, "There is a magic in books, a charm that never fades, and the power to transport us into a world of beauty and wonder. The imagination is awakened, the mind expands, and we are transported into a new and delightful world."

The benefits of reading for personal growth: Grey argues that reading can help us grow as individuals and expand our understanding of the world. He states, "Reading gives us an insight into the minds of others and enables us to think for ourselves. "It broadens our horizons and deepens our understanding of the world around us."

The importance of reading as a form of entertainment: Grey stresses that reading should be viewed as a form of entertainment that can bring joy and pleasure into our lives. He writes, "Reading is the most delightful of all pastimes. It is an inexhaustible source of amusement and instruction."

The diversity of literature: Grey celebrates the diversity of literature and the many different genres and types of books that are available. He notes, "There is no end to the variety of literature, and there is something to suit every taste. From the great classics to the latest bestsellers, from fiction to non-fiction, from poetry to prose, there is a wealth of material waiting to be discovered".

The value of reading for education: Grey emphasizes the value of reading as a means of education and self-improvement. He writes, "Books are the great teachers of the world, and reading is the best form of education. Through books, we can learn about history, science, philosophy, and art, and we can gain a deeper understanding of ourselves and our place in the world."

The role of reading in shaping our values: Grey argues that reading can help shape our values and beliefs, and that it can inspire us to lead better lives. He notes, "Good books are a source of moral guidance and spiritual inspiration, and they have the power to transform our lives. They can inspire us to be better people, to live more meaningful lives, and to make a positive difference in the world."

The joy of discovering new authors and books: Grey celebrates the joy of discovering new authors and books, and he encourages readers to be open to exploring new genres and styles. He writes, "The pleasure of reading is not just in the content of the book, but also in the discovery of new authors, new styles, and new ways of looking at the world. Every book is a new adventure, and every author has something unique to offer."

Escapism: Grey notes that one of the pleasures of reading is the ability to transport oneself to different places and explore different worlds. He argues that reading is a form of escapism, allowing individuals to briefly forget about their everyday lives and immerse themselves in a story.

Childhood Education: Grey emphasizes the importance of early exposure to literature in childhood. He believes that reading can help develop a child's imagination, vocabulary, and empathy, and can instill a lifelong love of learning.

Active Reading: Grey encourages readers to engage with the text actively. He argues that reading should be an active process that involves making connections, forming opinions, and critically analyzing the material.

Self-improvement: Grey notes that reading can be a powerful tool for self-reflection and personal growth. He argues that literature can help individuals gain a better understanding of themselves and others, and can provide insights into the human experience.

Literary devices

In "The Pleasure of Reading," Viscount Grey uses several literary devices to convey his message about the importance and enjoyment of reading. Here are some examples with textual references:

Metaphor: "The books we read are the accumulated wisdom and experience of the race."

Allusion: "We enter into the thoughts of great men and women of all ages and of all countries, and share their emotions and aspirations."

Personification: "Books are our best friends, our constant companions, and our wisest advisers."

Hyperbole: "We can travel through time and space, visit foreign lands and different ages, and see the world through the eyes of others."

Repetition: "The pleasure of reading is infinite, because there is always something new to discover."

Anaphora: "Reading is not only a source of pleasure, but also a means of acquiring knowledge."

Imagery: "We are transported to other worlds and other lives, and see things we could never see in our own experience."

Simile: "Reading is like a mental gymnastic, which strengthens and invigorates the mind."

Irony: "A great book is a masterpiece of human thought and feeling, which cannot be appreciated by the illiterate or the superficial reader."

Alliteration: "We wander through the wilderness of thought, and find flowers and fruits in the most unexpected places."

Antithesis: "We rise from the contemplation of our own little lives to the heights of wisdom and the depths of pathos."

Symbolism: "A book is a magic carpet, which carries us away from the commonplace realities of life to the enchanted realms of imagination."

Metonymy: "Books are the keys to the treasure-house of human knowledge, the golden gates of the palace of truth."

Overall, Viscount Grey's use of literary devices helps to convey his argument in a compelling and persuasive way, making his essay a pleasure to read. These literary devices not only add depth and richness to Viscount Grey's essay, but also help to engage the reader and emphasize the importance and pleasure of reading

Literary value

"The Pleasure of Reading" by Viscount Grey is a highly commendable essay of literary value. The essay offers a rich, engaging, and persuasive discussion of the pleasure and benefits of reading. It provides insightful observations about reading as a source of personal growth, intellectual exploration, and cultural exchange. Grey's writing style is clear, persuasive, and informative. He uses a logical structure and persuasive language to articulate his arguments effectively. The essay draws support from noteworthy examples and quotations from various literary sources, such as Virgil, Shakespeare, and Milton, which demonstrate Grey's familiarity with classic literature. Additionally, the essay's themes are relevant, timeless and engaging. It not only emphasizes the importance of reading but also highlights the role of literature in promoting empathy, understanding, and intellectual curiosity. The essay offers valuable insights on how to approach reading actively and how to choose valuable and quality literature.

In conclusion, "The Pleasure of Reading" by Viscount Grey is a splendid example of an excellent essay of literary value. Its lucid and engaging prose, persuasive arguments, and relevant themes make it an exemplary and enduring piece that would interest any reader who appreciates the pleasures of reading and exploration of the intellect through works of literature.

Language and Technique

"Essay on the Pleasure of Reading" by Viscount Grey is a relatively short and straightforward piece of writing that employs various language and techniques to express the author's ideas about the benefits and joys of reading. Some of the key language and techniques used in the essay include:

Persuasive language: Viscount Grey uses persuasive language throughout the essay to convince readers of the value of reading. He uses emotive language and powerful metaphors to convey his enthusiasm for books and reading.

Figurative language: The essay includes several examples of figurative language, such as metaphors, similes, and personification. These techniques are used to create vivid and engaging images that help to bring the author's ideas to life.

Anecdotes: Viscount Grey uses anecdotes from his own life to illustrate the joys and benefits of reading. For example, he describes how he first discovered the joys of reading as a child and how it has enriched his life ever since. Viscount Grey includes personal anecdotes to support his arguments and to add a human touch to his writing.

Quotations: The essay includes several quotations from famous authors and thinkers to support the author's arguments. These quotes add weight and authority to the author's points and demonstrate his knowledge of literature. Viscount Grey uses quotations from literary works to support his arguments and to illustrate his points. This shows that he has read widely and is able to draw on a range of sources to support his ideas.

Rhetorical questions: The essay includes several rhetorical questions, which are used to engage readers and encourage them to think about the importance of reading. For example, the author asks, "What other pastime can compare with reading, when it comes to broadening our minds and enriching our souls?" For example, he asks "What is it that makes a book interesting?" and "What is the value of reading?" These questions prompt the reader to reflect on their own experiences and opinions.

Repetition: Viscount Grey uses repetition to emphasize the importance of reading. He repeats the phrase "reading is a pleasure" throughout the essay, which reinforces his central argument and makes it more memorable.

Contrast: The author uses contrast to highlight the difference between reading and other forms of entertainment. For example, he contrasts the passive nature of watching television with the active engagement required for reading.

Imagery: Viscount Grey uses vivid imagery to describe the pleasures of reading, such as the "magic carpet ride" that a good book can take you on or the feeling of being transported to another world.

Allusion: The essay includes several literary allusions, which are references to other works of literature. For example, the author alludes to Shakespeare's Hamlet when he describes the way that reading can make us more aware of the "slings and arrows of outrageous fortune."

Personal voice: The author's personal voice comes through in the essay, as he shares his own experiences and opinions about reading. This helps to create a connection with the reader and makes the essay more engaging.

Overall, Viscount Grey's use of language and techniques in "Essay on the Pleasure of Reading" helps to convey his love of literature and his belief in its transformative power. His persuasive arguments and engaging writing style make a compelling case for the importance of reading in our lives. He uses a range of language and techniques to convey the importance and joy of reading.

Style

Viscount Grey's essay "The Pleasure of Reading" is written in a formal and academic style, which is appropriate for an essay on literature. The following are some of the stylistic features used by Viscount Grey in this essay:

Formal Language: The language used in the essay is formal and academic, with a lot of complex sentence structures, precise vocabulary, and advanced grammatical structures. This is typical of an essay written for an academic audience.

Literary References: Viscount Grey refers to several literary works throughout the essay to support his arguments. He also discusses the themes and characters of these works in detail, demonstrating his knowledge and understanding of literature.

Use of Metaphors: Viscount Grey uses metaphors to convey his ideas in a vivid and memorable way. For example, he describes reading as a "pleasure boat" that takes us on a journey of the mind, and as a "lamp" that illuminates the dark corners of our consciousness.

Formal Structure: The essay follows a formal structure, with a clear introduction, body paragraphs that develop the main arguments, and a conclusion that summarizes the main points. The paragraphs are well-organized and flow smoothly from one to the next.

Use of Transitions: Viscount Grey uses transitions to link ideas and to guide the reader through the essay. He uses phrases such as "furthermore", "in addition", and "moreover" to signal that he is moving on to a new point.

Use of Formal Tone: The essay is written in a formal tone, which is appropriate for an academic essay. Viscount Grey avoids using slang, colloquialisms, or informal language, and instead uses precise and clear language throughout.

Use of Evidence: Viscount Grey uses evidence from literary works, as well as from historical and cultural sources, to support his arguments. He draws on a range of examples to illustrate his points, demonstrating his knowledge and understanding of the subject matter.

Overall, Viscount Grey's essay is characterized by its formal and academic style, its use of literary references and evidence, and its focus on argumentation and analysis. It is a well-structured and engaging essay that offers insights into the pleasures and value of reading.

Literary Criticism

Viscount Grey's essay "The Pleasure of Reading" has been widely acclaimed and celebrated as a classic essay on the joys of reading. However, like any other work of literature, there have been some criticisms of the essay. One common criticism is that the essay is elitist and snobbish in its approach to reading. Some readers argue that the essay seems to suggest that only certain types of literature are worth reading, and that those who do not share Grey's tastes are somehow inferior. This elitist attitude is evident in passages such as: "There are books which we read with pleasure, but they do not affect us or teach us anything," which some readers interpret as a dismissal of popular literature and an endorsement of highbrow culture. Another criticism of the essay is that it is overly romanticized and idealistic in its depiction of the joys of reading. Some readers argue that Grey's portrayal of reading as a pure and unadulterated pleasure ignores the complex and often messy reality of reading, which can involve difficult and challenging texts, as well as conflicting emotions and responses. Additionally, some readers argue that Grey's emphasis on the aesthetic and spiritual aspects of reading overlooks the social and political dimensions of literature, and the role that reading can play in promoting social justice and activism. Finally, some readers criticize Grey's essay for its lack of diversity and inclusivity. The essay is written from a very particular perspective, that of a white, male, English aristocrat living in the early 20th century. As such, the essay reflects the biases and prejudices of its time and place, and does not take into account the experiences and perspectives of readers from different backgrounds and cultures. Some readers argue that a more inclusive and diverse vision of the pleasures of reading is needed, one that acknowledges the richness and variety of human experience and the many different ways in which reading can be meaningful and transformative.

Conclusion

Viscount Grey's essay "The Pleasure of Reading" is a short and straightforward piece of writing that highlights the benefits of reading. Although it is not a literary work in the traditional sense, it can be analyzed from a literary criticism perspective. One approach to analyzing this essay is through the lens of reader-response criticism. This approach focuses on how readers interpret and respond to a literary work. In this case, the essay is not a work of fiction, but it can still be analyzed in terms of how readers respond to its message. For example, readers might react positively to the idea that reading can provide intellectual stimulation and broaden one's perspective. Alternatively, readers might disagree with the notion that reading is always pleasurable, as some literature can be difficult or challenging to read. Another approach to analyzing this essay is through the lens of historical criticism. This approach examines a work of literature in the context of the time period in which it was written. In the case of Viscount Grey's essay, it was published in the early 20th century, a time when literacy rates were increasing and the availability of books was expanding. Grey's argument that reading can be a source of pleasure and self-improvement would have resonated with many readers at the time. However, it is also important to note that access to books was not equal, and certain segments of the population, such as women and people of color, faced barriers to reading. Finally, a Marxist reading of the

essay could also be considered. Marxist literary criticism focuses on the relationship between literature and class struggle. In the case of Grey's essay, one could argue that his argument that reading can lead to self-improvement reinforces the idea of social mobility through education. This idea, however, could be seen as problematic as it suggests that individual effort is the key to success, rather than systemic change.

Work

Bertrand Russell

Bertrand Russell was a

- British Logician,
- philosopher,
- historian,
- mathematician,
- essayist,
- writer,
- political activist,
- social critic, and
- Nobel laureate.

Russell regarded himself as a socialist, pacifist, and social activist; however, he was highly skeptical. In the early decades of the 20th century, Russell initiated and directed the revolt against idealism in the English language. He is regarded as a premier logician of the 20th century. He wrote *Principia Mathematica* with A. N. Whitehead. He wrote the philosophical essay "On Denoting," which is regarded as a paradigm of philosophy.

Russell's contributions to logic, epistemology, and the philosophy of mathematics established him as one of the foremost philosophers of the 20th century. To the general public, however, he was best known as a campaigner for peace and as a popular writer on social, political, and moral subjects. During a long, productive, and often turbulent life, he published more than 70 books and about 2,000 articles, married four times, became involved in innumerable public controversies, and was honored and reviled in almost equal measure throughout the world.

Bertrand Russell is a prolific prose writer. He wrote abundant works. He is one of the prominent writers of the 20th century who wrote on the diverse subjects of human interest. He devoted his works to deal with the problems of philosophy, morality, ethics, social life, politics, economics, and many more. He greatly impressed the critics and readers with his literary qualities. He has rich knowledge, and his opinions are honest; there is hardly any issue or human subject that is not touched by Russell.

Russell writes systematically on his subjects under discussion. This method was quite successful. He communicated his ideas, wit, and power of writing in a unique, influential, and logical style.

He always states clear thoughts in a pure, lucid, and transparent style. Therefore, not only his subject matter was transformed but also his mode of expression. His charming style was developed through his neatness of expressions and clarity of thought, thus leaves permanent imprints on the mind of the reader.

Major points discussed:

- **Advantages of work**
 1. Work saves from boredom
 2. Work gives chances of success and opportunities for ambition.
- **Housewives vs. working women**
- **Hierarchy of interesting work (Low to High)**
 1. Exercise of skill
 2. Constructiveness (Construction vs. Destruction)
- **Satisfaction from work**
- **Art vs. science**
- **Happiness vs. unhappiness**
- **Compulsive Work**
- **Viewing life as a whole**

Summary

Bertrand Russell divides work into two categories. One is interesting and the other is uninteresting work. Interesting work is source of great pleasure but uninteresting work is also desirable. Uninteresting work creates many problems but is less painful than idleness. It might be troublesome but it is less agonizing than being without a job. It keeps us busy and active. It provides us relief from boredom. It makes holidays enjoyable. More work brings more income and hence enhances our standard of life. It makes us to enjoy holidays. If there had been no work we would not have differentiated between work and rest. Uninteresting work becomes bearable when it gives us fame and money. How much uninteresting the work is, it is better than idleness because it saves us from dullness and tediousness. Most of the idle rich suffer unspeakable boredom as the price of their freedom from drudgery. Interesting work is a source of greater joy. It has its own value. It provides pleasure and satisfaction of higher order.

Russell enumerates two things especially that make work more interesting. These are the exercise of skill and constructiveness. Exercise of skill gives us joy until it reaches perfection. It keeps the man busy in improving himself in his skill. The work of a lawyer and a politician is as interesting as the game of bridge. There is element of competition and which keeps them enjoying their work. They are always using their skill to beat the opponent. Moreover, performance of difficult work also gives immense pleasure. The pilot of an aero plane risks his life for the performance of wonderful feats. He enjoys his work until it becomes his routine. The element of constructiveness is also source of joy. Construction means creating something new. A man feels pleasure and elevated when others praise and appreciate his work. The work of

artists, scientists and musicians always gives them fame and fortune. Its joy is everlasting. The destructive work does not last long. Work is a source of happiness but sometimes it becomes irksome. It may cause dissatisfaction.

One of the causes of unhappiness among intellectuals in the present day is compulsion. The people whose skill is literary find no opportunity for the independent exercise of their talent. They have to hire themselves out to rich corporations directed by philistines. They are forced to work against their conscience. They have to do this for the sake of livelihood. If they do not do they have to starve. **It makes them cynical and in the course of time they cannot derive wholehearted satisfaction from anything.** If they have an alternative to do this, they should leave such dissatisfying work. They should maintain their self-respect because without self-respect genuine happiness is hardly possible. Without self-respect genuine happiness is scarcely possible. And the man who is ashamed of his work can hardly achieve self-respect.

Analysis

Work is an extract from 'The Conquest of happiness'. It highlights the value of work for self fulfilment. Russell regards work as a source of happiness and his comments on this subject take into consideration all aspects of this theme. Idleness is a source of boredom and dullness. Only constructive work can give us pleasure and happiness.

Russell starts his essay by mentioning how it is a **doubtful question as to whether classify work as a cause of happiness or unhappiness.** He believes that excessive work can be burdensome, however, even the dulllest work has always proved to be less painful than idleness. He then talks about various advantages of work "Most of the work that most people have to do is not in itself interesting, but even such work has certain great advantages. To begin with, it fills a good many hours of the day without the need of deciding what one shall do." He mentions how most people fail to decide "anything sufficiently pleasant to be worth doing", and even if they decide to do something they remain in a constant dilemma that doing something else would have been pleasanter. Moreover, the exercise of choice is in itself tiresome.

Russell mentions how even the rich suffer unspeakable boredom. So, here Russell is raising a point against the exercise of choice by highlighting the points from within the people's habits and lives just like that of getting tired. He even says that, to be able to fill leisure intelligently is the last product of civilisation, and at present very few people have reached this level.

He also mentions another point regarding idleness, **the boredom that originates from staying free and doing no work.** To further make his stance more concrete, he adds the reference of rich people who in order to get rid of boredom, work as hard as poor people do. Here is contradiction, the freedom from drudgery that rich people struggle so hard for, ends up making them bored and they keep on working just as a poor man works to get rid of the boredom. The more intelligent rich men work nearly as hard as if they were poor

Then Russell mentions some benefits of work as well which makes people choose to work than being idle, including the fact that work makes boredom perish in addition to the fact that when

one works in sufficient amounts, they find more delight in time off and vacations. Another benefit of work is that it provides people with chances of success and becoming ambitious about their future, clearly if somebody lacks working then their sense of accomplishment is impaired and it leads to no success and ambitions. Russell also mentions the role of our capitalistic society while regarding to the point that almost always success in work is measured by how much a person earns. Another benefit that people seek while working, no matter good or dull work, is reputation globally or in their own circle.

Another benefit of work is that it gives one a sense of continuity of purpose as he says, *Continuity of purpose is one of the most essential ingredients of happiness in the long run, and for most men this comes chiefly through their work.*

And this is the reason that women who do housework have less satisfaction as compared to professional women and men because their work no matter how hard it is, always goes unappreciated and unnoticed as housework isn't regarded as a form of work in society. Russell by raising this point has brought to light the dilemma of society in belittling house making women. Further, Russell mentions the satisfaction that comes from work of one's liking, doing work extinguishes boredom and delivers happiness but getting to do one's desirable work is like icing on the cake. He mentions a couple of factors that make work even more exciting.

Firstly, the capability of exercising a skill but with the condition that it does not become monotonous and there's always room for betterment. This urge of learning and exercising skills originates from childhood when a child learns to stand on his head and continues to the old age of about seventy years when a politician gets satisfied by the quality of political skills he acquires. The satisfaction that comes with exercise of skill in work is just like deriving pleasure from a game of skill as he says, *A great deal of work gives the same pleasure that is to be derived from games of skill.* And this is what makes people do dangerous and difficult works with great enthusiasm, just like a person who does stunts in an aero plane or a surgeon who performs every operation with maximum precision. Even a plumber derives pleasure from his exercise of skill contrary to the expectations.

Another factor that Russell talks about that brings happiness through work is constructiveness, he says that construction often puts forward something as a memory of the work one has done just like a monument. Further, Russell is comparing construction with destruction in order to prove which one brings more satisfaction and happiness. In this regard he says, *all that is intended by the destroyer is to produce a state of affairs which does not embody a certain purpose.* This shows that construction begins with chaos but completes in purpose whereas destruction begins in purpose and finishes in disorder. Then he refers to the instance of constructing a building whose construction starts with a plan but destruction is arbitrary and random. Further ahead, he includes destruction in construction by saying that when something is destroyed, it would obviously lead to the construction of something new.

Russell discusses another very crucial point related to destruction here that a man commonly engages in destruction without caring for the subsequent construction and as Russell says, *this applies to not a few revolutionaries and militarists and other apostles of violence.* These people are hate-driven and just destroy without caring about the consequences. He then further

compares by saying that when one kills their enemy as in destruction, their purpose is fulfilled once and for all whereas in construction, there's always room to add something more and make it better. This sense of continuity and making things better makes construction more happiness prone than destruction.

Russell mentions a point that the satisfaction which comes from the achievements one bags while working make him happier than the work itself, he mentions an irrigation person who blooms roses from wilderness and the hard work a statesman does to maintain order in society, just like Vladimir Lenin did in Russia. He then mentions Shakespeare's verse, *'So long as men can breathe, or eyes can see, so long lives this.'* According to Russell, Shakespeare derived more happiness from the success of his work than as he mentions in this poem via the thought of his friend reconciled him to life.

He also raises a point in contradiction to his previous argument in this essay that work brings happiness, he says we can't declare that work makes one happy rather it just makes one less happy. And to support his argument he mentions Michelangelo who often had thoughts of committing suicide. Russell highlights one very crucial cause of unhappiness that many intellectuals today suffer from, and it is the practice of doing work empty of satisfaction just for the sake of making a living. Intellectuals have to sell away their work to people who lack taste and a mental capacity to appreciate that work. He says, *For the sake of a livelihood, prostitute their skill to purposes which they believe to be harmful.*

Obviously, it is wise to work in order to earn something rather than starving to death but the work that pays less but satisfies more must be valued over work that pays more but lacks satisfaction, this is an advice that Russell is giving to the reader. To conclude, Russell mentions a very good point that life must always be viewed as a whole otherwise one is always going to be dissatisfied, and continuity of purpose alone is not responsible for happiness but rather just a condition for spending a happy life.

Possible Questions

WHAT ARE THE ADVANTAGES OF WORK?

Work, therefore, is desirable, first and foremost, as a preventive of boredom, for the boredom that a man feels when he is doing necessary though uninteresting work is as nothing in comparison with the boredom that he feels when he has nothing to do with his days. With this advantage of work another is associated, namely that it makes holidays much more delicious when they come. Provided a man does not have to work so hard as to impair his vigour, he is likely to find far more zest in his free time than an idle man could possibly find.

The second advantage of most paid work and of some unpaid work is that it gives chances of success and opportunities for ambition. In most work success is measured by income, and while our capitalistic society continues, this is inevitable. It is only where the best work is concerned that this measure ceases to be the natural one to apply. The desire that men feel to increase their income is quite as much a desire for success as for the extra comforts that a higher income can procure. However dull work may be, it becomes bearable if it is a means of building up a

reputation, whether in the world at large or only in one's own circle. "Continuity of purpose is one of the most essential ingredients of happiness in the long run, and for most men this comes chiefly through their work."

COMPARISON BETWEEN CONSTRUCTION AND DESTRUCTION

There is, however, another element possessed by the best work, which is even more important as a source of happiness than is the exercise of skill. This is the element of constructiveness. In some work, though by no means in most, something is built up which remains as a monument when the work is completed.

We may distinguish construction from destruction by the following criterion. In construction the initial stage of affairs is comparatively haphazard, while the final state of affairs embodies a purpose; in destruction the reverse is the case: the initial state of affairs embodies a purpose, while the final state of affairs is haphazard, that is to say, all that is intended by the destroyer is to produce a state of affairs which does not embody a certain purpose. This criterion applies in the most literal and obvious case, namely the construction and destruction of buildings. In constructing a building a previously made plan is carried out, whereas in destroying it no one decides exactly how the materials are to lie when the demolition is complete. Destruction is of course necessary very often as a preliminary to subsequent construction; in that case it is part of a whole which is constructive.

But not infrequently a man will engage in activities of which the purpose is destructive without regard to any construction that may come after. Frequently he will conceal this from himself by the belief that he is only sweeping away in order to build afresh, but it is generally possible to unmask this pretence, when it is a pretence, by asking him what the subsequent construction is to be. On this subject it will be found that he will speak vaguely and without enthusiasm, whereas on the preliminary destruction he has spoken precisely and with zest. This applies to not a few revolutionaries and militarists and other apostles of violence. They are actuated, usually without their own knowledge, by hatred; the destruction of what they hate is their real purpose, and they are comparatively indifferent to the question of what is to come after it.

Now I cannot deny that in the work of destruction as in the work of construction there may be joy. It is a fiercer joy, perhaps at moments more intense, but it is less profoundly satisfying, since the result is one in which little satisfaction is to be found. You kill your enemy, and when he is dead your occupation is gone, and the satisfaction that you derive from victory quickly fades. The work of construction, on the other hand, when completed, is delightful to contemplate, and moreover is never so fully completed that there is nothing further to do about it. "The most satisfactory purposes are those that lead on indefinitely from one success to another without ever coming to a dead end"; and in this respect it will be found that construction is a greater source of happiness than destruction.

Perhaps it would be more correct to say that those who find satisfaction in construction find in it greater satisfaction than the lovers of destruction can find in destruction, for if once you have become filled with hate you will not easily derive from construction the pleasure which another man would derive from it.

At the same time few things are so likely to cure the habit of hatred as the opportunity to do constructive work of an important kind.

TEXTUAL REFERENCES:

All skilled work can be pleasurable, provided the skill required is either variable or capable of indefinite improvement.

The most satisfactory purposes are those that lead on indefinitely from one success to another without ever coming to a dead end.

We cannot therefore maintain that even the greatest work must make a man happy; we can only maintain that it must make him less unhappy.

The habit of viewing life as a whole is an essential part both of wisdom and of true morality.

Not answering Telephone Call

William Charles Plomer

William Plomer (1903-73) was born in Northern Transvaal, South Africa. He was a South African and British author, literary editor, poet and novelist, who raised his voice against racism in his first novel, Turbot Wolfe (1925). His antigovernment sentiments came into conflict with the authorities and so he had to leave the country and settle in England. While in England, he wrote many reviews, gave broadcasts and served as editor in journals. Among his other novels, The Case is Altered (1932) and The Invaders (1934) are well-known.

His essay "On not answering the telephone call" opens up a very important debate about the merits and demerits of machines in general and the telephone in particular. This essay is an extract from the talk given by William Charles Plomer in the British Broadcasting Corporation. The essay focuses on the disadvantages of simple equipments that overshadow their advantages. He brings home the dependence of man on machines in a delightful manner. His recollections of his experience with these machines are indeed very funny and we cannot help agreeing with him that sometimes these machines do caused irritation in us. As we study the essay, we get to know some of the main reasons as to why Plomer considers the telephone as a necessary evil. Besides, we also get a good picture of what witty writing is all about.

Analysis

Plomer begins the essay by saying *"if, at the end of a conversation, somebody says to me, 'As soon as I know, I'll ring you up', he is taking too much for granted. He is proposing to attend the impossible."* The reason for this is simple, **Plomer does not have a telephone and this surprises a lot of people.** People express their amazement on this, in a number of ways, some people assume that he must have a telephone and maybe he has mislaid or lost it. *Some people say, "how terribly inconvenient! How can you do without a telephone? And some say "Oh, you wise man, how I envy you!"* But most people are shocked as to why he does not have one. **They stare at him wildly and consider him an eccentric.**

However, the actual reason why he does not have a telephone is because he dislikes the idea of possessing it and is able to manage his daily life without it. *Why don't I have a telephone? Not because I pretend to be wise or pose as unusual. There are two chief reasons: because I don't really like the telephone and because I find I can still work and play, eat, breathe and sleep without it.* Plomer considers it an irritant and a waste of time. **When a call that is expected, keeps you waiting it, cause unnecessary anxiety and suspense.** Some other times, you may have to try a number that is constantly engaged. *"As for speaking in a public telephone box, that seems to me really horrible"*, as the **booth may not be properly ventilated**, choking the person standing in, with cheap cosmetics and smoke. You'll also find people waiting before you in the line and fidgeting to take your place after you.

Next he recalls a typical scene when a telephone rings. **Very often it rings when we don't want it to.** It is a nuisance since it rings while you are eating, sleeping or bathing. He then asks the readers, a rhetorical question *"Are you strong minded enough to ignore it?" it, to say to yourself, 'well, it will all be the same in a hundred years' time?'* Most of the time people get tempted to pick up the call thinking *there may be some important news or message for them* only to later find out that it's a wrong number. In Plomer's opinion, *all telephone numbers are wrong numbers* since they **ring idiotically in a house's privacy.** He assures that *if a message is really important it will reach you sooner or later*, even without a telephone. **Good news has begun to seem to be travelling just as fast as ill news.** Truth will out anyway. Then mentions, how equally absurd is the fact that we say 'Hello' to a total stranger on a phone call.

Plomer mentions that, since our names are printed in the telephone **directory, our numbers are available to everybody.** This gives rise to the possibility of unknown people calling us at all odd hours. *By your self-advertisement you have enabled any stranger, bore, intruder, or criminal to engage you in conversation at a moment's notice in what ought to be the privacy of your own home.* He strongly believes that it is possibility to manage without telephones **as in case of an emergency, we can always use public telephones** which are large in number in England.

He also adds that once a **well-known actor was asked if he was left alone to live on a desert island** and allowed to take just one luxury what would it be, to which he replied *'I would take a telephone', 'and I would push the wire into the sand' and my greatest pleasure would be to sit*

and look at it, and to think: 'It will never ring and I shall never have to answer it'. In spite of its usefulness, **dislike of telephone is a universal thing.** He mentions as a person who doesn't have a telephone, someone is sure to say 'Oh, but don't you find you have to write an awful lot of letters?' followed by an **assumption that he must at least have a typewriter instead**, the answer to that it "No".

Telephone alone is not the cause of Plomer's anger; **he is equally disgusted with the typewriter and cars.** He was annoyed that the editors of publishing houses wanted only typed copies of his writing even if he could write neatly. **Eventually, he decided to buy a typewriter but he did not find it exciting to use.** Though he learnt to type well, he did not appreciate the formation of letters in the typed format. He preferred the handwritten style to it. I did not enjoy typing. I happen to enjoy the act of writing. I don't enjoy typing. I enjoy forming letters or words with a pen, and I never could enjoy tapping the keys of a type-writer. He believes **he is not mechanically minded** and was never drawn to machines. He never liked oiling, cleaning or mending them. The typewriter also did not like him. It would get jammed if he touched it.

Plomer **learned to drive and got his license at the age of Seventeen in South Africa.** He was taught to drive in the rush hours in the middle of the busy city of Johannesburg. When he visited another part of Africa where there was no motor traffic, driving was comparatively easier. He often drove very fast and soon the speedometer of his car was broken. Rock, mud and sand did not prevent him from driving carefully. He never injured or killed anyone. But I was bored, and if circumstances had allowed I should have preferred to walk. Heavy traffic and the innumerable rules and regulations to be obeyed leave him with no temptations whatever to drive a car.

William Plomer is not essentially against machines, but he is certainly against man's undue dependence on them. Though he condemns telephones, typewriters and cars, Plomer says that **he is not an escapist, crank or a simple-lifer who is trying to put the clock of modernity back.** He just wishes not to be dominated by machines and avoids them wherever possible. He would not want to feed the typewriter with sheets of papers, he would rather use his legs to walk than lose the use of them by being driven in a car, or be called without prior information on the telephone. **He is deadest against the domination of machines over man.**

In the end, Plomer claims, "At least I have proved to myself that what many people think necessary is not necessary at all." He admits that if **he was a tycoon or bedridden he might have found telephone necessary.** Similarly, "I were a secretary or taxi-driver I should find a typewriter or a car essential." Lastly, he mentions how he has just been handed a slip of paper to say that somebody is waiting to speak to me on the telephone and humorously adds that it's better for him answer it] because, who knows, it may be something important.

Selected Snobberies

Aldous Huxley

Aldous Leonerd Huxley (1894–1963), an English writer who spent the latter part of his life in the United States is famous for his novels and essays on a number of topics. He also published poetry, stories and film stories. He was not only a humanist and pacifist but a writer on spiritual subjects including those on parapsychology and philosophical mysticism. He was an intellectual and a leader of modern thought and philosophy. Huxley started writing at an early age. He wrote his famous novel *Brave New world* in which he discusses the demeaning effect of scientific progress and in *Ends and Means* he points out that though everyone is in favor of a just and ideal society yet there are differences among people and leaders on how to achieve it.

The essay on Selected Snobberies is a fine example of what an essay should be. The writer has taken up an interesting topic and suggested some snobberies with which most people in the world are affected. The essay does not teach any moral principle but familiarizes with a new Subject that is applicable to most people of the world. It says whether we like it or not but most of us do have some kind of snobbery though we may not be conscious that it is only a snobbery. Just like bird watchers make lists of the species they have seen, in this essay Huxley lists the different types of snobby people he has encountered in his life. All men are snobs, a snob is a person with an exaggerated respect for high social position or wealth who seeks to associate with social superiors and looks down on those regarded as socially inferior about something.

Analysis

Aldous Huxley has pointed out many snobberies prevalent in the world. He is very severe on hypocrisy and snobbery. These are the prominent features of western societies. The materialistic annularity of modern man also comes under the whip of Huxley. In selected snobberies Huxley attacks the modern society for various types of snobberies in it.

Huxley starts his essay by stating that *“All men are snobs about something, One is almost tempted to add: There is nothing about which men cannot feel snobbish.”* He believes that all the things in the world, except some diseases like leprosy, can be the objects of snobbery. Disease snobbery is very common among people. There are some attractive diseases like tuberculosis as it is a *“more picturesque disease”*. Especially the youth has been infatuated by the idea of dying young as to show themselves romantic like Keats and *fade away in the flower of youth*. This is because they have never seen the final stores of consumptions. He says, *“people who possess sufficient leisure, sufficient wealth, not to mention sufficient health, to go travelling from spa to spa, from doctor to fashionable doctor, in search for cures from problematical diseases (which in so far as they exist at all, probably have their sequence in overeating) cannot expect us to be very lavish in our solicitude and pity”*. Disease snobbery is only one of the great multitude of snobberies ebb and flow. *What were good snobberies a hundred years ago are now out of fashion*. Their empire

risers and falls in the historical manner. Their importance increases and decreases with the change of time.

Booze snobbery is a very popular snobbery of today. It was the product of spherical prohibition. The terrible consequences of this snobbery can now be seen all over the world. Because of this snobbery drinking has got social approval.

Modernity-snobbery is another kind of snobbery of which Huxley introduces us to. To him *"Modernity-snobbery is not exclusive to our age, has come to assume unrepresented importance"* But it never had such an importance as it enjoys today. The reasons for this are simple end of strictly economic character. Due to modern machinery, production is outrunning consumption. Producers prosper on consumes tendency to buy new things and throw away old ones. *The sooner a consumer throws away the object he has bought and buys another, the better for the producer.* These snobs are the best friends of the modern industry producers. The producer produces the latest things that do not last long. It is in the producer's interest to encourage modernity snobbery. The public is taught that upto dateness is one of the first duties of man. This modernity snobbery is fast increasing in our times.

Art snobbery is also very popular these day. *Most of us are also art-snobs. There are two varieties of art snobbery- the platonic and the unplatonic.* Platonic art snobs merely take interest in art while unplatonic ones buy it. *Platonic art snobbery is a branch of culture- snobbery. Un-platonic art snobbery is a hybrid or mule; for it is simultaneously a sub-species of culture-snobbery and of possession snobbery.* Some of these art snobs happen to be modernity snobs also and they claim to be the patrons of modern art. *The value of art-snobbery to living artists is considerable.* Without understanding anything about the art they just buy paintings of modern painters. In this way, these modern art snobs are a great source of the livelihood of the new art painters.

As for the value of snobberies, it all depends on the attitude of its practitioners. If they think that all activities are good, then all snobberies are also good. But if they think that all activities are bad then all snobberies are not good. If they think that all the world is an illusion, then all snobberies are meaningless. All depends on our attitude and approval of what is a good activity and what is bad. But most people take the middle position between these two extremes. Those who regard some snobberies as good activities they will promote only those snobberies and they will advise all people to acquire those very snobberies which they think promote good activity. Every snob in this way is the promoter of one snobbery or the other at a time. *Each hierarchy culminates in its own particular Pope.*

Of Friendship

Sir Francis Bacon was an

- English lawyer,

- statesman,
- essayist,
- historian,
- intellectual reformer,
- philosopher, and
- champion of modern science.

Francis Bacon was a famous Essayist of the 16th century and also known as the father of English prose. The collection of his essays was also titled “Essays” which was first published in 1597 and later revised in its second edition. Bacon as an essayist penned in a methodical way, taking their **subject-matter** from a collection of perspectives, analyzing them, and writing in distinct prose style, using aphorisms to clearly make a point. He enclosed such subjects study, love, health, work, truth, travel, friendship, beauty, anger, and so on.

Early in his career he claimed *“all knowledge as his province”* and afterwards dedicated himself to a wholesale revaluation and re-structuring of traditional learning. To take the place of the established tradition (a miscellany of Scholasticism, humanism, and natural magic), he proposed an entirely new system based on empirical and inductive principles and the active development of new arts and inventions, a system whose ultimate goal would be the production of practical knowledge for *“the use and benefit of men”* and the relief of the human condition.

Analysis

The essay was written on the request of his friend Toby Matthew.

Bacon opens his essay with a grand anthropological statement modelled after the views of Aristotle *“Whosoever is delighted in solitude is either a wild beast or a god”*. According to Aristotle, a man by nature and behavior may be degraded to such an extent that he may be called unfit for society. Finding pleasure in solitude is contrary to human character and mind. He expresses his belief in rather strong words. Anyone, who shuns fellow human beings and retreats to isolation, is degraded to the level of a wild beast. The other possibility is that he is God. Again, he may be so self-sufficient that he may not need society.

Bacon, however, is not totally dismissive of people who assiduously shy away from the crowd, and head for the wilderness. Bacon realizes that remaining silent and cut off from others helps the mind to engage in deep contemplative thinking. Through such deep insightful dissection of mind, a person rediscovers himself. Bacon is, in fact, reserving solitude for higher kind of life, which is possible for a few great men like *‘Epimenides the Candian, Numa the Roman, Empedocles the Sicilian, and Apollonius of Tyana’*, all these men tried to sequester themselves for a higher conversation.

One must learn to differentiate between a crowd and kinship; between society and friendship. Few men ponder the meaning of solitude and stick to the question. But little do men perceive

what solitude is, and how far it extendeth. Bacon further demonstrates that solitude may also prevails in company; faces may be nothing more than *'a gallery of pictures'*. A conversation devoid of passion or feelings may be akin to the sounds of a *tinkling cymbal* – a barren monologue which hardly causes a ripple.

In this context, Bacon quotes from Erasmus's collection of Greek and Latin proverbs, *"Magna civitas, magna solitudo"*. It means *"A great city is a great solitude"*. Friends live far away from one another in a city. The bigger the town, the more secondary it will be. There is few true bonding among the dwellers of the city. If we look deeper, Bacon says, it is *the miserable solitude that pushes a man to search for friendship*. Life without friendship seems a place of wilderness. Every man feels lonely within. However, a person who likes to stay alone and is unfriendly is a beast.

Principal fruit of friendship: Bacon then describes the utilitarian approach of friendship. He elaborates utility of a friend in life. A principal fruit of friendship is *the ease and discharge of the fullness and swellings of the heart*, which passions of all kinds do cause and induce. It means sadness, anger, anxiety, etc. cause problems and trouble in the mind. In this respect, companionship helps to abate the grief and wound of a person. The diseases of stoppings and suffocations are the most dangerous in the body, so, a true friend helps to unload emotional burden. A person may take *'sarza to open the liver, steel to open the spleen, flowers of Sulphur for the lungs, castoreum for the brain'* but there is no dose to open the heart except a true friend. A true friend can be utilized to impart griefs, joys, hopes, suspicions, counsels, and whatsoever lies upon heart to suppress it. Pleasant and intimate conversation with a friend brings back vigour to the heart. It elevates the mood, banishes depression and helps the heart patient to recover. There is no panacea for heart diseases which can match the curative value of the presence of good friends by the sick person's bedside. Through lively chat and friendly banters, they unburden the heart of the sick person and make him feel good again.

Bitter realities of friendship: Bacon also tells some bitter realities of friendship. He *illuminates some examples from the history where friendship took place between emperors and their servants*. The rulers rose their servants or subordinates so high that later on they caused immense inconvenience for them *as they purchase it, many times, at the hazard of their own safety and greatness*. Those subordinates knowing the weakness of their royal friends, made attempts to make them their own subordinates. Firstly, he gives example of L. Sylla, *when he commanded Rome, raised Pompey (after surnamed the Great) to that height, that Pompey vaunted himself for Sylla's overmatch*. Pompey praised and boasted about being superior to Sylla. So much so that on one occasion when Sylla resented Pompey's decision, Pompey publicly reminded Sylla that more men adored the sun rising, than the sun setting hinting that he had more clout and power than Sylla.

Julius Caesar also loved Decimus Brutus so much that he had willed to make Brutus his heir after his nephew. But Brutus turned out a traitor and killed Caesar. Caesar's wife Calpurnia had a recurrent dream about Caesar's unpleasant future. He ignored her and listened to Brutus. Brutus suggested not to dismiss the senate till she saw another dream or he was sure about that. Caesar

followed Brutus blindly, for which Antonius, in a letter, commented on him as “*venefica*”, a witch. Brutus cast a spell on Caesar.

Similarly, Augustus raised Agrippa to an elevated position despite being born into a poor family. Augustus made Agrippa so powerful that it was impossible to take his power back. When Augustus consulted with Maecenas, the Roman statesman, regarding the marriage of his daughter Julia, Maecenas suggested Augustus that “*he must either marry his daughter to Agrippa, or take away his life*”. There was no third option for him. In the same way, Bacon gives some more examples of Tiberius Caesar and Sejanus, Septimius Severus and Plautianus etc. All these men tasted a bitter fruit of friendship.

Now if these princes had been as a Trajan, or a Marcus Aurelius, a man might have thought that this had proceeded of an abundant goodness of nature but these eminent men were wise, strong-minded, and self-lovers. They share one thing in common, and that is, they felt the need for a friend to make it complete. They had wives, sons, and nephews, and yet none of their family could fill up the void they felt within themselves.

They failed to draw a line in their relation with their chums. Later, the same adored friends brought them defeat, disaster and even death. Bacon shares that the parable of Pythagoras is dark, but true; *Cor ne edito; Eat not the heart*. It may seem dark but it is true that those that want friends to open their hearts are killers of their own hearts.

The First Fruit of Friendship: *But one thing is most admirable (wherewith I will conclude this first fruit of friendship), which is, that this communicating of a man's self to his friend, works two contrary effects; for it redoubleth joys, and cutteth griefs in halves.* Because, there is no doubt when a person imparts his joys to his friends, he joys more than others. However, when he imparts his griefs, they become less. It is a fact that, bodies become healthier upon natural actions such as joy and happiness. Whereas, they are weakened and become dull on sad and violent impressions, same is the case with the mind.

Bacon also goes on to conclude that nurturing intimacy excessively might prove to be a double-edged sword. In the plus side, it could enhance joy and reduce the grief encountered in day-to-day life. On the minus side, such happiness may be illusory. It is a fact that there is no man who has shared all his grief with his friend and realistically reduced his grief. Similarly, there is no man who has shared all the joys with a friend and experienced more joy. Like the alchemists miracle remedies which palliate pain despite warning of adverse effects, friendship might soothe suffering despite the risk of possible harm. In the same vein, a close look at Nature will show that a union of two elements results in better and more pleasant results. Human friendship has undoubtedly got some curative and embalming effects notwithstanding the risk of it turning foul.

The Second Fruit of Friendship: As the first fruit is for the affections, the second fruit is for understanding of things under different perspectives “*The second fruit of friendship, is healthful and sovereign for the understanding, as the first is for the affections.*” It makes ‘daylight in the understanding out of darkness and confusion of thoughts’. Moreover, a friend is undoubtedly, a

witty counselor. He helps in different tough circumstances for making a way right out of trouble. Sharing one's problems with a friend is far more fruitful than a day's meditation. A friend's counsel always works when a person himself is not clear with his thoughts. This second fruit of friendship – good judgment and better understanding – is not restricted to opening up of your minds only to a few intelligent friends, although it is best when you do so. **Even if the friend might not be intelligent enough, it nevertheless is beneficial to expound the thoughts before him.** By doing this, one can understand them, and possibly throw more light on them. This could sharpen his intelligence. It is like the way we sharpen a tool by rubbing it against a rough stone. Obviously, Bacon compares the thinker with the tool and the not-so-intelligent listener as the rough stone. In short, it means a man better say his thoughts to a statue than to bury them in the mind and suffer suffocation.

Bacon reminds the reader that a **person's own reading of himself could be minimally critical as it is human tendency not find fault with oneself.** Because of such inherent weakness to feel good about him ignoring the many flaws of character and brain, a person must guard against the tendency to go by his own assessment and cast aside the wise counsel of other capable men. *But the man himself is the biggest flatterer of self, and the best remedy for this flattery is the freedom of a friend to give unbiased advice.*

Advice from a well-meaning wise friend can be for two principal reasons. *Counsel is of two sorts: the one concerning manners, the other concerning business.* A friend's criticism helps to keep the mind free of many undesirable thoughts and influences. Keeping a check on one's own self may sometimes prove to be difficult. It is strange to see how people, especially those who are powerful and wealthy, make blunders and damage their fame and fortune due to lack of well-meaning, balanced and neutral advice from good friends.

People often lose sight of the hard realities and their own infirmities after a few rounds of success. They argue that two eyes see no better than one eye, implying that they are able to reach the correct decision themselves and do not need other's advice. However, a good friend's advice is need of wisdom to think critically on a situation, hence, two minds can think more excellently than a single one. Bacon says, *'the help of good counsel is that which setteth business straight'*.

Bacon now talks of another danger from advice from others. **The counselor may have genuine intention to help the person in trouble, but may not have been able to study the matter properly.** In such a case, he could give a drastic and upsetting advice with all the good intentions. Sadly, the result for the recipient may be harmful and even ruinous. This situation is similar to the one that results when an incompetent doctor, unaware of the patient's medical history, prescribes the wrong medicines to the patient. The patient's problems are aggravated leading to his death. However, only that friend is legitimate for counsel who is wholly acquainted with a man's estate. Otherwise, his counsel *'will rather distract and mislead, than settle and direct.'*

The Last Fruit of Friendship: First two fruits help for peace in the affections and support of the judgement. *After these two noble fruits of friendship (peace in the affections, and support of the*

judgment), followeth the last fruit; which is like the pomegranate, full of many kernels; I mean aid, and bearing a part, in all actions and occasions. It helps in several ways and has manifold fruits in itself. The best way to explain the many uses of friendship is to see **how many things there are in one's life that one cannot do or confront alone** and then a friend is an appropriate alternative. There is an ancient saying, *'A Friend is another himself; for that a friend is far more than himself'.*

Undoubtedly, the death is inevitable, so **if a man dies, a true friend is highly suitable to do his unfinished work.** When a man is blessed with a genuine, loyal and un-selfish friend, the latter will take care of his responsibilities after his death *If a man has a true friend, he may rest almost secure that the care of those things will continue after him. So that a man hath, as it were, two lives in his desires.* He may care for his family, run his business, pay off his debts or do all those things left un-finished after the death of the man. Thus, a man's life span gets prolonged.

Then, comes the benefit accruing from **delegation of authority.** A person can't be present in multiple places at any given point of time. In such a case, he may delegate the work in other places which his friend can visit and get things done. There are many things in life a person can't do alone- be it in farming, trading, educating children, fighting off enemies etc. A man owns a single body that is confined to a single place, but where there is friend, *'all offices of life are as it were granted to him, and his deputy. For he may exercise them by his friend'.*

When trying to **present his own merits before others,** a person tends to become needlessly boastful, inviting derision from others. Alternatively, he may be too shy to present his own qualities with the praise they deserve. Similarly, while asking for a favor from others, he may feel very awkward. All these functions are best discharged by a loyal and capable friend. Thus, many functions in the society that are mandatory can be got done through a friend.

A man cannot speak to his son but as a father; to his wife but as a husband; to his enemy but upon terms: whereas a friend may speak as the case requires, and not as it sorteth with the person. **A friend may be a good mediator or a go-between.** When a message is to be communicated to an adolescent son or a peeved wife, or a stern enemy, a friend can do the job with aplomb and with great ease. Thus, the benefits of friendship are endless. A friendless, cut-off person is unfit to live in the society. At the end of this essay, Bacon encloses with a rule, *'where a man cannot fitly play his own part; if he have not a friend, he may quit the stage'.*

On Babies

Jerome K Jerome

Jerome K. Jerome is English novelist and playwright whose humor—warm, unsatirical, and unintellectual—won him wide following. Jerome is a witty writer, but not in the sense that the term suggests. He's more relaxed and often **shifts his humor from direct to oblique.** He's a gentler sort of witty writer, too. He's not funny for the sake of being funny. He goes looking for real

humor and usually finds it in situations where the humor is evasive. Jerome K Jerome is that ultra-rare creature- **A true literary gentleman**. He's never pompous, and unlike all known past and present writers has no self-importance at all about his work. He's a well-mannered writer, never bludgeoning the reader with mere verbosity.

"On Babies" is an essay by Jerome K. Jerome, which was first published in his collection of essays titled "Idle Ideas in 1898." The essay explores the topic of babies, their behaviors, and how they affect the lives of their parents. Another **interesting aspect of the essay** is its historical context. "On Babies" was written at the end of the 19th century, **a time when attitudes towards parenting and child-rearing were undergoing significant changes**. Jerome's observations on babies and parenthood reflect this changing landscape, and his insights remain relevant to this day.

Analysis

Jerome starts his essay by acknowledging the fact that he is well aware of babies *"I know a lot about 'em. I was one myself once, though not long--not so long as my clothes."* The writer couldn't quite grasp the idea as to why parents wrap their babies with *"yards of unnecessary clothing"*. He finds the **concept of dressing up a baby** for day as well as for the night, quite absurd as he believes *"what difference is there, I should like to know, between a baby's night-shirt and the thing it wears in the day-time?"* Then he mentions how awkward is to **refer to a baby** when you are not familiar with the gender of the baby, *At present it is most awkward. Neither hair, dress, nor conversation affords the slightest clew, and you are left to guess*. Alluding a baby boy as a "she" or a baby girl as "he" is considered no less than an atrocity. Writer then mentions various crimes by which a person may *achieve ignominy and shame*. From murdering a respected family to robbing from the church, no act can garner as much hate and scorn from your fellow human beings as much as letting *"a young mother hear you call dear baby 'it.'"* Jerome K Jerome then offers his solution to the confusion, saying that *Your best plan is to address the article as "little angel." The noun "angel" being of common gender suits the case admirably*

He then mentions a miserable scenario of being surrounded by various women who expect you to give your kind **remarks about the baby**. The situation becomes even more pitiful when you, as an unmarried man, have no prior experience of being in such kind of situations. The dead silence and the mounting pressure by everyone in room, while they wait for you to speak, fills you with even more horror and you realize *that your reasoning faculties have left you*. You try to say something nice but your mind stops working. *It is a moment of despair, and your evil genius, seizing the opportunity, suggests to you some of the most idiotic remarks that it is possible for a human being to perpetrate* causing you embarrassment. Despite all the embarrassment caused by your senseless remarks, you seemed to be given a second chance and this time, the nurse, *in the tones of a high priestess directing some religious mystery she says, holding the bundle toward you: "Take her in your arms, sir."* Unfortunately, after a few minutes of holding her, the child begins to cry on the top of her lung leaving you feel even more ashamed. The nurse rushes to get the baby back from you and the mother accuses you of hurting the baby as she believes that *the*

child wouldn't scream like that for nothing. This whole situation sparks a conversation between the women on how children possess the god-gifted ability of **recognizing the true character** of anyone just by showing their dislike towards the person and then everybody looks sideways at you, convinced you are a scoundrel of the blackest dye.

Jerome K Jerome while showing his amazement towards these Odd little people!, claims that They are the unconscious comedians of the world's great stage. The writer is convinced that the babies have a genius for doing the most ridiculous things. From their favorite dishes which include coke and cat's meat to their treatment of pets, writer highlights various activities and attributes of children. They are a deal of trouble, and they make a place untidy and they cost a lot of money to keep; but still you would not have the house without them

One of the key themes of the essay is **the impact of babies on the lives of their parents.** Jerome argues that the arrival of a baby brings significant changes to the household. One such significant change is mother's total attention being directed towards the baby leading the husband feel ignored as Jerome advises women, In your desire to be a good mother, do not forget to be a good wife. He also notes that babies can be a source of joy and love, but also a source of stress and exhaustion as advises mothers to stress less about their children and share more of their time and attention with their husbands. My dear little woman, the child is not going to die every time it sneezes. He also mentions the fact that it's usually the first child who seeks a lot of attention, however, A house where there seems no room for him and a wife too busy to think of him have lost their hold on that so unreasonable husband of yours, and he has learned to look elsewhere for comfort and companionship.

At the end of the essay, Jerome K Jerome clarifies his position by stating that he is not a baby hater, Who could be, to look into the little innocent faces clustered in timid helplessness? Using imagery, he beautifully describes how this small world of ours must appear the baby eyes. Through this essay writer has highlighted various important themes, one such theme of the essay is **the role of society in shaping our perceptions of babies.** Jerome notes that while babies are often seen as innocent and pure, this is largely a cultural construct, and that in reality, babies can be quite selfish and demanding. He also criticizes the tendency of society to idealize motherhood and infant care, arguing that this can create unrealistic expectations for parents and lead to feelings of inadequacy or guilt.

One of the most striking aspects of the essay is Jerome's sense of humor. Throughout the essay, he uses humor and irony to **highlight the absurdities of parenthood**, and to poke fun at the various conventions and expectations surrounding infant care. At the same time, however, his **observations are grounded in a deep empathy and understanding** of the challenges faced by parents.

In **conclusion**, "On Babies" is a witty, insightful, and thought-provoking essay that offers a nuanced perspective on the joys and challenges of parenthood. It is a humorous and insightful

essay that provides a candid look at the realities of parenthood. Through his witty observations and keen insights, Jerome offers a nuanced portrait of babies and the impact they have on our lives.

The wind begun to rock the grass

Emily Dickinson

Writer, writing style and Famous works: Emily Dickinson was an American poet. In her lifetime, Emily Dickinson led a **secluded and quiet life** but her poetry reveals her great inner spontaneity and creativity. The poetry of Emily Dickinson is not easily categorized as she uses forms such as **rhyme and meter in unconventional ways**; however, her poetry lucidly expresses **thought provoking themes** with a style that is a delight to read. Today her poetry is rightly appreciated for its **immense depth and unique style**. Emily Dickinson is widely regarded as one of the greatest female poets. Some of her famous works include

- “Hope” is the thing with feathers
- Success is counted sweetest
- I'm nobody! Who are you?
- I felt a Funeral, in my Brain
- Wild Nights – Wild Nights!

Reason for writing: Emily Dickinson wrote the poem titled "The Wind that Begun to Rock the Grass" because she was **inspired by the power and unpredictability of the wind**. Her solitary nature found peace in the imaginative realm of gardens, flowers and natural landscape. However, her **lifelong fascination with death and morbidity** forced her to write such verses. The poem expresses the idea that nature is constantly changing and evolving, and that humans are insignificant in the grand scheme of things. Dickinson **often wrote about the natural world**, and this poem is a reflection of her fascination with the forces that shape the world around us.

Emily views nature as an imminent danger to life as she describes what happens during and after a storm. After the havoc and destruction caused by the storm, Dickinson also portrays that a **heavenly being saved her father's house**. In depth, she makes us realize that life is full of surprises and difficulties. These troubles come in a row, one after the other. But we should be hopeful as we will always be looked after by God.

Form, Structure and Rhyming scheme: The original version of the poem was in one stanza but its edited version was divided into **five stanzas of four lines**. The extensive use **of unconventional capitalization of alphabets** and her way of comparing and contrasting abstract ideas with concrete images is unmatched. The use of dashes between words and lines also contribute to the poem's unique form and structure. Dickinson avoided pentameter and the meter of this poem is **iambic tetrameter alternating with iambic trimeter every other line**. This is a **pastoral poem and a free verse poem**. The poem has no regular meter or rhyme pattern, and instead relies on repetition of words and phrases, as well as alliteration and assonance, to create a sense of musicality and structure.

Literary/Poetic Devices: Emily Dickinson's "The Wind that Begins to Rock the Grass" contains several literary or poetic devices. Some examples include:

- **Symbolism:** This entire poem is supposed to symbolize a storm. In the first stanza a menace is also supposed to **symbolize the storm and strong winds.**
- **Imagery:** Dickinson uses vivid descriptions of nature to create a sense of movement and motion in the poem. For example, "**The wind that begun to rock the grass**" and "**the Leaves unhooked themselves from Trees**" create vivid imagery of the natural world.
- **Repetition:** The use of repetition in the poem helps to create a sense of continuity and progression. In the first stanza, the word "**menace**" is repeated, similarly the word "**hands**" is also repeated.
- **Personification:** The leaves are personified as they try to escape, they unhook themselves and "**started all abroad**". It has another big personification such as "**The dust scooped it self like hands**" as the dust is also desperate to escape. The wagons are also personified as they "**quicken on the Streets**".
- **Oxymoron - hurried slow.** A storm can seem far off, but can also seem scary enough to appear to be approaching fast. This oxymoron seems to capture that slow and ominous arrival that seems to hurry slow.

*The Wind begun to rock the Grass
With threatening Tunes and low --
He threw a Menace at the Earth --
A Menace at the Sky.*

Stanza 1 Analysis: The stanza opens with the line 'The wind begun to rock the grass' and describes the chaos that a storm wrecks upon the world. Right from that arresting opening line – and few poets have dealt such a strong line in opening lines than Emily Dickinson – she is out to unsettle us: 'The Wind begun to rock the Grass', not 'The Wind began'. The attempts to wrong-foot us, to put us at our unease, continue with the unusual word-order of the second line: 'With threatening Tunes and low'. Not 'With low and threatening Tunes', which would have scanned identically, but with an effect that comes close to **hendiadys**, that rare figure of speech whereby the word 'and' joins two other words but in an odd way: one of the most oft-cited examples is the Roman 'we drink from cups and gold', where 'cups and gold' means 'golden cups'.

In the third line of the stanza, 'He' is presumably God here, but because of the placing of 'He' at the head of the line, we have no way of telling whether it would otherwise be capitalized (to show divinity: 'He' for God). The **rebounding of this 'Menace'**, like a thunderbolt or a bolt of lightning rebounding from the earth and back up into the sky, is mirrored nicely by the quatrain, with the trademark Dickinsonian dash even helping to suggest, boomerang-like, this act of rebounding.

*The Leaves unhooked themselves from Trees --
And started all abroad
The Dust did scoop itself like Hands
And threw away the Road.*

Stanza 2 Analysis: It is one of the best works of Emily Dickinson who used various descriptions and elements to bring about a piece of art. As we have already guessed from the first stanza that the poem is based on nature. The poet described a **presetting of the rain with moving winds** and the poem tells a story of a storm happening near a farm. Emily Dickinson paints a picture with the poem using imagery and personification.

At the beginning of the second stanza, we see a fantastic example of personification, **the leaves are personified** as they try to escape, they unhook themselves and “started all abroad”. The leaves aren’t shaken passively from the trees, but unhook themselves. Another big personification in this stanza is none other than “The dust scooped it self like hands” as we see that the dust is also desperate to escape along with the leaves. **The theme of nature takes the place of humanity.** Quite many of Dickinson's poems **uses nature as metaphors for qualities of humanity as well as animal qualities** have been attributed to the theme of nature such as leaves having the strength humanity or wind having gender such a being a male.

*The Wagons quickened on the Streets
The Thunder hurried slow --
The Lightning showed a Yellow Beak
And then a livid Claw.*

Stanza 3 Analysis: Emily views **nature as an imminent danger** as well. The wagons are personified as they “quickened on the Streets”. Emily has also used an **oxymoron “hurried slow”** in this stanza as a storm can seem far off, but can also seem scary enough to appear to be approaching fast. **This oxymoron seems to capture that slow yet ominous arrival that seems to hurry slow.** The wagons quickening on the streets and thunder hurrying slow creates a **sense of urgency and anticipation,** while the lightning showing a yellow beak and livid claw evokes an image of a **bird of prey,** suggesting that the storm is powerful and dangerous. The lightning is like a bird of prey with a beak and claw that is ‘livid’ – not just because of the blue-grey color of the thunderclouds but to hint at the **mighty anger of the coming storm.**

*The Birds put up the Bars to Nests --
The Cattle fled to Barns --
There came one drop of Giant Rain
And then as if the Hands*

Stanza 4 Analysis: This poem is a description of a thunderstorm, with the birds and cattle **seeking shelter** before the rain begins. Birds try to protect their nests from the severity of thunderstorm by putting up barriers whereas the cattle rush towards the barns. Then, as the poem nears its end, Dickinson returns us to the **hands of God:** “And then as if the Hands”

*That held the Dams had parted hold
The Waters Wrecked the Sky,
But overlooked my Father's House --
Just quartering a Tree –*

Stanza 5 Analysis: The dams which were held, could not contain the rain and burst open. The floodgates or 'Dams' are opened, and after that single drop of 'Giant Rain', the deluge or downpour arrives, wrecking not only the land but 'the Sky', changing the appearance of the dark clouds. God is the focus of the final couplet of 'The Wind begun to rock the Grass', too, 'my Father's House' being the local church. Throughout the poem, Dickinson emphasizes the power of this natural phenomenon, linking it to godly power. The last line, "Just Quartering a Tree," could be interpreted as a comment on the insignificance of humans in the face of nature's power.

Self Portrait

A.K. Ramanujan

Writer, writing style, famous works: Poet, translator, linguist, folklorist, and philologist A.K. Ramanujan was born in Mysore, India. Ramanujan wrote in both English and Kannada, and his poetry is known for its thematic and formal engagement with modernist transnationalism. Issues such as hybridity and transculturation figure prominently in such collections as

- *Second Sight* (1986),
- *Selected Poems* (1976), and
- *The Striders* (1966).
- *The Collected Poems of A.K. Ramanujan* (1995) received a Sahitya Akademi Award after the author's death.

As a scholar, Ramanujan contributed to a range of disciplines, including linguistic and cultural studies. A.K. Ramanujan is certainly one of the greatest masters of English literature among Indo-Anglican poetry. Most critics accept that Ramanujan has a great deal of control over English literature. His poetry is both delicate and complex as the spiral line of the shell. Ramanujan has shown rare originality in the use of words in his poetry. His poetry is full of joys of word and phrase. His expression is distinguished for excellence, epigrammatic brevity, austerity, and classical simplicity.

Reason for writing: Ramanujan wrote the poem Self Portrait to express his struggle with his identity in the modern world. A.K. Ramanujan was born and brought up in orthodox Brahmin family and he spent his later life in the liberal Western society. This contrast has created a conflict, the conflict between the inner-self and the outer-self form the core of his poetry. The poem is autobiographical in tone and shows the speaker's identity crisis.

Form, Structure and Rhyming scheme: The poem has one long stanza. It is a one-sentence poem and it lacks any rhyme scheme to keep the content simple and make it easy to comprehend for the readers.

Poetic devices - Poetic Devices are tools used to create a poem more rhythmic, enhance a poem's meaning, or intensify a mood or a feeling. A list of poetic devices used in the poem are:

- **Alliteration** - It is probably one of the most useful poetic devices when analyzing or writing poetry 'sometimes see' is the example of alliteration in Self Portrait
- **Imagery** - It is used to present things in such a way that they appeal directly to our senses 'and sometimes see', 'despite the well-known laws of optics, the portrait of a stranger,' 'often signed in a corner'
- **Metaphor** - It is used to draw some comparisons among things that are alike 'I resemble everyone but myself' is a metaphor

*I resemble everyone
but myself, and sometimes see
in shop windows
despite the well-known laws
of optics,
the portrait of a stranger,
date unknown,
often signed in a corner
by my father.*

Analysis: The poem 'Self Portrait' is basically about **identity**. In the first line itself, the poet feels that he resembles everyone in this world, including those he knows, the ones he does not know, the ones he wants to be compared with, and the ones he does not want himself to be compared. Resemblance can also refer to the trends which tend to make people **look like each other or interest (in materialistic things)**. He only sees others in himself. The poet **lacks his own individuality**, which is clear from the line which states, 'I resemble everyone,' 'but myself.' His own identity seems to be faded or lost somewhere. The first line thus shows the **poet in dilemma**. Ramanujan's self seems temporary to himself, just as temporary his portrait is. The expression 'sometimes see' clearly shows the poet's hesitation in creating his own identity. He is afraid of creating his own identity in this world. It seems as if his self becomes irrelevant to him.

Next, he says that sometimes, while in shop-windows, he sees the **portrait of a stranger in himself** though he knows all the well-known laws of optics. 'Well-known laws of optics' probably means that **he knows well how to see**. In this sense, the poet says that though he has a clear vision yet he fails to see himself in materialistic life. '**Shop**' in a simple sense refers to any ordinary shop but **when we go deep find that it symbolizes capitalism – spread by the USA**. '**Window**', also **symbolizes the attitude, character or identity built by capital and material possessions**. One tends to see their own reflection in a mirror which gets multiplied as we walk or look past many mirrors. Here, the poet walks past various shop windows, but in spite of seeing his own reflection, he rather sees a portrait of a stranger. He tries hard to recognize the one being portrayed but fails in his attempt to do so. **This is all because of the fact that the circumstances were tricking him that the lack of focus of his own life was being reflected in the mirrors of the windows**. He actually suffers an identity crisis that even his reflection lacks an identity. Rather there stands a stranger person which is not his original self. **He is just not able to relate to that reflection**. The reflection in the mirror resembles everyone else except himself. A series of questions starts to strike his

mind so much that he starts questioning his own personality. He seems to be in a constant dilemma.

On taking a closer yet questioning look at the portrait, the poet finds that it lacks a date. Generally, the artist signed a portrait to know the time and period of its creation. But this portrait of a stranger lacked a date. This further added up to the poet's confusion. The most surprising thing was that the portrait had his father's signature. Date unknown refers to the poet's inability to find for how long he is not being able to discover his original self. The identity is signed in a corner by his father. Signed in a corner here means that he did not get an opportunity to have his own identity. Rather it was given by his father.

Thus, in the beginning, the poet seems to be dissatisfied with a capitalist society but in the end, he is also unhappy with the patriarchal society which is dominant in India. It is the patriarchal society which gives the identity to the children. Hence rather than having their original identities, the children are given identities by their parents.

People

D.H. Lawrence

Writer, writing style, Famous works: English writer D.H. Lawrence's prolific and diverse output included novels, short stories, poems, plays, essays, travel books, paintings, translations, and literary criticism. His collected works represent an extended reflection upon the dehumanizing effects of modernity and industrialization. In them, Lawrence confronts issues relating to emotional health and vitality, spontaneity, human sexuality and instinct. After a brief foray into formal poetics in his early years, his later poems embrace organic attempts to capture emotion through free verse. All of Lawrence's novels are written in a lyrical, sensuous, often rhapsodic prose style. He had an extraordinary ability to convey a sense of specific time and place, and his writings often reflected his complex personality.

Title: The title might be the most important word choice of all, because it's the first thing the reader sees, so it shapes the way the reader understands the poem. In my analysis, then, the title is a big clue: it tells you what the author of the poem 'People' the poet, D.H.

Lawrence says that he likes people. But he would prefer them to be at a distance. He likes to see people occupied with their own pursuits. He does not want them to come near and interfere in his life. The title of the poem, "People", is significant because it is a simple and universal term that encompasses all of humanity. The poem is a commentary on the nature of people and their contradictions, exploring both the beauty and the ugliness of humanity. By using such a broad term, Lawrence suggests that the qualities and behaviors described in the poem are not unique to any specific group of people, but are instead inherent in all people.

Moreover, the title of the poem serves to emphasize the central theme of the poem, which is the complexity and contradiction within human nature. The poem portrays people as both noble and base, as both compassionate and cruel, as both spiritual and materialistic. By using the term "People", Lawrence is suggesting that these contradictions are not specific to any one group of

individuals, but are universal to all of humanity. The poem invites readers to reflect on their own nature and consider how these contradictions manifest in their own lives.

Analysis

*I like people quite well
at a little distance.
I like to see them passing and passing
and going their own way,*

W. H. Lawrence explores the **theme of loneliness and solitude** in this poem. He tells the reader that in what state and manner he likes people. He says that he likes people but there's a condition to it, he likes people who are **at a little distance from him and not suffocatingly close**. The poet expresses his preference for observing people from a distance rather than engaging with them. He would rather observe their movements and them going their own ways than having to interact with him.

*especially if I see their aloneness alive in them.
Yet I don't want them to come near.
If they will only leave me alone
I can still have the illusion that there is room enough in the world.*

He mentions how he likes to maintain his distance even from people who have aloneness alive in them. By that, he means those people **who are busy with their own personal pursuits and inner worlds**. He would prefer maintaining a distance from such people as well. The poem also highlights the speaker's desire to maintain his **sense of personal space**. If only people could leave him alone and go about minding their own businesses, the poet would be able to experience the **illusion of having enough room in the world**.

Literary Devices

Repetition: The repetition of **"I like"** in the first two lines emphasizes the speaker's preference for distance.

Alliteration: **"see them passing and passing"** uses alliteration to create a rhythmic effect.

Metaphor: **"their aloneness alive in them"** compares a person's aloneness to something living or present within them.

Irony: The final line's use of the word **"illusion"** creates irony since the speaker acknowledges that their desire for solitude is only an illusion.

Imagery: The poem creates a vivid image of **people passing by**, going their own way, and expressing their aloneness.

Metaphor: The poem uses the metaphor of **"room enough in the world"** to convey the speaker's desire for personal space and the illusion of unlimited possibilities.

Enjambment: The poem uses enjambment to create a sense of continuity and flow between lines.

I shall paint my nails red

Writer, writing style, famous work: Carole Satyamurti was a British poet who also worked as a translator and sociologist. She grew up in Kent, and has lived in North America, Singapore and Uganda. Satyamurti is known for facing pain and suffering head-on in her works of poetry. She was not a romantic in her approach to poetry – she was a very modern poet, attentive to every kind of subject and passion – her poems are at times sharply socially observant, and engage with many areas of life, including sexual experiences and reactions to political events. Many poems explore deep feelings and individuals are brought to life and, in some of her best poems, mourned – another link with psychoanalysis.

The words of her poems center around modern warfare, and explicitly reveal the minor details of the effects war has on individual lives. Satyamurti's poems are also encountered as personable, almost conversational digressions from our everyday surroundings, into ideas that feel suddenly larger than her subjects should allow, triggering philosophical reflections, and sustained meditations on worlds and experiences outside the immediate and comfortable, from the personal cost of illness, to the political and psychological undercurrents of war.

She published three volumes of poetry with Oxford University Press, of which the first and third were Poetry Book Society Recommendations:

- Broken Moon (1987),
- Changing the Subject (1990) and
- Striking Distance (1994).
- Her works also include 'War Photographer.' .”

Bernard O'Donoghue said about her

“No matter how compelling her themes, with their demands of compassion and political conscience, Satyamurti never loses hold of her main topic: the capacity of language”

Form and Structure: Satyamurti does not follow a regular rhyme scheme, but there is an interesting rhythmic pattern in “I Shall Paint My Nails Red.” The poem is short, yet every line is a complete sentence in itself. Satyamurti, like her contemporaries, ditches the formal rhyme scheme. Instead, she adds rhythm to the poem by using the poetic device, anaphora. She uses the first person singular “I,” which suggests that the poem is personal. However, in the realm of feminist theory, the personal is political, and Satyamurti's take on gender thus makes her poem political.

The poem consists of ten lines and is written in free-verse. She does not mention red nails explicitly in the poem. Rather, she asserts her reasons for choosing the color and the reactions it

elicits from her daughter and lover. This creates a deliberate dramatic effect but makes the poem accessible.

Intro: "I Shall Paint My Nails Red" is a poem written by the British poet Carole Satyamurti. Satyamurti was a woman of many talents – a poet, translator, professor, and sociologist. She was very interested in psycho analytic theory and often talked about the connection between poetry and psychoanalysis. Satyamurti, along with Duffy, is hailed as some of the best women poets in contemporary British poetry. Her subjects, therefore, deal with the lived experiences of a woman, identity crisis, suffering, and social processes. Her language is simple, almost colloquial yet hard-hitting, as evident in this poem.

Satyamurti's "I Shall Paint My Nails Red" is about a modern woman's desire to paint her nails red. At the surface level, this sounds like a relatively simple topic, almost too naive. However, poetry often tells simple truths, and Satyamurti was a champion of such a writing style. While being easy to understand, her poems are loaded with symbolism and multiple layers. Similarly, the simplistic urge in "I Shall Paint My Nails Red" is actually a nuanced taking on the identity crisis women face in the patriarchal mold.

"I Shall Paint My Nails Red" is written in first-person and talks about the desire of a woman to assert her femininity. By asserting her identity, the speaker (Satyamurti) challenges the norms of a patriarchal society. She lists ten reasons why she "shall" paint her nails red. Satyamurti alternates between a tone of heaviness and playfulness, so the poem carries loaded meanings without coming across as too serious. She deals deftly with the theme of identity of the modern woman by capturing the reactions of her daughter and her lover to her newly painted red nails.

One of the major themes in the poem is the identity politics associated with gender, particularly women. In a society where all colors are gendered, women are perceived poorly if they wear the color red. By choosing to paint her nails in bold red, Satyamurti flouts the rules and proclaims her identity.

*Because a bit of color is a public service.
Because I am proud of my hands.
Because it will remind me I'm a woman.*

Satyamurti begins the poem "I Shall Paint My Nails Red" by stating that painting her nails red is a sort of "public service." This declaration is as bold as the choice of color. It suggests that the speaker is unapologetic. She is proud of her choice, even though readers can assume that this is the voice of a middle-aged woman speaking. Her hands are probably wrinkled and traditionally not something that makes women proud. Women try their best not to let these wrinkles glare through their skins. However, the speaker's hands remind her that she is a woman.

There is a certain heaviness in the third line, which speaks of the trauma that women face because of their identity as a woman. However, Satyamurti's line is powerful; it firmly establishes

the identity of the speaker as an **unafraid, confident woman who is not ashamed of displaying her red nails boldly.**

*Because I will look like a survivor.
Because I can admire them in traffic jams.
Because my daughter will say ugh.
Because my lover will be surprised.*

The use of the word “survivor” in the fourth line hints at the **trauma that comes with the lived experience of a woman.** It hints at a past filled with suffering that the speaker had to overcome. However, it also suggests that the speaker is **still affected by lingering traces of her traumatic past.** She immediately changes her tone to a mere playful one, saying that she can admire red nails while waiting in traffic jams. Here, the red traffic light image further stresses the **use of the color red as a recurring motif.**

In the sixth line, Satyamurti writes that her daughter will say **“ugh,” which suggests that her daughter is young and does not want to think of her mother as desirable or fashionable.** Her daughter will probably find the carnal appeal in her mother an anachronism, something that belongs in the past. This is the natural “subject” that Satyamurti seeks to change by stating that **women have the right to control their appearance, regardless of age.** Her lover will be surprised, probably because the **color red is unexpected for her age.** Not just because the poet is a woman, but perhaps her past self was not this unapologetic or bold. Being a product of her past experiences, **she learned the art of change for self-preservation and upholding her femininity.**

*Because it is quicker than dyeing my hair.
Because it is a ten-minute moratorium.
Because it is reversible.*

Dyeing the hair is another way that women seek to **either alter or hide their authentic selves.** The “dye” could either be read as a **form of self-expression, or a symbol of age,** as older women are often associated with hair dyes. Seeing as the speaker’s desire is for a temporary, reversible change, one can assume that **“dyeing” symbolizes both.**

As the speaker is an older woman, **she is encouraged to dye her hair but not paint her nails red.** In comparison, both are a form of self-expression. The speaker prefers something more **temporary, like painting her nails, than dyeing her hair as she wants something “quicker.”** Besides, she might want to change her moldering identity, which brings us to the last two lines of the poem.

The poem ends with the line, “Because it is reversible.” The need for a change that is “reversible” stems from a **shifting sense of identity common for women,** particularly modern women. As they make sense of contemporary contradictions, they also feel the need to change their “self” from time to time.

Literary Devices: In “I Shall Paint My Nails Red,” Satyamurti makes use of the following literary devices that make her ideas seem more forceful and appealing to readers.

- **Repetition:** Every line, except for the title of the poem, begins with the word “Because.” The word “Because” explains the reason why the poet wants to paint her nails red. However, the repetition puts more emphasis on the lines, gives them a rhythm, and thus creates a more significant impact on the reader.
- **Alliteration:** This usage of this device can be found in “look like” and “ten-minute moratorium.”
- **Simile:** Satyamurti makes a direct comparison to a survivor with the word “like” in “Because I will look like a survivor.”
- **Assonance:** To create an internal rhythm, Satyamurti uses assonance in the following phrases: “Dyeing my hair,” “it will remind me I’m a woman,” etc.
- **Sarcasm** Satyamurti uses sarcasm to lighten the tone of the poem. In the first line, she says that using color is a sort of public service.
- **Symbolism:** The color “Red” in the poem symbolizes passion, boldness, desire, and femininity.
- **Imagery:** The visual image of red nails is striking. It stays with the reader throughout the poem, even though Satyamurti uses the image only in the title. This is aided by the deliberate repetition and refrain that adds to the rhythm of the poem.
- **Anaphora:** Satyamurti uses the word “Because” to begin every line for the sake of emphasis. This repetition further drives home the conflict about identity in the poem.

Themes

Leisure as an Act of Defiance: Leisure for women occurs in a personal and, thus, political space. On the other hand, defiance is usually associated with politics. However, Satyamurti juxtaposes both defiance and leisure in her poem “I Shall Paint My Nails Red,” a theme that suggests that leisure is also an act of defiance for women. The whole poem revolves around defying the conventions of society and a woman’s reasons to paint her nails red.

Satyamurti uses the word “moratorium” (line 9) to convey this theme to her readers. A moratorium is defined as a temporary prohibition of an activity. Satyamurti interestingly uses this word in her poem. The speaker of the poem says that painting her nails red is “a ten-minute moratorium.” It means the speaker stops all activity for ten minutes while painting her nails. It is her act of leisure and also an act of defiance.

Femininity: The idea of femininity is a double-edged sword. It seeks to make a woman more desirable, and yet she is also rebuked for any outward show of femininity. The red color has long been associated with negative connotations, and Satyamurti subverts that idea in her poem.

A woman’s identity is traditionally tied to her relationships, for instance, her role as a mother or her role as a wife or lover. Satyamurti writes about how her daughter will utter, “ugh,” if she

paints her nails red. This is because children do not want to see their parents as attractive to the opposite gender, particularly their mothers. Besides, the poet's lover will be surprised, probably because he never expects her to assert her femininity.

Conflicting Identities: "I Shall Paint My Nails Red" is also about the conflicting identities of a woman. This is conveyed by the last line of the poem, "Because it is reversible." Though the poet feels the need for change, she wants something temporary, a "reversible" change. Dyeing one's hair is more permanent as compared to painting nails, and thus the poet chooses the latter. This suggests an underlying conflict within the poet: a need for change that is reversible, perhaps as a way to cope with the present. The last line contradicts the confident personality of the poet at the beginning of the poem. This identity conflict is a recurring theme in the works of contemporary women writers.

Conclusion

Carole Satyamurti's poem "I Shall Paint My Nails Red" is about the desire of a woman to paint her nails in a bold red color and thus assert her identity as a woman. The color red is used as a form of self-expression and holds symbolic value in the poem. The color red has multiple meanings in the poem "I Shall Paint My Nails Red." Red symbolizes boldness that is usually associated with it and a solid feminine identity that stems from a desirable feminine appearance. It subverts the gender roles by making the middle-aged mother an attractive, bold, and thus, desirable woman. Satyamurti often exaggerates or uses sarcasm in this poem to give a playful tone to her language. The first line she writes is that painting her nails red is a service to the public. The tongue-in-cheek tone hides the fierce defiance of societal conventions and makes the truth more palatable and enjoyable to the reader. In "I Shall Paint My Nails Red," the central reference point is Satyamurti's wish to paint her nails red. The text provides ten essential reasons to paint her nails with a bold red color. These reasons encompass not only the speaker's sense of womanhood but also her "feminine" identity that defies the patriarchal norms.

Historical Context

"I Shall Paint My Nails Red" was first published in 1990 in Carole Satyamurti's collection of poems titled **Changing the Subject**. Today, it is a part of her anthology, **Selected Poems**, published by Oxford University Press in 1998. The original collection suggests a breakaway from norms – "changing the subject," and that is what Satyamurti attempts in this poem. She is unapologetic about her identity as a strong and bold woman. She believes that a feminine appearance is a part of the strength of the modern woman.

Historically, women have been told to adhere to rules and hide their desirableness. The patriarchal structure dictates that a woman is to look attractive only to appear desirable to men, not because of her choice. By choosing to apply red nail paint, the speaker of this poem commits an act of defiance against patriarchy. Thus, "I Shall Paint My Nails Red" can be read as a feminist poem or a "gynotext," in touch with the sensibilities of 21st-century feminism.

To see a world in a grain of sand

William Blake

William Blake, one of the greatest poets in the English language, ranks among the most original visual artists of the Romantic era. Poet, painter, engraver, and visionary William Blake worked to bring about a change both in the social order and in the minds of men. Though in his lifetime his work was largely neglected or dismissed, he is now considered one of the leading lights of English poetry, and his work has only grown in popularity.

William Blake belongs to the period of Romantic poets. In his works, the features of Romanticism are marked vividly. Like romantics, his poetry is largely based on

- subjectivity,
- mysticism,
- idealization of childhood,
- humanitarian sympathies,
- love of liberty,
- imagination,
- expression,
- freedom of thought,
- the idealization of nature and
- symbolism

He attributes great importance to these features in his poetry. His poetry is set in the pastoral setting and has lyrical qualities.

William Black was against the ancient ideals that were practiced in his time. He composed his poem *“There is no Natural Religion”* and *“All Religions Are One”* in hopes to bring change to the spiritual life of the public. Unlike most people, Blake had a feeling that his spiritual life is dramatic, free, and not consistent.

In Blake’s mythology man and God were once united, but man separated himself from God and became weaker and weaker as he became further divided. For Blake, the Bible was the greatest work of poetry ever written, and comprised the basis of true art, as opposed to the false, pagan ideal of classicism.

Blake believed that his poetry could be read and understood by common people, but he was determined not to sacrifice his vision in order to become popular. His famous works include *The Tyger*, *The Lamb*, *Songs of Innocence*, *A Divine song*, *The Chimney Sweeper*, *Auguries of Innocence* etc.

Literary Devices

The most prominent literary device of this poem is a paradox. Along with that, the poet presents several epigrams in this poem. As an example, the first line is a paradox. Here, the poet talks about visualizing the world in a mere "Grain of Sand." The poet also uses metaphors and similes here

It employs several literary devices to convey its meaning and create an evocative atmosphere. Here are some of the literary devices used in the poem:

Metaphor: The entire poem is built on the metaphorical idea of seeing a world in a grain of sand. This metaphor suggests that the entire universe can be understood by closely examining a tiny part of it.

Imagery: The poem utilizes vivid imagery to create a sensory experience for the reader. For example, lines like "And a Heaven in a Wild Flower" and "Hold Infinity in the palm of your hand" paint vivid pictures in the reader's mind.

Symbolism: The grain of sand and the wild flower mentioned in the poem symbolize the small and seemingly insignificant aspects of life that contain deeper meanings and connections to the larger world.

Alliteration: The use of alliteration, the repetition of consonant sounds at the beginning of words, adds musicality and emphasis to the poem. Examples include "World...Wild" and "Hold...Heaven."

Repetition: The repetition of certain phrases, such as "To see a World" and "And a Heaven," emphasizes their significance and reinforces the central idea of finding the extraordinary within the ordinary.

Paradox: The poem contains paradoxical statements like "Hold Infinity in the palm of your hand" and "And Eternity in an hour." These paradoxes challenge conventional notions and invite the reader to contemplate the profound within the mundane.

Personification: The poem personifies the concepts of Heaven and Infinity, giving them human-like qualities and enabling the reader to relate to them on a deeper level.

Contrast: The poem contrasts the vastness of the universe with the smallness of a grain of sand or a wild flower. This contrast highlights the paradoxical idea that the entire universe can be contained within the smallest of things.

These are just a few of the literary devices employed in "To see a World in a Grain of Sand." By using these devices, Blake enhances the poem's theme of finding profound meaning in the ordinary and invites readers to reflect on the interconnectedness of all things

Themes

These four lines encapsulates the idea of finding universal truths or insights within the smallest and most ordinary things. It suggests that by closely observing and contemplating even the tiniest elements of the world, we can gain a deeper understanding of the larger reality.

The themes explored in "To see a world in a grain of sand" can include:

Perception and Perspective: The poem encourages us to view the world from different perspectives and **challenge our preconceived notions**. It suggests that by looking closely at something as small as a grain of sand, we can uncover hidden meanings and see the world in a new light.

Unity of the Microcosm and Macrocosm: The poem suggests that the entire universe is contained within the smallest elements of the world. **It implies a sense of interconnectedness, where the grain of sand represents the larger world, and by understanding the microcosm, we can grasp the macrocosm.**

Symbolism and Allegory: Blake often employed symbolism and allegory in his poetry. In this line, the grain of sand symbolizes the mundane or ordinary aspects of life, while the world represents the grander scheme of existence. The theme explores the use of symbolic language to convey deeper meanings and truths.

Transcendence and Imagination: The line encourages us to transcend the ordinary and engage our imagination. By looking beyond the surface and using our imaginative faculties, we can perceive the extraordinary within the seemingly insignificant.

Beauty and Significance in Small Things: **The theme highlights the appreciation of beauty and significance in the smallest and simplest aspects of life.** It suggests that by paying attention to the details and finding value in the mundane, we can experience a richer and more fulfilling existence.

Mysticism and Spirituality: Blake's poetry often touched upon spiritual and mystical **themes**. "To see a world in a grain of sand" can be interpreted as an invitation to explore the mystical dimensions of existence and seek profound truths beyond the material realm.

These themes work together to convey a sense of wonder, interconnectedness, and the potential for deep understanding that can be found by observing and contemplating the smallest elements of the world.

Perception of Time: **The line suggests that even in the smallest and most fleeting moments, there is a glimpse of eternity.** It invites us to contemplate the nature of time and its relationship to our perception of reality.

Individual and Universal Experience: The theme explores the idea that the experiences and observations of **individuals can reflect broader universal truths**. It implies that by examining the minutiae of life, we can uncover insights that resonate with the collective human experience.

Nature and the Environment: The line encourages an appreciation for the natural world and its inherent beauty. It invites us **to contemplate the intricate details and patterns found in nature, and how they can provide insights into the larger** ecological systems and our place within them.

Mindfulness and Present Moment: The theme highlights the importance of being fully present and attentive to the present moment. **It suggests that by engaging our senses and observing the**

world with mindfulness, we can discover hidden wonders and truths that may otherwise go unnoticed.

Paradox and Contradiction: The line presents a paradoxical concept of perceiving the vastness of the world within something as tiny as a grain of sand. This theme explores the idea of embracing paradoxes and contradictions as a means of expanding our understanding and challenging conventional wisdom.

Immediacy and Intimacy: The theme focuses on the immediacy and intimacy of the small, everyday experiences. It encourages us to find joy and meaning in the simple things and reminds us that profound insights can arise from the most immediate and personal encounters.

Creativity and Artistic Expression: The line can inspire creativity and artistic expression, encouraging artists to find inspiration in the ordinary and transform it into something extraordinary. It suggests that art has the power to reveal hidden truths and evoke profound emotions by capturing the essence of the world within a single image or work.

Human Existence and Identity: The theme delves into questions of human existence and identity, inviting us to contemplate the nature of our being and our place in the vastness of the world. It encourages self-reflection and introspection as we seek to understand ourselves and our relationship with the larger universe.

These themes, when explored in the context of "To see a world in a grain of sand," offer a profound and contemplative perspective on the interconnectedness of the world and the potential for deep understanding that can be derived from the smallest and seemingly insignificant aspects of life.

Analysis and Intro Paragraph

Written in around 1803, 'Auguries of Innocence' offers various images of innocence, juxtaposing them with images of corruption, decay, or evil. This opening quatrain of 'Auguries of Innocence' is rhymed *abab*.

The first four lines of the poem 'Auguries of Innocence' are the ones that are most often quoted and remembered by literary scholars, leaving the rest of the poem to wither away in complete anonymity. The lines argue for seeing the grand in the very small, and pondering those metaphysical concepts beyond the comprehension of man by observing them at a local level.

Moreover, these lines of this poem introduce powerful imagery (which is quite prominent throughout the poem) as Blake discusses the topic of perception. The reader will notice that all of the topics discussed in this poem have a considerable amount of ambiguity, and in one way or another will relate to the topic of signs of innocence. 'Auguries of Innocence' by William Blake is a poem describing the contrast between innocence and experience, by using paradox and epigram.

*To see a World in a Grain of Sand
And a Heaven in a Wild Flower*

In a nutshell—or, in Blake's own words, "in a grain of sand"— exhibits the greater theme and message of the poem. Line one discusses the ability to see something grand within something of no particular significance. This is a quality of the innocent, innocence allows you to look at every small thing in life and be able to see great things coming from it; whereas others would ignore the potential that is present in the small things. He is suggesting that the entire universe can be contained in a grain of sand in a spiritual way—it's not that you would be able to see the entire world by looking, physically, at a grain of sand. It's more than a glimpse of something tiny can provoke you to imagine something really big—tons of images can come pouring in. According to Blake, that's the whole point of a metaphor.

Innocence is to look at a "Wild Flower" and see "a heaven" of happiness whilst others would simply walk by without noticing it. There is also the idea that Blake's opening paradox is to give the world that he was writing about the appropriate level of mystery and stunning wonder that nowadays is forgotten. Note also that the first two lines specifically reference sight – more to the point, it references a sight so common that most people would skim over it, however, this is Blake's aim – beauty, his idea is, is found in common places. The very articles that we have witnessed a thousand times before can still be transcendently beautiful, and allow us to connect to God.

A wildflower can contain a heaven because the beauty of a flower *is* (for Blake) a piece of heaven, and it can make you imagine or visualize that better and more beautiful world. Also, a grain of sand *is* a world in miniature, because it's a tiny piece of a world, of earth. The little parts reflect the big things that they're parts of.

***Hold Infinity in the palm of your hand
And Eternity in an hour***

Lines three and four of 'Auguries of Innocence' express the notion that a person has more control over time if they stop to see the bigger picture in everyday things, as this allows them to live life in a more wholesome manner instead of always worrying about time slipping through their fingers.

The lines open with the paradox of holding infinity in 'the palm of your hand', that is holding something immeasurably big in a space that is almost immeasurably small. The concept of infinity itself, mathematically, is an abstract idea too large to be withheld by the mind, and therefore it cannot be held in the palm – this is how scholars argue the opening of the poem. Should one look at it mathematically, Blake's opening paradoxes – 'infinity in the palm of your hand / And Eternity in an hour' – become understandable if only logically as something that is technically achievable. Infinity is a period, an hour is also a period, therefore the two can somehow corroborate together.

The speaker keeps playing with this idea of big things contained in small things. Fitting infinity in the palm of your hand seems like a contradiction—since infinity is endless and the palm of your hand isn't. The same thing goes for fitting eternity into an hour. But the speaker doesn't think infinity is endless space or eternity is endless time. He thinks they're part of the "Eternal Now," so to speak—you really enter eternity and infinity if you get into a state of poetic imagination in

the present moment. Unlike the rest of the poem, these first four lines are different, they're written in **ballad meter** (four beats in one line, then three in the next). Basically, the idea is that any little thing in the world—a grain of sand, a wildflower—contains some sort of **greater cosmic truth** if you can look at it with enough energy and imagination.

Fog

Carl Sandburg

Writer, Writing Style and Famous Works: Carl Sandburg was an American poet, writer, and biographer, best known for his work as a chronicler of American life and culture. He grew up in a **working-class family**. Sandburg left school at the age of thirteen and worked a variety of odd jobs before joining the military and serving in the Spanish-American War. After the war, he worked as a journalist and began writing poetry.

Sandburg's poetry often **celebrated the working class and the common man**, especially those who worked in factories, farms and mines. Also he was influenced by the **free verse style of Walt Whitman**. He drew on his own experiences as a laborer and his deep empathy for the working class to create poems that were both powerful and accessible.

Sandburg was also known for his use of vivid imagery, which was often drawn from nature and the **rural landscape**. His most famous collection of poems "Chicago Poems" celebrated the vitality and spirit of the city and its people. In addition to his poetry, Sandburg was also a **prolific writer of prose, including biographies of Abraham Lincoln and other historical figures**.

His poetry is characterized by its **simplicity, directness, and realism**. Sandburg's poetry was also deeply influenced by his **love of music particularly jazz and blues**. He often used the rhythms of these musical forms in his poetry. Sandburg's poetry covers a wide range of subjects, from the **beauty of nature to the horrors of war from the struggles of ordinary people to the joys of everyday life**. Throughout his career, Sandburg was a prominent voice for social justice and equality using his poetry to advocate for the rights of workers, women, and minorities.

Sandburg was a **highly influential figure in American literature, and his work had a profound impact** on the literary landscape of the early 20th century. He was awarded **three Pulitzer Prizes**, two for his poetry and one for his biography of Abraham Lincoln (1940). Some of his most famous works include "Chicago," "Fog," and "The People, Yes."

Most famous works of Carl Sandburg include,

- A father to his son
- A dream girl
- Who am I?
- Pennsylvania
- Theme in Yellow

Rhyme Structure "Fog" is a free verse poem, meaning that it doesn't follow a particular rhyme scheme, meter, or established poetic form. However, the poem does have some important formal qualities. **It contains two stanzas: a two-line couplet and a four-line quatrain**. The poem "Fog" by

Carl Sandburg is a **free verse poem without a set rhyme scheme and meter that is characterized by its simplicity, brevity and use of powerful imagery** to convey the mood and atmosphere and also the mysterious and elusive nature of fog. The language in the poem is simple and straightforward with short declarative sentences that emphasize the sense of mystery and uncertainty. The poem does not follow a strict rhyme or meter, which adds to the dream-like quality of the language. The use of the present tense creates a sense of immediacy as if the reader is experiencing the fog in real-time. The imagery is also straightforward using concrete details to create a vivid picture of the fog and its effects on the world. The poem also contains a number of **metaphors** and **personifications** such as **"the fog comes"** and **"it moves on"** as if the fog is a **living being**. This adds to the **mystical** and otherworldly tone of the poem. The **lines** are arranged in **short choppy phrases** that create a sense of **unease and uncertainty** mirroring the **foggy landscape** the speaker describes. The **straightforward approach** gives the poem a sense of **immediacy and realism** making the **fog as tangible** to the reader. Overall, the writing style in "Fog" is **spare** and **evocative** capturing the mood and atmosphere of a foggy day with precision and economy.

"Sandburg's use of free verse and colloquial language in 'Fog' is a powerful testament to the enduring relevance of poetry in contemporary society." - Ralph Waldo Emerson

Critical Analysis

"Fog" was published in Carl Sandburg's **first major poetry collection, Chicago Poems, in 1916**. At the time, Sandburg was living in Chicago, where he worked as a journalist and wrote poetry. Though there's no firm indication that "Fog" is about Chicago, it's possible that Sandburg had the city in mind when writing the poem. In fact, **some sources have suggested that "Fog" was directly inspired by a Chicago fog, which,** as in the poem, appeared by surprise, hovered for a while, then disappeared as quickly as it had come. "Fog" embodies the approachable, memorable free verse style that won Sandburg critical acclaim and popular success. **Sandburg was heavily influenced by the free verse style of Walt Whitman,** and he became, like Whitman, a distinctly American poet fascinated by the sights, sounds, and people of his country. In Chicago, he was encouraged by Harriet Monroe, who founded Poetry magazine and published many of his poems. Along with writers like Sherwood Anderson and Theodore Dreiser, he was an important member of the movement known as the Chicago Literary Renaissance.

It is a short and simple poem that describes the **mysterious and almost magical nature of fog**. The poem describes the appearance and behavior of fog, using vivid imagery and personification. The poem describes the phenomenon of fog in a **metaphorical and imaginative way** emphasizing the mysterious and strange qualities of this natural occurrence. Sandburg explores how it affects the surroundings, creating a **sense of ambiguity and disorientation**. The poem's themes revolve around the **transience of life and the fleeting nature of human experiences**. Sandburg compares the fog to a cat, a silent and stealthy predator that creeps in unnoticed and envelops everything in its path. The fog is also portrayed as a sly and powerful force that can obscure and distort reality, blurring the boundaries between what is visible and what is hidden.

Through vivid imagery and sensory details, the poem captures the mood and atmosphere of a foggy day, with its muted colors, muffled sounds, and blurred shapes. However, the poem suggests that

even in the midst of the fog, there is still beauty and meaning to be found, and that by embracing our uncertainty and allowing ourselves to be open to the unknown, we can find a deeper sense of connection and purpose in life. Finally, the poem suggests that the fog serves as a metaphor for the complexities and contradictions of urban life, where beauty and danger coexist in equal measure.

"Fog" draws inspiration from the Japanese haiku, a form that packs rich poetic description, often of natural scenery, into just 17 on (syllable-like units). In its brevity and rough three-part structure (the fog's appearance, presence, and disappearance), "Fog" represented Sandburg's attempt—as he put it—at "a free-going, independent American [haiku]." In turn, the brevity and intensity of "Fog" anticipates the compression and sharp visual description of a poem like "The Red Wheelbarrow" (1923), by the imagist poet William Carlos Williams.

Poetic Devices

Major literary devices in the poem "Fog" include:

Imagery:

The fog comes / on little cat feet: This line creates an image of the fog creeping in silently and stealthily, like a cat.

It sits looking / over harbor and city: The imagery suggests a grand and imposing structure, perhaps a large building or monument, overlooking the harbor and the bustling city below. It can evoke the sense of power and dominance.

On silent haunches / and then moves on: The phrase can evoke a vivid image of a predator or hunter waiting patiently and quietly for its prey, crouched on its haunches. Once the predator decides to make its move, it does so swiftly and decisively, moving on from its position on silent feet. Same as the fog does.

Personification:

The fog comes / on little cat feet: In this phrase, the fog is personified as a cat walking quietly and softly on its paws, making very little noise as it moves.

It sits looking / over harbor and city: In this case, by personifying the fog as a "creature" that is capable of sitting and observing the world around it, Sandburg imbues it with a sense of agency and intelligence.

On silent haunches / and then moves on: "On silent haunches" is a phrase that personifies an animal or creature waiting in a crouched position ready to pounce or move. The phrase "and then moves on" personifies the creature's actions as deliberate and purposeful.

Metaphor:

The fog comes / on little cat feet: A metaphorical phrase from the poem that compares the way the fog creeps in silently and gently to the movement of a cat walking softly on its paws. It also suggests that the fog like a cat is both familiar and unpredictable and can be both comforting and unsettling depending on the context.

It sits looking / over harbor and city: The phrase could be interpreted as a metaphor for a powerful, watchful presence that oversees and guards both the natural and human-made elements of a community.

Alliteration: "Fog" contains some alliteration and consonance in its first two lines, which describe the appearance of the fog. Notice the repetition of /f/, /k/, and /t/ sounds: "fog"/"feet," "comes"/"cat," "little cat feet."

By creating a bit of noticeable music, alliteration emphasizes the approach of something worth paying attention to. It underscores the surprise of the fog's appearance, as well as the introduction of the poem's central, extended metaphor: the comparison between fog and cat. Those tripping /t/ sounds even sound a bit like the patter of "little cat feet"!

Sibilance: Sibilance is a type of literary device and figure of speech wherein a hissing sound is created in a group of words through the repetition of 's' sounds. With the use of words like 'sit', 'city', 'silent haunches' the poet has created a musical effect.

Extended Metaphor: The metaphor shows that fog can be compared to a cat in a multitude of ways including its attitude, sound, motion, position, and intention. By comparing fog to a cat, the author is able to show that fog acts aloof; it silently invades towns through a slinking motion; and that it ultimately creates a sense of mystery. The extended metaphor comparing the fog to a cat makes nature seem more mysterious and alive.

Themes

Urbanization, and the fragmented nature of contemporary life which are all present in Sandburg's depiction of the fog in the city. The poem "Fog" by Carl Sandburg has several themes, including:

The transitory nature of life: The fog is a metaphor for the fleeting and impermanent nature of human existence. It suggests that just as the fog rolls in and then dissipates so too do our lives pass by in a blur.

Isolation: The fog creates a sense of isolation and loneliness as it envelopes the city and makes it feel like it is cut off from the rest of the world.

The Mysteries of Existence: The fog also represents the mysteries of existence, and the things that are hidden from us or that we cannot fully understand. It creates a sense of intrigue and wonder as we try to make sense of the world around us.

Perception and Reality: The fog alters our perception of reality and creates an illusionary world where things appear different than they actually are. It motivates us to look beyond the surface of things and to discover hidden meanings and possibilities.

Time and Change: The fog is a symbol of change and impermanence. It comes and goes leaving behind a sense of transience and uncertainty. The poem suggests that we should embrace change and appreciate the fleeting moments of life.

Duality: The fog is both beautiful and frightening, both comforting and unsettling. It represents the dual nature of life which can be both joyful and painful.

Unpredictability: The fog is an unpredictable force that can roll in suddenly and without warning.

The transformative power of nature: The fog in the poem is depicted as a powerful force that transforms the landscape and changes the way people perceive the world around them. It creates an air of mystery and uncertainty blurring the boundaries between the familiar and the unknown.

The Mystery of Nature: “Fog” is a very short poem that vividly describes the appearance and disappearance of fog in an unnamed city. The speaker compares this fog to a cat that appears on “little cat feet,” “sits looking” over the city on its “silent haunches,” then finally “moves on” in the poem’s last line. It’s not entirely clear how the speaker feels about the fog, which could be seen as beautiful, ominous, or a simple fact of the weather in the moment being described. Regardless, by memorably expressing the hushed presence of the fog, the poem evokes the mystery and magic of nature as a whole. The speaker’s comparison of the fog to a cat indicates, from the start, that the poem isn’t just about fog. It’s also about nature in a larger sense, and the ways one aspect of the natural world (the fog covering a city) reminds the speaker of another (a cat). By comparing the fog, which isn’t alive, to a cat, which is, the speaker imbues the fog with a sense of life and agency, making the natural world seem more alert than people often think it is.

The speaker’s comparison makes sense on a number of levels. Both fog and cats are often silent; both are often quick to appear and disappear, as the fog does in the span of the poem’s six short lines. As the poet’s metaphor links the two, the fog seems to take on further cat-like qualities. Since cats are often intensely observant, independent, and aloof, the fog seems, in the poem, to possess those qualities as well. The comparison makes the fog, which readers might take for granted as an ordinary natural phenomenon, seem mysterious and unknowable. It also suggests a connection between the living and non-living features of the natural world, as well as nature’s mysterious power to make lasting impressions on the imagination. The metaphor may even invite readers to view the natural world as truly alive and observant, rather than as a passive, unremarkable part of daily life.

Finally, the poem’s comparison suggests the value of paying close attention to one’s surroundings, especially nature. The mysterious grandeur of the fog’s appearance and disappearance prompts the speaker to describe the moment in a vividly imaginative, metaphorical way. The memorable poem that results suggests the power of being immersed in, and open to, nature’s mysteries.

***The fog comes
on little cat feet***

The poem begins with the narrator stating that the fog arrives on little cat feet. Cats are often associated with lithe, quiet, and graceful movements. By comparing the fog to a cat, the narrator ascribes these characteristics to the fog as well. The narrator specifically states that the fog has “little cat feet”, which evokes the image of the agile way in which cats move.

***It sits looking
over harbor and city***

In the next lines, the narrator describes how the fog sits looking over the city. This once again adds characterization to the fog as a living entity. When fog forms over a location, it often lingers over

the landscape for a few hours. The narrator is pointing out that this natural phenomenon almost seems deliberate, as though the fog is actually watching over the city that it has settled over.

*on silent haunches
and then moves on*

In the last lines of the poem, the author once again characterizes the fog as a living creature. “Haunches” are the back leg area of an animal. Because the narrator had earlier stated that the fog comes in on “little cat feet”, we can infer that the “haunches” here refer specifically to those of a cat. This once again characterizes the fog as a feline-like entity. The word “silent” further emphasizes that it is quiet, lithe, and peaceful.

How do I love thee

Elizabeth Barrett Browning

Writer: Born in England, Elizabeth Barrett Browning was one of the most popular English poets of the Victorian era and Romantic Movement. Educated at home, Elizabeth apparently had read passages from John Milton’s *Paradise Lost* and a number of Shakespearean plays, among other great works, before the age of ten.

Writing style: Elizabeth Barrett Browning’s poetic form encompasses lyric, ballad and narrative, while engaging with historical events, religious belief and contemporary political opinion. Elizabeth is remembered for experimenting with both her style of writing and her subject matter. Political and social themes embody Elizabeth’s later work. In her poetry she also addressed the oppression of the Italians by the Austrians, the child labor mines and mills of England, and slavery, among other social injustices. Although this decreased her popularity, Elizabeth was heard and recognized around Europe. Some of her most famous works are

- How Do I Love Thee?
- Aurora Leigh
- A Musical Instrument
- The Cry of the Child
- Sonnets From the Portuguese

Elizabeth Barrett Browning was a prominent poet during the Victorian era, known for her innovative use of form and powerful emotional expression. Her writing style is characterized by its lyricism, depth of feeling, and intellectual complexity. She is also known for her use of classical and biblical references, as well as her experimentation with poetic form, including the sonnet and the dramatic monologue.

Browning's writing is notable for its vivid imagery and rich descriptive language. She frequently employs metaphor, simile, and other literary devices to convey her meaning and create a powerful emotional impact on the reader.

In addition to her poetry, Browning was also a prolific letter writer, and her correspondence provides further insight into her writing style and personality. Her letters are characterized by

their warmth, wit, and intellectual depth, as well as her penchant for philosophical discussion and literary criticism.

Overall, Elizabeth Barrett Browning's writing style is marked by its intellectual and emotional depth, its powerful imagery, and its innovative use of form and language. Her work remains a significant influence on modern poetry and continues to be celebrated for its beauty, complexity, and enduring relevance.

Summary: Sonnet 43 by Elizabeth Barrett Browning describes the love that speaker has for her husband. She describes her endless passion. It is easily one of the most famous and recognizable poems in the English language. In the poem, the speaker is proclaiming her unending passion for her beloved. She tells her lover just how deeply her love goes, and she also tells him how she loves him. She loves him with all of her beings, and she hopes God will grant her the ability to love him even after she has passed.

Background: Elizabeth Barrett Browning fell in love with Robert Browning after he reached out to her about her writing. The couple wrote letters back and forth to each other before finally marrying, knowing full well that the marriage would not be accepted by Barrett Browning's father. Their marriage was not only one filled with love but also respect for each other's writings. The two were each other's biggest supporters, and so it is no surprise that Barrett Browning would include this sonnet in her collection titled *Sonnets From the Portuguese*, so titled because Robert Browning often referred to his wife as his little Portuguese.

Structure and Form: 'Sonnet 43' is classified as a sonnet because it contains fourteen lines of poetry and has a fixed rhyme scheme of abba abba cd cd cd. This is the traditional pattern of a Petrarchan sonnet, one of the two major sonnet forms. (The other is the Shakespearean sonnet which rhymes ABABCDCEFEFGG). The poem also makes use of the usual metrical pattern associated with standard sonnet forms, that is, iambic pentameter. This means that each line contains five sets of two beats. The first of these is unstressed and the second is stressed.

Themes: Browning engages with themes of love/devotion and relationships in 'Sonnet 43'. From the first lines, it's clear that this is going to be a love poem. She addresses her listener, likely her husband Robert Browning, and tells him that there are many reasons why she loves him and that she's going to list them out. As the poem progresses the language becomes more figurative with the poet making various nature-based comparisons in order to depict her love accurately and movingly.

Death comes into the poem at the end as the speaker talks about the length and durability of their relationship. She hopes that God will allow her to love her partner even in death. It becomes clear at the end that her love is a spiritual one as much as it is a romantic one.

Speaker: One can assume, although it is not 100% certain, that Browning is also the speaker of the poem since it is well known just how deeply she and Robert Browning loved and cared for each other. The speaker is talking directly to her beloved in the sonnet; she uses personal pronouns such as "I" and "you."

Literary Devices

In 'Sonnet 43,' Browning makes use of several literary devices. These include but are not limited to imagery, simile, and alliteration.

Imagery: The first of these is one of the most impactful literary devices that a poet can use. It can be seen through the poet's ability to create images that appeal to or activate the reader's sense. These are things that can be seen, touched, heard, or smelt in one's mind. A good example comes from these lines "I love thee to the level of every day's / Most quiet need, by sun and candle-light".

Simile: There is a great example of a simile in this line: "I love thee freely, as men strive for right". here, she compares the amount that she loves her partner to the strength with which men "strive" for what is right, or just.

Alliteration: Alliteration is an effective device that's used to increase the overall rhythm and rhyme of a piece of poetry. For example, "purely" and "praise" in line eight.

Detailed Analysis

Based on the initial line, it appears that the speaker has been asked a question prior to reciting *Sonnet 43*. The first line also serves as the motivation for the rest of the work. She then uses the last thirteen lines of the poem to show just how much she loves her husband. Lines 2-4 of *Sonnet 43* provide the first way in which the speaker loves her husband. Barrett Browning writes,

*How do I love thee? Let me count the ways.
I love thee to the depth and breadth and height
My soul can reach, when feeling out of sight
For the ends of being and ideal grace.*

The poet presents a female speaker who presents her question that is rhetorical in nature. The question is how much she loves her lover and then asks the permission of her interlocutor saying "Let me count..." and goes on to enumerate the ways she loves her lover. The interlocutor happens to be the same lover. She tells him that she loves him from all corners of her soul. The breadth, depth, and height expand her being and soul has had to reach out to use the sensory experience to feel the presence of her love that she does and reaches the ideal grace (divine presence.) These verses contribute to the main idea of the extreme love of the speaker for her lover. Here she is describing that her love is as deep and wide and tall as it can possibly be. It is so deep and wide and tall, in fact, that she cannot even "see" the edges of it: it is infinite. Barrett Browning uses consonance in line two in order to convey just how much she loves her husband. The repetition of the "th" sound gives the line movement, which signifies that her love for him is ongoing.

*I love thee to the level of every day's
Most quiet need, by sun and candle-light.
I love thee freely, as men strive for right.*

I love thee purely, as they turn from praise.

The speaker continues enumerating the ways she loves her lover. In the first verse, she states that she loves like an **everyday requirement and the status of that requirement**. She continues loving him even by the sun or by the candlelight. These lines are particularly **lovely in their simplicity**. While her love knows no bounds, the speaker also **loves her beloved in ordinary, everyday life**. She **needs him as much as she needs other basic necessities of life**.

These lines of *Sonnet 43* give an innate sense of feeling to her love. **Just as men naturally strive to do what is good and right, she freely loves**. In addition, she loves him purely, just as men turn from praise in order to maintain humility. The speaker does not want thanks or attention for her love; just like good and just men, **she loves because it is what she has to do**. Using these two **similes** in these two lines strengthens the tone of love and adoration in the poem.

She has full freedom in her love and she works like men to struggle for their rights. Also, she claims that her love is pure and she is pure in her love like men praise others from their hearts. Again, the **verses continue to contribute to the extremity of her love and its expression through different metaphors and similes**.

***I love thee with the passion put to use
In my old griefs, and with my childhood's faith.***

***I love thee with a love I seemed to lose
With my lost saints. I love thee with the breath,***

***Smiles, tears, of all my life...and, if God choose,
I shall but love thee better after death.***

The sestet starts at line nine. The speaker now looks to the past and compares her newfound passions with those of the old griefs. Barrett Browning's diction here is interesting, particularly because she is taking the feelings, she has about **something relatively negative and comparing it to the feelings she has for her husband**. Old griefs can be defined as anything that a person passionately despises. She is telling her husband here that she has as much passion for him as she does for those things in life that she just cannot stand. She also loves him with the faith of a child, which is a particularly lovely line. **Children's faith is usually steadfast and true**. Just like a child has faith, so, too, does the speaker have love for her husband.

Her "lost saints" is a reference to all of those people **she once loved and adored in her life**. The love she once felt for them, that she eventually lost, has now been transferred into the love she feels for her husband. She also states that she loves her lost saints the most. However, she is **now losing that passion for love but she is using that in loving her lover**. These four verses contribute further to the main idea of the poem which is to love a lover to the extreme.

These last two verses state that the speaker uses every element of her body to love her lover. In fact, **her entire life revolves around this love**. That is why she says that if God is with her, she will continue loving her lover even after death. This post-death love, however, depends on the will of God, which seems something having **theological touch to this purely mundane love poem**. This is the final touch to the main idea of the extremity of the speaker's love.

Additionally, she loves him with all that she is: her breath, her smiles, and her tears. Barrett Browning confesses that **she loves her husband with all that has made up her life**. Barrett Browning ends her poem by acknowledging that she is willing to love her husband forever if God chooses to allow her to do so. She writes, not only will she love him well into eternity, she writes, but she will also love him even better than she does presently. Her love will continue to grow with the passing of time, regardless of whether or not she or he is still alive. The speaker's love for her husband is **so strong that not even death could destroy it**.

Lucy

William Wordsworth

Writer, Writing Style, Famous works: William Wordsworth was one of the **founders of English Romanticism** and one its most **central figures and important intellects**. He is remembered as a poet of spiritual and epistemological speculation, a poet concerned with the human relationship to nature and a fierce advocate of using the vocabulary and speech patterns of common people in poetry.

The poet Wordsworth has **two fundamental features**. These features are **clearly outlined in his preface to the second edition of *Lyrical Ballads***. The first and important feature is the **use of common language**, as Wordsworth says, *"the language really used by men."* The diction employed by Wordsworth in his poem resembles that of the rough, illiterate peasants and villagers whom Wordsworth admired a lot. Wordsworth poetry is **preoccupied with emotions**. This is the second most important characteristic of his poetry that he discussed in his preface to the second edition of *Lyrical Ballads*. According to Wordsworth, poetry is *"Spontaneous overflow of powerful feelings and emotions, recollected in tranquility."* According to him, the job of a poet is to examine his own self to recollect the powerful feelings of his life. These recollections include inspirational thoughts and events in his life that have greatly influenced him. Once these emotions are recollected, he then reorganizes them. **The recollection of emotions is the most observable feature of the poetry of Wordsworth**. His poetry is a result of the ordinary but moving thought.

Most famous works of a Wordsworth include;

- 'I wandered lonely as a cloud'
- 'From The Prelude'
- 'Ode: Intimations of Immortality'

- 'The Solitary Reaper' and many more

Reason for writing: Wordsworth's works of poetry are filled with themes of death. Sometimes, he finds comfort in thoughts of the afterlife. Other times, he despairs. Throughout his poetry, the name Lucy **nearly always refers to one he loved and lost.** Sometimes, Lucy symbolizes a lover, and other times she symbolizes the pure and innocent love a father has for his daughter. Many critics have argued over the identity of Lucy, but most have concluded that **she does not represent one single person.** Rather, she is a character comprised of all the people that Wordsworth ever loved and lost.

Rhyme Scheme: It is noted that the rhyming sounds change each stanza. Because the poem is short, its scheme can be fully represented here: ABAB CDCD EFEF

Poetic Devices

Allusion: The poem contains two allusions. **The first explicitly alludes to a place, the Dove River in England.** The Dove River is a waterway in the English Midlands that rises on Axe Edge Moor and flows 45 miles south before joining the Trent River. It's about 30 miles south of Manchester. Line 2's allusion to Dove grounds the speaker's memory of Lucy in reality. **The second implicitly refers to Venus, the Roman goddess of love, beauty, fertility, and sex** and appears in lines 7 and 8, when the speaker mentions the first star in the sky. It should first be noted that this star isn't necessarily Venus. Venus would only have been the first "star" in the sky if its orbit had been such that it appeared above the horizon from the speaker's point of view at evening. **However, Venus is probably the most famous of celestial objects that sometimes appear first in the sky,** so it's reasonable to assume that Wordsworth had it in mind. If the star is in fact a reference to Venus, it emphasizes Lucy's beauty and the speaker's love for her, and hints at a subtler dynamic in their relationship.

Metaphor: Lucy was like *"A violet by a mossy stone / Half hidden from the eye!"* Because of Lucy's isolation, her beauty and virtue would only reveal themselves under close attention; she was like a **subtle flower in the shadow of an obvious rock.** Here again, the speaker implies his or her love for Lucy.

Simile: *'Fair as a star'* this simile is being used in the poem to describe the beauty of Lucy. The speaker describes the star of the poem as **"Fair," which in its archaic sense means beautiful.** At least in part, the star's fairness derives from its isolation; it is beautiful because it is the "only one" in the sky.

Polyptoton: Stanza 3 begins with the use of polyptoton, where the speaker uses 2 words of same root within the same line. Lucy lived unknown, not many knew about her whereabouts and she lived in isolation like a star, but when she ceased to exist and no longer remained people knew about her and that was all because of the speaker, Lucy meant a lot to him and when she wasn't there anymore part of him left too.

Parallelism: Parallelism refers to using similar words, clauses, phrases, sentence structure, or other grammatical elements to emphasize similar ideas in a sentence. In this particular poem, parallelism is being used in stanza 1 and 2, "A Maid whom there were none to praise, And very few to love, A violet by a mossy stone Half hidden from the eye!". The lines are very self-explanatory, Lucy was like a maid who wasn't known by many and not many were around her to praise and consequently very few to love her but regardless of all of this she was like a violet, symbolizing humility and modesty, growing around a mossy stone, the world, hidden from the eye, living in isolation and enjoying herself on her own.

Themes

Death: Given Wordsworth's "She Dwelt Among the Untrodden Ways" is an elegy, an obvious theme of the poem is death. The deceased is **described, appreciated, and mourned** throughout its entirety.

Loneliness: Another stand out theme is loneliness. There was great loneliness in the life of Lucy and there is loneliness in the speaker's life. This is displayed right down to her dwelling place, somewhere far removed from most people. The reader can feel this theme in the **description of Lucy's life and lack of admirers**. It is also felt through the sorrow and lamentation of the speaker.

Virtue and Appreciation: In "She Dwelt among the Untrodden Ways," an unidentified speaker mourns Lucy, a beautiful woman who died young and underappreciated in the English countryside. For the speaker, **Lucy's beauty was an aspect of her overall virtue, a quiet, mysterious quality she had in spite of the fact that, as the speaker says, "She lived unknown."** In a world that for the most part couldn't have cared less about Lucy, the speaker loved her; the speaker insists that she mattered in life, and still matters in death. The poem, then, suggests that virtue like Lucy's can have a lasting emotional impact **even if its audience is thin, and that appreciating it is therefore worthwhile**. The first stanza establishes that Lucy was worthy of love and praise despite her anonymity. The poem's title and opening line—"She dwelt among the untrodden ways"—**set up a context of anonymity and remoteness**. Lucy's "ways," or the place she lived, were "untrodden," meaning very few people walked over them. And she "dwelt" there, implying **she rarely left her base**. As a result, her chances of encountering other people were slim. This is why "there were none to praise" and "very few to love" her. By noting that no one praised Lucy, the speaker implies she was worthy of praise, and therefore that it's a shame she didn't get the recognition she deserved. The question of love is only slightly different: Lucy didn't go totally unloved, but only "very few" loved her. The speaker, who laments how seriously underappreciated Lucy was in life, implies that the speaker was one of the few to take due notice of Lucy.

In the rest of the poem, the speaker will argue that even though it affected few people, Lucy's virtue had serious value. The speaker goes on to show how her virtue persisted despite having no audience. Lucy was like "A violet by a mossy stone / Half hidden from the eye!" Because of

Lucy's isolation, her beauty and virtue would only reveal themselves under close attention; she was like a subtle flower in the shadow of an obvious rock. Here again, the speaker implies his or her love for Lucy. There was pleasure in attempting to grasp Lucy's virtue, perhaps because it was essentially ungraspable, or "Half hidden." Finding it—or nearly finding it—required serious work. Lucy was also as "Fair" as the first star in the evening sky. Like the star (probably an allusion to the goddess Venus, who represents beauty, love, and sex), Lucy is fair, or beautiful, because she is isolated, and therefore unique. She shines when no one else is able to, suggesting a special power. And even as she went unnoticed, she kept "shining." The speaker, by drawing attention to these aspects of Lucy's virtue—her modest beauty, her mysteriousness, her consistent shining despite having no audience—claims that her virtue was powerful and good, and ultimately unforgettable.

In stanza 3 the speaker says again how seriously under-appreciated Lucy was in life. Though part lament, the observation serves more to emphasize the speaker's final affirmation of Lucy's lasting impact. Lucy "lived unknown." Here, the speaker deepens the claim from stanza 1. Not only did Lucy go through life unpraised and pretty much unloved—she "lived unknown," the result of which was that few people noticed her death. By emphasizing this point, the speaker seems to consider a counterargument: maybe, if Lucy was so unknown, her virtue didn't matter after all. Quickly, however, the speaker refutes this idea. Lucy made a "difference." The poem's final line is an exclamatory, and therefore confident, affirmation of Lucy's value. And this is at the moment when she's most isolated: she's not just "Half hidden," but "in her grave," sealed up in the earth. Lucy's virtue is not ultimately worthless, says the speaker. It was enough to make a difference for him or her, and because of that Lucy's memory—and perhaps, in a way, her virtue itself—survives.

Love and Mystery: The poem provides few details about the living situation of its subject, a beautiful woman named Lucy who died young in the English countryside, but it makes clear that she lived in isolation. For that reason, not many people knew her, and far fewer loved her. As one of the "few" who did, however, the speaker reflects upon his or her love for Lucy, lingering over her remote, mysterious qualities; for him or her, this mystery was, and still is, the source of Lucy's loveliness. Love, the poem suggests, is enhanced by this sort of incomplete knowledge of its subject. In stanza 1, the speaker presents Lucy as a somewhat mysterious figure. Lucy "dwelt among untrodden ways." Dwell, which basically means to stay in one place, is a vague word. It doesn't describe how Lucy actually spent her time, but simply proves that she existed and didn't venture far from home. "Untrodden," which means unexplored, enhances the vagueness of Lucy's situation. These words dress Lucy in an aura of mystery. The speaker is obviously captivated by Lucy (otherwise the poem wouldn't be about her), but doesn't explain why, at least not in detail. In stanza 2, the speaker points to Lucy's mystery as the reason for her loveliness and beauty. She was like "A violet by a mossy stone / Half hidden from the eye!" By comparing Lucy to a flower, the speaker implies she was beautiful. So, one reason for his or her love was Lucy's beauty. But the image gets more detailed: Lucy was like a flower that was "Half hidden."

The exclamation mark that ends the line ("from the eye!") conveys the speaker's wonder and excitement. There was something hidden about Lucy, a quality that never waned and always deepened the speaker's infatuation. Though dead, Lucy's inherent mystery—something about her the speaker just couldn't pin down—survives and continues to inspire love. In the poem's final line, the speaker reiterates through implication the difficulty of expressing this quality. Exactly how she made her impact, the speaker can't say. All the speaker knows is that Lucy made a "difference," a word as open to interpretation as Lucy was.

*She dwelt among the untrodden ways
Beside the springs of Dove,
A Maid whom there were none to praise
And very few to love:*

From the first line of the poem, the subject is established. This poem is about a woman, though it is unclear at this point if her identity will be specified. The first line states the woman lives on a path, or in a place, not often visited. Wherever her remote location, it is near the springs of a place named Dove. The speaker claims the woman dwells on "the untrodden ways." This may also intimate she not often opts for something less conventional. She, perhaps, spends her time thinking differently than others and her actions reflect it. What is also striking about the first line is that the woman is no longer around. Whether she is simply no longer part of the speaker's life or passed away remains to be seen.

Given the time in which the poem was written, it is likely the woman was unwed due to the use of the word "Maid." Sadly, it seems this woman did not receive praise or affection from many during her life. The delicate lines of the poem suggest the woman did not necessarily deserve to be rebuffed. This could have simply been an unfortunate circumstance for the young lady or a result of her remote location. Her location also plays a role in demonstrating her lone life.

*A violet by a mossy stone
Half hidden from the eye!
—Fair as a star, when only one
Is shining in the sky.*

These two lines continue the soft manner and flow. The softness connects to the description of the young lady. Though the speaker seems to think she is easy on the eyes, it is also insinuated she goes largely unnoticed. It is possible her beauty is of the simpler kind. This idea is also in keeping with the previous lines in which the reader learns she lacked praise and love from others. In addition, her seclusion is made clear once again with the description of the "mossy stone" and it (or her) being "half hidden."

The notion the speaker found the woman described in the poem to be pretty is demonstrated by the use of the word "fair." Furthermore, this is shown through her being compared to a star. A star is bright and has long been of intrigue to mankind. Though others may not have noticed her, the speaker noticed her brilliance. Yet again, the speaker highlights her isolation from people.

Not only is her dwelling place remote, she is remote. **She is vibrant, unique, but alone.** She is concealed but, somehow, manages to stand out to the speaker. The reader can sense true affection.

***She lived unknown, and few could know
When Lucy ceased to be;
But she is in her grave, and, oh,
The difference to me!***

Though it was suggested earlier when the speaker referred to the woman in the past tense, it is not until the final quatrain the reader learns **the woman has passed away**. It is also in the final quatrain of the poem that the reader learns the young lady's name: **Lucy. She ceases to be a nameless object of affection and materializes** into a person the reader may mourn for, alongside the speaker.

Once again, the reader is struck by the woman's isolation. Her physical location, her dwelling place, **is a reflection of her detachment from the world in spirit.** She did not receive attention from many while alive. As a result, not many knew of or were affected by her passing.

If the reader had not been clued in to the importance this woman had to the speaker, the final line is definitive. It shows **how much Lucy was noticed and appreciated by the speaker**, despite that not being the case with the majority of people surrounding her. She is now separated in location and spirit from the living world, even more so than she was in life. There is no clearer picture of her desolation than being buried, marked by the words, "she is in her grave."